HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

PATROLOGY IV

PATROLOGY OF ETHIOPIAN FATHERS

Prepared By Mhr. Behailu Bekele

2025

HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

Addis Ababa, Ethiopia

General Introduction to the Module

This module invites students into the profound and often under-explored world of Ethiopian Patrology, a field rich in theological depth, historical significance, and unique cultural expression. It is an invitation to journey through nearly two millennia of continuous Christian thought and spiritual life, as articulated, defended, and lived out by the venerable Fathers (*ʾAbatočč*, **አባቶች**) of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church **የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**. Our purpose is not merely to survey historical figures and texts in an abstract manner, but to engage with a living tradition (*ḥəyaw təwəfit*, **ሕያው ትውፊት**) that has been consistently shaped by the "lives" (*ḥəywät*, **ሕይወት**) and "works" (*śəraḥočč*, **ሥራዎች**) of these holy men and women of God.

Through their inspired teachings, their pastoral care, their literary endeavors, and often their profound suffering for the faith, these Fathers have molded a nation's identity and offered a distinct, powerful witness to the Gospel from an ancient and African perspective. This module particularly embraces a decolonizing lens. As scholars like Paulau & Tamcke (2022) observe, the grand narrative of Christian history has often been Eurocentric, marginalizing ancient non-Western Christian traditions like Ethiopia's Miaphysite heritage (a Christology emphasizing the one united divine-human nature of Christ, distinct from Chalcedonian dyophysitism), a heritage championed and meticulously articulated in the "works" of countless Ethiopian Fathers. This course actively seeks to counter such biases by centering the indigenous voices and theological contributions of the Ethiopian *ʾAbatočč*.

The scope of this course encompasses a chronological and thematic exploration of Ethiopian patristic thought, examining the "lives and works" of its key proponents.

Chapter One lays the foundational understanding of Ethiopian Patrology; defining its scope, the criteria for recognizing the Church Fathers (Yäʾityoṗṗəya ʾAbatočč, **የኢትዮጵያ አባቶች**), and tracing the Church's apostolic roots (*zämänä hawaryat*, **ዘመነ ሐዋርያት**).

Chapter Two investigates into the Aksumite patristic foundations, focusing on the seminal "works" of Fathers such as St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama, **አባ ሰላማ**) and the Nine Saints (*Täsʿatu Qəddusan*, **ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**), whose efforts established the Church and its early literary traditions in *Gəʿəz* (**ግዕዝ**).

In **Chapter Three**, we explore the flourishing of early indigenous voices, particularly the creative brilliance evident in the liturgical and theological "works" of St. Yared (*Qəddus Yared*, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**) with his *Zema* (**ዜማ**), and consider the patristic expressions of the Zagwe era, exemplified by St. Lalibäla (Qəddus Lalibäla, **ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**).

The journey continues in **Chapter Four** with an examination of the monastic theologians and literary maturation during the early Solomonic period, highlighting the "lives and works" of pivotal figures like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), and the crucial translation "work" of Abba Sälama "the Translator" (*Sälama Mätərgʷəm*, **ሰላማ መተርጉም**).

Chapter Five investigates the climax of medieval Ethiopian patristics, showcasing the systematizing genius found in the rich theological "works" of Fathers such as Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**) and the theologian-ruler Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**).

Chapter Six explores the resilient apologetic "works" of 16th-century Fathers, including Ǝčča̱ge Ǝnbaqom (**እጨጌ ዕንባቆም**) and Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዴዎስ**), who navigated periods of profound existential crisis and defended the faith against external threats.

Chapter Seven delves into the intense internal theological debates of the Gondarine period, often termed "Ethiopian Heresies." It examines the Christological controversies surrounding *Qəbʿat* (**ቅብዐት**) and *Ṣägga* (**ጸጋ**), and the "lives and works" of Fathers like Ǝčča̱ge Beträ Giyorgis (**እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ**) (in his defense of *Täwaḥədo* against earlier Jesuit challenges) and the great scholar Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**) who refined the *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**) tradition amidst these disputes.

Chapter Eight details the imperial "works" towards doctrinal unification and patristic standardization in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, focusing on the Councils of Amba Čara and Boru Meda, and the contributions of scholars like Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) and Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**).

Chapter Nine then offers a thematic exploration of how Ethiopian Fathers defined Orthodoxy against various internal theological challenges and "heresies" (*mənfəqəna*, **ምንፍቅና**) throughout different historical periods. This chapter will revisit and synthesize the Church's engagement with movements such as the Estifanosites and Ewostatewosites, and the theological deviations addressed by Fathers like Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.

Finally, **Chapter Ten** brings us to the modern era, discussing the monumental journey to autocephaly (*rasəwan yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan*, **ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን**), the impact of the Italian Occupation, the "work" of influential 20th-century Fathers like Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**), Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**), and Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**), and the Church's contemporary patristic engagement in a globalized world, considering challenges like the diaspora (*səḍtät*, **ስደት**) and the 1974 Revolution (*ʾabyot*, **አብዮት**).

A central methodological commitment of this module is to approach Ethiopian Patrology from a decolonizing perspective, focusing on the "lives and works" of its indigenous teachers. For too long, as scholars like Paulau & Tamcke (2022) have observed, the grand narrative of Christian history has been predominantly Eurocentric, often marginalizing or misinterpreting ancient non-Western Christian traditions. This course actively seeks to counter such biases by centering indigenous Ethiopian voices, their interpretive methods like the *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**)—itself a collective "work" of generations of teaching Fathers—and the inherent theological value of a tradition whose Fathers always understood themselves as direct inheritors of biblical and apostolic faith. We will highlight the sophisticated intellectual heritage preserved in *Gəʿəz* (**ግዕዝ**) literature, the sacred language through which these Fathers produced their enduring "works," and the unique ways in which they grappled with universal Christian doctrines, articulating them within their specific cultural and historical milieu.

Students engaging with this module will develop a nuanced understanding of:

- The criteria for recognizing "Church Fathers" within the Ethiopian Orthodox tradition, based on their "lives and works."
- The key literary genres and theological themes that characterize the patristic "works" of Ethiopian writers.
- The "lives and seminal works" of major Ethiopian Fathers across different historical periods.
- The development of distinctively Ethiopian hermeneutical approaches, such as the *Andəmta*, as practiced and refined by generations of teaching Fathers.
- The interplay between theological development as seen in the "works" of the Fathers, political history, and cultural expression in Ethiopia.

- The contemporary relevance and enduring vitality of the Ethiopian patristic heritage, as it continues to inspire the "lives and works" of the Church today.

Ultimately, this module aims to equip students with a deeper appreciation for the richness and complexity of Ethiopian Orthodox Christianity by focusing on the "lives and works" of its Fathers. It seeks to foster a more inclusive and globally aware understanding of Patrology. It is an invitation to listen to ancient voices whose wisdom, enshrined in their "works" and exemplified in their "lives," continues to resonate, offering profound insights not only into the Ethiopian Christian experience but into the universal quest for faith, truth, and spiritual understanding. The journey through Ethiopian Patrology is a journey into the heart of one of the world's oldest and most resilient Christian civilizations, a testament to the enduring power of indigenous faith and the scholarly "works" of its devoted Fathers.

Mämhər Behailu Bekele

Course Outline

University Name: HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

Course Name PATROLOGY IV: PATROLOGY OF ETHIOPIAN FATHERS

Name of the Instructor:

Course Code

Course Description

This course, drawing significantly from the foundational module prepared by Mhr. Behailu Bekele, invites students into the profound and often under-explored world of Ethiopian Patrology; a field rich in theological depth, historical significance, and unique cultural expression. We will journey through nearly two millennia of continuous Christian thought and spiritual life, as articulated, defended, and lived out by the venerable Fathers (*ʾAbatočč*, **አባቶች**) of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (**የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**). Our purpose isn't just to survey historical figures and texts abstractly but to engage with a living tradition (*ḥəyaw təwəfit*, **ሕያው ትውፊት**) shaped by the "lives" (*ḥəywät*, **ሕይወት**) and "works" (*śəraḥočč*, **ሥራዎች**) of these holy men and women. The module, and thus this course, embraces a decolonizing lens, countering Eurocentric biases by centering the indigenous voices and theological contributions of the Ethiopian *ʾAbatočč*. We'll explore how these Fathers, through their teachings, literary endeavors, and often profound suffering for the faith, have molded a nation's identity and offered a distinct, powerful witness to the Gospel from an ancient African perspective. This really is about understanding our own heritage on its own terms.

Pre-requisite Course

Successful completion of earlier Patrology courses (Patrology I-III) or a strong foundational knowledge of general Christian history and theology would be ideal. A basic understanding of Ethiopian history could also be very helpful. But truly, a keen interest in the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church's heritage is the main thing.

Objectives of the Course

Upon successful completion of this course, drawing from the module's stated aims, students should be able to;

- Understand the criteria for recognizing "Church Fathers" within the Ethiopian Orthodox tradition, based on their "lives and works."
- Identify the key literary genres and theological themes that characterize the patristic "works" of Ethiopian writers.
- Detail the "lives and seminal works" of major Ethiopian Fathers across different historical periods as outlined in the module.
- Explain the development of distinctively Ethiopian hermeneutical approaches, such as the *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**), as practiced and refined by generations of teaching Fathers.
- Analyze the interplay between theological development as seen in the "works" of the Fathers, political history, and cultural expression in Ethiopia.
- Appreciate the contemporary relevance and enduring vitality of the Ethiopian patristic heritage, as it continues to inspire the "lives and works" of the Church today.
- Articulate how Ethiopian Patrology offers a decolonizing perspective, valuing indigenous knowledge (*ṭəbäb*, **ጥበብ**) and providing a counter-narrative to Eurocentric Church history.

Course Breakdown (16 Weeks)

- **Week 1: Module Introduction and Foundations of Ethiopian Patrology (Chapter 1)**
  - Introduction to the module's scope and decolonizing approach.
  - Defining Ethiopian Patrology; scope and significance of "Ethiopia" (*ʾItyoppəya*, **ኢትዮጵያ**).
  - Criteria for recognizing *Yäʾityoppəya ʾAbatočč* (**የኢትዮጵያ አባቶች**); their lives and works.
  - The Church's apostolic foundations (*zämänä hawaryat*, **ዘመነ ሐዋርያት**) as understood by the Fathers.
- **Week 2: Foundations (Cont.) & Aksumite Patristic Foundations (Chapter 1 & 2)**
  - Primary literary genres of the Fathers; overview of the developmental route of Ethiopian patristic thought.
  - St. Frumentius (*Abba Sälama*, **አባ ሰላማ**); his life, episcopal "work", and Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) translations.
  - The Nine Saints (*Täsᶜatu Qəddusan*, **ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**); their monastic "work", Gəᶜəz translations, and consolidation of Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) theology.
- **Week 3: Early Indigenous Patristic Voices (Chapter 3)**
  - The life and divinely inspired literary and liturgical "works" of Saint Yared (*Qəddus Yared*, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**).
  - His *Zema* (**ዜማ**) as liturgical theology; Christology (**ነገረ ክርስቶስ**) and Soteriology in his hymns.
  - Patristic themes in the Zagwe era; St. Lalibäla's (**ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**) rock-hewn churches as theological "works".
- **Week 4: Monastic Theologians and Literature (Chapter 4)**
  - Patristic renewal in the early Solomonic period; the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**).
  - Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and Däbrä Hayq (**ደብረ ሃይቅ**).
  - Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) and Däbrä Libanos (**ደብረ ሊባኖስ**).

    - Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) and his Sabbath advocacy.
- **Week 5: Maturing Gəʿəz Literature & Climax of Medieval Patristics (Chapter 4 & 5 Intro)**
    - The literary "work" of Abba Sälama "the Translator" (*Sälama Mätərgʷəm*, **ሰላማ መተርጉም**).
    - The *Rətuʿa Haymanot* (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**) compendium.
    - Introduction to the climax of medieval patristics; synergy of monastic and imperial "works".
- **Week 6: Climax of Medieval Patristics; Abba Giyorgis (Chapter 5)**
    - Life, intellectual formation, and "works" of Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**).
    - Focus on *Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir* (**መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**) and *Arganonä Maryam* (**አርጋኖነ ማርያም**). His enduring stature.
- **Week 7: Climax of Medieval Patristics; Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob & Andəmta (Chapter 5)**
    - Patristic "works" and theological vision of Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**); e.g., *Mäṣḥafä Bərhan* (**መጽሐፈ ብርሃን**).
    - Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (**ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**).
    - The *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**) tradition; its history, methodology, and role.
    - Other literary forms; *Maḥəletä Ṣəge* (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ**), *Mälkəʾ* (**መልክዕ**).
- **Week 8: Midterm Review and Examination**
    - Review of key Fathers, texts, and theological developments from Weeks 1-7.
    - Midterm Examination. It's a good point to pause and consolidate.
- **Week 9: Ethiopian Patristic Voices in 16th C. Compositions (Chapter 6)**
    - Context of crisis; Ahmad Grañ's wars and Jesuit missionaries.
    - Ǝčča Ǝnbaqom (**እጨጌ ዕንባቆም**); his life and the *Anqäṣä Amin* (**አንቀጸ አሚን**).
    - Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዴዎስ**); his life and the *Ṭomarä Gälawdewos* (**ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ**).
    - Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**); his chronicles and poetic "works" like *Mäzmurä Krəstos* (**መዝሙረ ክርስቶስ**).
- **Week 10: Christological Debates in Gondarine Period (Chapter 7 Part 1)**

- Introduction to "heresy" (*mənfəqəna*, **ምንፍቅና**) within internal discourse.
- 17th C. debates with Portuguese Jesuits; defense of Täwaḥədo by Fathers like Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis (**እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ**). His life and "work."

- **Week 11: Gondarine Debates & Scholarship (Chapter 7 Part 2)**
  - Internal Christological schools; Qəbᶜat (**ቅብዐት**) and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (**ጸጋ/ሦስት ልደት**).
  - Life and "work" of Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**); his revision of the *Andəmta* and the Yä-Lay Bet/Yä-Tačč Bet (**የላይ ቤት/የታች ቤት**) distinctions.
  - Politicization of doctrinal differences.
- **Week 12: Fathers at the Beginning of Modernity (Chapter 8)**
  - Quest for unity post-Gondarine era; imperial agendas of Tewodros II, Yohannes IV, Menelik II.
  - Council of Amba Čara (**አምባ ጭራ**) and Council of Boru Meda (**ጉባኤ ቦሩ ሜዳ**).
  - Life and contribution of Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**).
  - Theological interpretations of national events e.g., Battle of Adwa (**ጦርነት ዓድዋ**).
- **Week 13: Engaging "Heresies" Thematically & Transmitting Heritage (Chapter 9 & 8 cont.)**
  - Revisiting early challenges; Arianism, Estifanosites, Ewostatewosites, Zamika'elites.
  - How Fathers defined Orthodoxy (*Rətuᶜa Haymanot*, **ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**).
  - Life and scholarly "work" of Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**) in transmitting the patristic heritage.
- **Week 14: Autocephaly and Living Patristic Tradition (Chapter 10 Part 1)**
  - Emperor Haile Selassie I's (**ቀዳማዊ ኃይለ ሥላሴ**) patristic vision and contributions.
  - Italian Occupation; martyrdom of Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**) as patristic witness.
  - The journey to autocephaly (*rasəwan yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan*, **ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን**); life of Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**).
  - Engagement with Oriental Orthodox Communion; 1965 Addis Ababa Conference.

- **Week 15: 20th Century Fathers & Contemporary Engagement (Chapter 10 Part 2)**
    - Modern theological scholarship; contributions of Fathers like Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**), Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**), and Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**).
    - Role of Holy Trinity Theological College.
    - Contemporary challenges; 1974 Revolution (*ʾabyot*, **አብዮት**), diaspora (*səḏtät*, **ስደት**).
- **Week 16: Course Review, Student Presentations/Final Discussion**
    - Synthesis of major themes, figures, and "works" of the Ethiopian Fathers.
    - Student presentations on selected research topics.
    - Discussion on the enduring vitality and contemporary relevance of Ethiopian Patrology. This is where we bring it all home.

Evaluation

- **Class Participation & Engagement;** 20% (Active discussion, informed by readings, is essential you know).
- **Short Analytical Papers (2-3 papers, 3-4 pages each);** 30% (Focusing on the "lives and works" of specific Fathers or themes from the module).
- **Midterm Examination;** 20% (Covering material from Weeks 1-7).
- **Final Research Paper (10-15 pages);** 30% (On an approved topic related to Ethiopian Patrology, demonstrating engagement with the module's content and a decolonizing perspective. Students should strive for proper citation, APA style is recommended for their formal written work).

Plagiarism Statement

All submitted work must be the student's own original thought and writing. Presenting another person's ideas or words as your own, without proper attribution, constitutes plagiarism. This is a serious academic offense and will result in a failing grade for the assignment and possibly the course. We are studying a tradition where careful transmission (*təwəfit*) and respect for intellectual *śəraḥoccč* (works) are paramount; academic integrity honors this spirit. If you are unsure about citation, please ask.

Main Text(s)

- The primary text for this course will be the module: **PATROLOGY IV: PATROLOGY OF ETHIOPIAN FATHERS**, prepared by Mhr. Behailu Bekele.
- Selected readings from primary sources in translation (e.g., excerpts from *Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir*, *Ṭomarä Gälawdewos*, etc.) and relevant scholarly articles will be provided by the instructor.

Some Key Reference Books

- Binns, J. (2017). *The Orthodox Church of Ethiopia; A history*. I.B. Tauris.
- Cowley, R. W. (1988). *Ethiopian biblical interpretation; A study in exegetical tradition and hermeneutics*. Cambridge University Press.
- Gebru, M. K. (PhD) (2009). *Miaphysite Christology; An Ethiopian perspective*. Gorgias Press. (This seems particularly relevant for Chapter 7).
- Getatchew Haile. Various entries in *The Coptic Encyclopedia* and other scholarly works. (His contributions are foundational).
- Kəfle, K. W. (1956). ***መጽሐፈ ሰዋስው ወግስ ወመዝገበ ቃላት ሐዲስ*** *(Mäṣḥafä säwasəw wägəss wämäzgäbä qalat ḥaddis)* (D. Täklä-Wald, Ed.). Artistic Printing Press. (The KWKDic is essential for Gəᶜəz studies).

- Kəfyaläw Məraḥi. (2004 E.C. [2011/2012 G.C.]). ***ዝክረ ሊቃውንት ካልዕ*** *(Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə)* [Memorial of the Scholars, Vol. 2]. **ንግድ ማተሚያ ድርጅት** (Nəgd Matämiy̆a Dərəğğət).
- Paulau, S., & Tamcke, M. (Eds.). (2022). *Ethiopian Orthodox Christianity in a global context; Entanglements and disconnections*. BRILL. (Good for the decolonizing frame).
- Sergew Hable Sellassie. (1972). *Ancient and Medieval Ethiopian History to 1270*. United Printers.
- Taddesse Tamrat. (1972). *Church and state in Ethiopia, 1270-1527*. Clarendon Press.

List of Acronyms

- **CE:** Coptic Encyclopedia
- **CSCO:** Corpus Scriptorum Christianorum Orientalium
- **DACB:** Dictionary of African Christian Biography
- **EAE:** Encyclopaedia Aethiopica
- **E.C.:** Ethiopian Calendar
- **EMML:** Ethiopian Manuscript Microfilm Library
- **EOTC:** Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church
- **G.C.:** Gregorian Calendar
- **KWKDic:** Kidanä Wäld Kəfle Dictionary

Key to Amharic and Geez transliteration

Table 1 transilitation

ሀ (hä)	ቸ (čä)	የ (yä)
ለ (lä)	ጎ (ḫä)	ደ (dä)
ሐ (ḥä)	ነ (nä)	ጀ (ǧä)
መ (mä)	ኘ (ñä)	ገ (gä)
ሠ (śä)	አ (ʾä)	ጠ (ṭä)
ረ (rä)	ከ (kä)	ጨ (č̣ä)
ሰ (sä)	ኸ (ḳ̲ä)	ጰ (p̣ä)
ሸ (šä)	ወ (wä)	ጸ (ṣä)
ቀ (ḳä)	ዐ (ʿä)	ፀ (ṣ́ä)
በ (bä)	ዘ (zä) / ዠ (žä)	ፈ (fä)
ተ (tä)		ፐ (pä)

This key follows the transliteration system used by the Encyclopaedia Aethiopica

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Chapter One

1 Foundations of Ethiopian Patrology

Chapter Objectives

- To introduce the discipline of Patrology by focusing on its specific application within the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (EOTC) as the study of the lives, teachings, and enduring literary contributions of its recognized Church Fathers (Yäʾityoṗṗəya ʾAbatočč, **የኢትዮጵያ አባቶች**).
- To explore the profound significance of the name "Ethiopia" (ʾItyoṗṗəya, **ኢትዮጵያ**) and its biblical connections (e.g., Kuš, **ኩሽ**) in shaping the patristic consciousness and self-understanding of these venerated figures.
- To delineate the EOTC's organic, Spirit-guided criteria for recognizing its Fathers, emphasizing their orthodox faith (rətuᶜ haymanot, **ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት**), holy lives (**ቅድስና ሕይወት**), significant literary and theological legacies, and enduring ecclesiastical reception within the living tradition (**ሕያው ትውፊት**).
- To firmly establish how the EOTC Fathers consistently understood and articulated the Church's direct apostolic foundations as central to her own identity and theological endeavors.
- To provide an overview of the primary literary genres through which the Ethiopian Fathers expressed their theological insights and pastoral concerns, noting the unique characteristics of their Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) corpus.
- To outline the developmental trajectory of patristic thought in Ethiopia as evidenced by the succession of these teachers and their contributions across distinct historical periods.
- To frame the study of these Ethiopian patristic figures and their legacies within a decolonizing perspective, valuing their indigenous knowledge (ṭəbäb, **ጥበብ**) and their unique contributions as a counter-narrative to Eurocentric Church history.

This chapter, and indeed this entire module, embarks on a foundational exploration into the profound and often under-explored world of Ethiopian Patrology. It is an invitation to journey through nearly two millennia of continuous Christian thought and spiritual life, as articulated, defended, and lived out by the venerable Fathers of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (**የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**). Our purpose is not merely to survey historical figures and their texts in an abstract manner, but to engage deeply with a living tradition that has been consistently shaped by the spiritual journeys and influential legacies of these holy men. Through their inspired teachings, their pastoral care, their literary endeavors, and often their profound suffering for the faith, these patristic authorities have molded a nation's identity and offered a distinct, powerful witness to the Gospel from an ancient and African perspective.

This study particularly embraces a decolonizing lens. As scholars like Paulau & Tamcke (2022, p. 1) observe, the grand narrative of Christian history has often been Eurocentric, marginalizing ancient non-Western Christian traditions like Ethiopia's Miaphysite heritage—a Christology emphasizing the one united divine-human nature of Christ, distinct from Chalcedonian dyophysitism, which was championed and defended by generations of Ethiopian Fathers. This course actively seeks to counter such biases by centering the indigenous voices, the lived experiences, and the theological contributions of the Ethiopian ʾAbatočč.

Engaging with the profound depths of Ethiopian Patrology, understood as the study of the lives and literary output of these Fathers, is not merely an academic diversion; it constitutes an indispensable pilgrimage for understanding Christian history comprehensively. Prevailing narratives have often marginalized traditions outside the Roman and Byzantine spheres (Paulau & Tamcke, 2022, p. 1). The legacy of the Ethiopian Fathers proffers a vital counter-narrative, offering a luminous portal into an ancient, dynamic tradition that, as these scholars (Paulau & Tamcke, 2022, p. 2) further observe, has "so far received relatively little attention in Western scholarship." Our Church's distinctive characteristics, including its uniquely broad biblical canon and practices sometimes labeled "Jewish" such as the observance of Sänbät (**ሰንበት**, Sabbath)—practices defended and contextualized by our patristic guides—are often too cursorily attributed to "geographically isolated location."

This present study, however, aligns itself with a mushrooming scholarly movement intent on challenging such superficial assumptions. It seeks instead to diligently explore Ethiopian Christianity’s "various trajectories of translocal and transconfessional entanglements" and to

accord due recognition to the "decisive role" played by its Church teachers "in the making of Christianity into a global religion centuries before the European expansion" (Paulau & Tamcke, 2022, p. 2).

The Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, through the teachings of its spiritual ancestors, has never perceived its identity as peripheral. Our homeland, inextricably linked by our Fathers to the biblical Kush (Kuš, **ኩሽ**) or ʾItyoṗṗəya (**ኢትዮጵያ**), is a land profoundly embedded in sacred scripture (EOTC, 2000). This deep-seated self-understanding, consistently articulated by our ʾAbatoччč, is no recent fabrication. As Wendy Laura Belcher (2012) has meticulously shown, the EOTC, through its patristic writings, has for millennia actively "broadcast its own achievements and singularity." This is strikingly evident in the traditional Ethiopian patristic connection of the Ghion River (Gihon, **ግዮን**) from Genesis 2:13 directly to our own majestic ʿAbbay (**ዓባይ**, Blue Nile) (Teshome Zerihun, 2006; EOTC, 2000). Such a claim, passed down by generations of teachers, transcends mere geography; it is profoundly theological, asserting an ancient and unique covenantal identity (kidan, **ኪዳን**) for the land and its people.

1.1 Defining Ethiopian Patrology

When we engage with the term "Patrology" itself, a classical Western definition, exemplified by J. Tixeront's (1923, p. 1) *Handbook of Patrology*, defines "Ancient Christian Literature" as that of "the early centuries of Christianity," and Patrology as "the study of the life and works of the men designated by that name [Fathers of the Church]" (Tixeront, 1923, p. 2). Tixeront further delineates standard qualifications for a "Father": orthodoxy of doctrine (rətuʿ haymanot, **ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት**), holiness of life (qəddəsənna ḥəywät, **ቅድስና ሕይወት**), ecclesiastical sanction, and antiquity (Tixeront, 1923, p. 2). This offers a useful, albeit somewhat Western-centric, point of departure for understanding our focus on the Ethiopian ʾAbatoччč.

However, immersion in the world of the Ethiopian Fathers reveals a tradition that, while sharing common theological ground, pulsates with its own distinct rhythm. The spiritual lives and literary legacies of our Fathers follow a unique trajectory, forged through a unique synthesis of diverse influences and profound indigenous wisdom (ṭəbäb, **ጥበብ**) (Aymro Wondmagegnehu & Motovu, 1970). Understanding this tradition necessitates examining:

- The specific historical claims and foundational experiences of key Ethiopian patristic figures.
- The vast textual universe produced or transmitted by these teachers. This includes Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) translations they undertook or oversaw, indigenous Gädlät (**ገድላት**, hagiographies detailing their lives and struggles), the rich Andəmta (**አንድምታ**, traditional commentary shaped by generations of teaching Fathers), the sublime Zema (**ዜማ**, sacred chant) of St. Yared (Qəddus Yared, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**), and monumental compositions like the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**, Glory of Kings), which itself reflects a patristic worldview.
- The distinctive theological expressions, such as Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**, Union/Unity) Christology and profound Marian devotion, as articulated and defended in the writings and teachings of these sacred authors.

A critical divergence from some Western conceptions appears concerning the "Patristic age." Western Patrologies often describe a definitively closed period. Tixeront (1923, p. 5), for example, posits the patristic era concluded circa 749 AD for the Greek Church and 636 AD for the Latin.

The Ethiopian and broader Orthodox perspective, however, offers a different view. As Fr. Tadros Y. Malaty (2003, p. 8) cogently highlights, these traditions frequently see the spirit (mänfäs, **መንፈስ**) and activity (gəbər, **ግብር**) of the Fathers as an ongoing, living reality. This is because the Holy Spirit (Mänfäs Qəddus, **መንፈስ ቅዱስ**) is continually active in the Church, raising up new witnesses and teachers. Consequently, Ethiopian Patrology is not merely an archaeological excavation of a bygone era of Church authorities. It is the study of a continuous intellectual and spiritual heritage (rəst, **ርስት**), shaped by a succession of Fathers, which profoundly informs the Church today as it navigates the complex challenges of the modern world, including the enduring legacies of foreign interventions (Ademe & Ali, 2023) and the realities of its "declining hegemony" in a changing Ethiopian society (Feyissa, 2025).

Furthermore, while Tixeront (1923, p. 3) suggests a methodological division where Patrology covers "the history of the life and works of the Fathers," with doctrine (təmhərtä haymanot, **ትምህርተ ሃይማኖት**) belonging to "the History of Dogma," the Ethiopian tradition, as Fr. Malaty (2003, p. 7) encapsulates, often perceives the life (ḥəywät, **ሕይወት**), the literary contributions (śəraḥočč, **ሥራዎች**), and the theological thought (ḥəssabä mäläkot, **ሐሳበ መለኮት**) of the Fathers as indivisible. Patrology, in this sense, is "the door through which we can enter into the

Church and attain her spirit," transforming the historical texts and lived examples of these teachers into living, resonant thoughts. This study, therefore, endeavors to engage with the Ethiopian ʾAbatoччč on their own terms, recognizing the intrinsic value of their spiritual witness and literary legacies, and their unique, often decolonizing, testimony within the global Christian family (betäsäb, **ቤተሰብ**).

1.2 Criteria for Recognizing Yäʾityopṗəya ʾAbatoччč

Recognizing an individual as an "Ethiopian Father" (Yäʾityopṗəya ʾAbat, **የኢትዮጵያ አባት**; pl. Yäʾityopṗəya ʾAbatoччč, **የኢትዮጵያ አባቶች**) is not contingent upon consulting a formal, centrally decreed list (həgg, **ሕግ**). While Tixeront's (1923, p. 2) classical qualifications (orthodoxy, holiness, ecclesiastical sanction, antiquity) resonate deeply, the EOTC, much like other Orthodox Churches, does not "canonize" its Fathers through a formal juridical process. Instead, as Fr. Malaty (2003, p. 8) elucidates, their recognition emerges organically from the living tradition (ḥəyaw təwəfit, **ሕያው ትውፊት**) of the Church. This recognition is manifested through sustained veneration (kəbər, **ክብር**) by the faithful, liturgical commemoration (täzkar, **ተዝካር**)—especially within the Sənkəssar (**ስንክሳር**, Synaxarium, which itself is a collection of the lives of the saints and Fathers)—and the enduring influence of their writings (ṣəḥufatoччč, **ጽሑፋቶች**) and teachings (təmhərtoччč, **ትምህርቶች**). The title "Father," as Malaty (2003, p. 7) also clarifies, is not narrowly restricted to ordained clergy (kahənat, **ካህናት**); it embraces all who, through their exemplary lives and significant literary contributions, have shaped the Church's faith and understanding.

The core qualities sought in an Ethiopian Father, as evidenced by those whom the Church has historically embraced, generally encompass:

1. Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**, Correct Faith): An unwavering orthodoxy in their teachings and writings, particularly concerning the Holy Trinity (Qəddəst Śəllase, **ቅድስት ሥላሴ**) and the Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) Christology, which is the hallmark of Ethiopian Orthodoxy.
2. Qəddəsənna Ḥəywät (**ቅድስና ሕይወት**, Holiness of Life): An exemplary life where authentic theology and virtuous living are inseparable. The Gädlät (lives of

saints/Fathers) often emphasize their asceticism, prayerfulness, and pastoral love as integral to their theological authority.

3. Significant Contribution to Christian Literature and Tradition (Śəraḥ, **ሥራ**): This spans a wide range of influential outputs: systematic theological treatises, profound apologetics, divinely inspired hymns (Zema, **ዜማ**; Mäzmur, **መዝሙር**), illuminating Gädlät, insightful Andəmta commentaries, and vital translations (tərgʷame, **ትርጓሜ**) of sacred and patristic texts.
4. Antiquity and Foundational Impact: Special respect is accorded to those Fathers who laid the foundations of the Church in Ethiopia or made pivotal contributions during formative periods. However, the "spirit of the Fathers" (mänfäsä ʾabäw, **መንፈሰ አበው**) is understood as ever-present, allowing for the recognition of teachers from later periods who continue this sacred work.
5. BäBetä Krəstiyan Mətəwwaq (**በቤተ ክርስቲያን መታወቅ**, Recognition by the Church): This is perhaps the most encompassing and ultimately decisive criterion. It is demonstrated through the sustained veneration of a Father by the faithful community (məʾəmənan, **ምእመናን**) over generations, the liturgical use of their writings and hymns, and the continuous reference to their teachings in the ongoing life and education of the Church.

Figures such as the early Gəʿəz translators who first brought the Scriptures into the Ethiopian vernacular; the unparalleled hymnographer St. Yared (Qəddus Yared), whose Zema is the very breath of Ethiopian worship; the often-anonymous authors of influential Gädlät that shape piety and convey theological truths through narrative; the myriad scholars of the Andəmta tradition like Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**) and Mämhər Akalä Wəld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**), who dedicated their lives to interpreting the sacred texts; and great systematic theologians like Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**), all embody these qualities. The collective legacy of their spiritual witness and intellectual achievements is deeply interwoven with Ethiopia's unique spiritual self-perception, including cherished traditions they upheld, such as the understanding of Ethiopia as ʾAśratä Maryam (**ዓሥራቱ ማርያም**, Tithe of Mary), based on narratives like (**ወትቤሎ እግዝእትነ ማርያም ሀበኒዮ ውእተ ሕዝበ ወይቤላ ንሥኢ ይኩንኪ ዓሥራቱ** - "And Our Lady Mary said to Him, 'Give me that people,' and He said to her, 'Take, let it be your tithe'") (Getatchew Haile, 2013a).

1.3 Illustrative Ethiopian Fathers by Thematic Contribution

The Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church venerates a multitude of Fathers whose spiritual examples and intellectual contributions have profoundly shaped its identity. While not exhaustive, the following examples, drawing from scholars like Qəsis Dr. Amsalu Tefera (2011 E.C., pp. 1-4) who highlight prominent Ethiopian authors and their contributions, illustrate the diverse roles these patristic figures played:

- Foundational Translators and Early Organizers:
    - Abba Sälama Käśate Bərhan (St. Frumentius, **አባ ሰላማ ከሣቴ ብርሃን**) (4th Century): The first bishop, whose foundational activity included initiating the translation of Scriptures into Gəᶜəz and establishing the early Church structure (see Chapter Two).
    - The Nine Saints (**ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**) (late 5th-6th Centuries): These monastic Fathers undertook extensive translation projects of patristic and ascetic texts from Greek and Syriac, deeply embedding Miaphysite theology and monastic traditions (see Chapter Two).
- Liturgical Innovators and Master Hymnographers:
    - Saint Yared (Qəddus Yared, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**) (6th Century): The divinely inspired composer of the foundational corpus of Ethiopian liturgical chant (Zema, **ዜማ**). His corpus includes the five great chant books (Dəggʷa, Ṣomä Dəggʷa, Məᶜraf, Zəmmare, Mäwasəʾət), hymns like Anqäṣä Bərhan, and, according to tradition, some hagiographies and anaphoras (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 1; see Chapter Three).
    - Azaž Gera (**አዛዥ ጌራ**) and Azaž Raguel (**አዛዥ ራጉኤል**) (16th Century): These Church scholars are credited with the development of the musical notation for St. Yared's Dəggʷa and compiling/authoring the Mäṣḥafä Ziq (Book of Ziq) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 3, citing Getatchew Haile, 2010).
- Systematic Theologians and Apologists:
    - Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**) (fl. c. 1375): A scholar-Father known by this epithet, whose literary output included composing homilies (dərsanat) for various feasts (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 1; see Chapter Four).

- Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**) (c. 1365–1425): A prolific and profound theologian whose compositions include the systematic Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir (Book of Mystery), the devotional Arganonä Maryam (Harp of Mary), Ḥoḫətä Bərhan (Portal of Light), Mäṣḥafä Säᶜatat (Book of Hours), Fəkkare Mäläkot (Exposition of Divinity, likely referring to Fəkkare Haymanot), Wəddase Mäsqäl (Praise of the Cross), and many others, totaling over 40 compositions (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 1; see Chapter Five).
- Ǝčča Ǝnbaqom (**እጫጌ ዕንባቆም**) (c. 1470–c. 1560): A convert from Islam who became Ǝčča of Däbrä Libanos. His apologetic treatise, Anqäṣä Amin (Gate of Faith), written in Arabic first for Imam Ahmad Grañ and then in Gəᶜəz, defended Christianity against Islamic arguments. He also authored Mäṣḥafä Qeder (Book of Absolution) and translated numerous texts from other languages into Gəᶜəz, including Bärälam wäYəwasəf, Chrysostom's Commentary on Hebrews, Abušakər (Chronography), the Revelation of John, and ʾArägawi Mänfäsawi (Spiritual Elder) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., pp. 2-3; see Chapter Six). His multilingual abilities made his translation endeavors particularly significant.

- Theologian-Rulers and Patrons of Literature:
  - Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) (r. 1434–1468): A powerful theologian-king whose literary contributions included authoring numerous homilies and treatises like Mäṣḥafä Bərhan (Book of Light), Mäṣḥafä Milad (Book of Nativity), Ṭomarä Təsbʾət (Epistle of Humanity), and Kəḥdätä Säyṭan (Abjuration of Satan), as well as commissioning translations and promoting doctrinal unity (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 2; see Chapter Five).
  - Emperor Naᶜod (**ዐፄ ናዖድ**) (r. 1494–1508): This emperor is credited with the composition of Mälkəʾa Maryam (Image of Mary) and Mälkəʾa Mikael (Image of Michael) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 4).
  - Emperor Bäʾədä Maryam (**ዐፄ በእደ ማርያም**) (r. 1468–1478): He is recognized for composing Mälkəʾa Qurban (Image of the Eucharist) and Mälkəʾa Kidanä Məḥrät (Image of the Covenant of Mercy) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 4).
  - Emperor Ləbnä Dəngəl (**ዐፄ ልብነ ድንግል**) (r. 1508–1540): His literary legacy includes Mälkəʾa Edom (Image of Edom/the Red) and, from the Mäṣḥafä Säᶜatat

(Book of Hours), Marian praises such as LäNoḥ Ḥamäru (To Noah His Ark), Täfäśśəḥi Maryam (Rejoice O Mary), Läʾ Adam Fasikahu (To Adam His Pascha), and O Rəhrəḥtə Ḥəllina (O Compassionate of Mind) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 4).

- Poets, Hagiographers, and Chroniclers:
    - Arkä Śəllus (**አርከ ሥሉስ**) (15th Century): A renowned master of Qəne poetry, whose achievements included composing concise five-line poetic praises (Arke) for the saints commemorated in the Sənkəssar (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 2).
    - Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**) (16th Century): A monk from Gamo Gofa (Bərər Maryam), whose literary output included the Mäzmurä Krəstos (Psalm of Christ), Mälkəʿa Gäbrəʾel (Image of Gabriel), Sälamä Qəddusan (Peace of the Saints), and, significantly, chronicles (Zena Mäwaʿəl) of Emperors Gälawdewos, Minas, and Śärṣä Dəngəl (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 2; see Chapter Six).
- Authors of Devotional and Poetic Works:
    - Səbḥat Läʾ Ab zäGondär (**ስብሐት ለአብ ዘጎንደር**) (Gondarine Period): From Dəräsge Maryam, North Gondär, credited with composing Mälkəʾa Śəllase (Image of the Trinity) and the thirteen Ḥəmamatä Mäsqäl (Sorrows of the Cross) (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 3).
- Anonymous Fathers: Dr. Amsalu Tefera (2011 E.C., p. 4) also rightly notes that many Ethiopian authors, due to humility, did not attach their names to their compositions, instead using phrases like "I, the sinner." This means the full extent of indigenous patristic authorship is even greater than the named figures suggest. The authors of numerous hagiographies (Gädlät), Marian miracles (Täʾammərä Maryam), Mälkəʿ hymns, and Sälam prayers are often unknown, yet their collective literary heritage forms an immense part of the Ethiopian patristic corpus. He also notes the tragedy that some Ethiopian authors even attributed their compositions to foreign authors, further obscuring the true extent of indigenous literary production (Amsalu Tefera, 2011 E.C., p. 4).

These examples, spanning various centuries and types of contribution, demonstrate the richness and diversity of those recognized as Fathers in the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church. Their collective spiritual witness and literary endeavors, whether in founding institutions, composing liturgy, translating vital texts, systematizing theology, defending the faith, authoring devotional

masterpieces, or chronicling the Church's journey, have all contributed to the living tradition (ḥəyaw təwəfit) that continues to nourish the faithful.

1.4 The Literary Works of the Fathers

The body of Ethiopian patristic literature (sənä ṣəḥuf, **ሥነ ጽሑፍ**), comprising the collective intellectual output (śəraḥočč) of these Fathers, is incredibly rich and varied, forming the very core of the EOTC's intellectual and spiritual traditions (Esler, 2019, p. 101; Binns, 2017, p. 159). While sharing functional similarities with Greek and Latin patristic genres (Tixeront, 1923), the Ethiopian Fathers developed their own distinct expressions, primarily in the sacred Gəʿəz (**ግዕዝ**) language:

- Theological Treatises (Mäṣaḥəftä Məśṭir, **መጻሕፍተ ምሥጢር**) and Apologetics. These include systematic expositions of doctrine and defenses of the faith, exemplified by compositions like Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča's Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir (**መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**) and Fəkare Haymanot (**ፍካሬ ሃይማኖት**), or Ǝčäge Ǝnbaqom's Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን**).
- Biblico-Exegetical Writings (Andəmta, **አንድምታ**): The unique Ethiopian commentary tradition, a collective achievement of generations of teaching Fathers such as Mämhər Esdros, Mämhər Akalä Wəld, and ʾArat ʿAyna Goššu (**አራት ዓይና ጎሹ** – "Four-Eyed Goshu").
- Homilies and Sermons (Dərsanat, **ድርሳናት**; Səbkät, **ስብከት**): Expository and hortatory discourses delivered by the Fathers for the instruction and edification of the faithful.
- Hagiographies (Gädlät, **ገድላት**): Narratives detailing the lives (ḥəywät), spiritual struggles, miracles, and teachings of saints (qəddusan, **ቅዱሳን**), who are themselves often considered Fathers. These texts are central to Ethiopian piety and serve as vehicles for conveying theological and moral teachings.
- Liturgical Works (Śərʿatä Qəddase, **ሥርዓተ ቅዳሴ**) and Hymnody (Zema, **ዜማ**): This genre is overwhelmingly dominated by the divinely inspired compositions of St. Yared, including his five seminal books (Dəggʷa, **ድጓ**; Məʿraf, **ምዕራፍ**; Zəmmare, **ዝማሬ**; Mäwasəʾət, **መዋስዕት**; Ṣomä Dəggʷa, **ጾመ ድጓ**) and the distinctive melodic modes (Gəʿəz, ʾǝzəl, **እዝል**; Araray, **አራራይ**) that form the backbone of EOTC worship.

- Poetry (Qəne, **ቅኔ**): A sophisticated form of theological poetry, often employing the "wax and gold" (sämənna wärq, **ሰምና ወርቅ**) hermeneutic, developed and mastered by numerous monastic Fathers and scholars.
- Historical Writings (Tarik, **ታሪክ**): Chronicles and historical narratives, the most famous being the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**), which, while a national epic, also reflects a deep patristic theology of Ethiopia's covenantal identity.
- Ascetic (Täbaḥtəwo, **ተባሕትዎ**) and Monastic Writings (Mäṣaḥəftä Mänäkosat, **መጻሕፍተ መነኮሳት**): Rules, spiritual counsels, and lives of monastic Fathers that guide the ascetic and communal life of monks and nuns.
- Pastoral or Imperial Letters and Confessions (Dəbdabewočč, **ደብዳቤዎች**; Ṭomar, **ጦማር**): Writings such as Emperor Gälawdewos's Confession (Ṭomarä Gälawdewos, **ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ**), which articulate and defend the faith in specific historical contexts.

The compositions of St. Yared are particularly celebrated, not only for their spiritual depth but also for their role in advancing Gəᶜəz literature and unifying the Church's worship across the nation (EOTC, 2000).

This entire corpus, the fruit of the spiritual journeys and intellectual labors of the Ethiopian Fathers, is not a static collection of ancient texts but the living textual heart (ləbb, **ልብ**) of the EOTC, continually studied, chanted, and meditated upon.

1.5 Apostolic Foundations

The Ethiopian Fathers consistently understood and articulated the Church's identity as inextricably bound to the Holy Bible and the apostolic age (EOTC, 2000). In their writings and teachings, the biblical "Kush" (Kuš) is identified with ʾItyoṗṗəya (EOTC, 2000), and they often pointed to Psalm 68:31 ("Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God") as evidence of a pre-Christian inclination towards worship of the Creator (Fäṭari, **ፈጣሪ**). Foundational narratives, such as the Queen of Sheba's (Nəgəśtä Saba, **ንግሥተ ሳባ**) visit to Solomon (Sälemon, **ሰሎሞን**) (1 Kings 10:1-9), which our Fathers understood as the event that brought Old Testament doctrine (Həggä Orit, **ሕገ ኦሪት**) to Ethiopia, are central to their articulation of a unique covenantal history (EOTC, 2000; Binns, 2017, p. 1).

The definitive arrival of Christianity (Krəstənna, **ክርስትና**) is traditionally dated by the Fathers to 34 AD with the baptism (ṭəmqät, **ጥምቀት**) of the Ethiopian Eunuch by Philip the Apostle (Filipp̣os Hawarya, **ፊሊጶስ ሐዋርያ**) (Acts 8:26-40). This high official, known in our tradition as Bacos (**ባኮስ**), is honored by subsequent teachers as the "rocky foundation" of Ethiopian Christianity (Teshome Zerihun, 2006).

Eusebius and St. Jerome are often cited in Ethiopian patristic tradition as confirming this early Christianization, thereby affirming Ethiopia's direct apostolic connection (EOTC, 2000; Teshome Zerihun, 2006). The formal organization of the Church solidified around 330 AD with the consecration of Abba Sälama (**አባ ሰላማ**, St. Frumentius) as the first bishop by the great Alexandrian Father, St. Athanasius (EOTC, 2000). This act, establishing orthodox episcopal succession, is seen by Ethiopian Fathers as a cornerstone of their Church's apostolicity. The subsequent arrival of the Nine Saints (Täsᶜatu Qəddusan, **ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**) around 451 AD, themselves monastic Fathers fleeing turmoil elsewhere, is understood to have further deepened the Church's indigenous character. Their activity in advancing Gəᶜəz translation and consolidating Orthodox (Täwaḥədo) doctrine, rooted in the first three Ecumenical Councils (Gubaʾeyat, **ጉባኤያት**), is a pivotal chapter in the story of the Ethiopian Fathers (EOTC, 2000; Sergew Hable Sellassie, 1970).

1.6 The Developmental Route of Ethiopian Patristic Thought

The study of Ethiopian patristic thought, as revealed through the lives and literary contributions of its Fathers, unfolds across several distinct periods, each with its unique characteristics, challenges, and legacies. This trajectory demonstrates remarkable continuity, extending far beyond the chronological limits often imposed on the "Patristic Age" in Western scholarship.

- The Ancient or Aksumite Period (zämänä ʾAksum, **ዘመነ አክሱም**) (c. 4th - early Medieval centuries): This was the foundational era, shaped by the spiritual examples and influential endeavors of Fathers like Abba Sälama and the Nine Saints. Their primary contribution was the monumental Gəᶜəz translation of Scriptures and early patristic texts, alongside the establishment of monasticism (mənəkəsənna, **ምንኩስና**). This period also saw the emergence of the unique genius of St. Yared, whose divinely inspired Zema became a cornerstone of Ethiopian Orthodox life (Esler, 2019; Binns, 2017).

- The Medieval "Golden Age" (**ወርቃዊ ዘመን**) (c. late 10th/12th - 17th century): Encompassing the Zagwe dynasty (whose king-saint Lalibäla (**ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**) left monumental patristic statements in stone) and the Solomonic Restoration, this period witnessed an explosion of indigenous intellectual production by a succession of influential Fathers. Major theological compositions by monastic teachers like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**), Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), the great systematizer Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**), and the theologian-emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**), alongside the compilation of the Kəbrä Nägäśt, the flourishing of Gädlät literature, and the extensive development of the Andəmta tradition by countless teaching Fathers, define this era.
- The Post-Medieval/Gondarine to Early 20th Century (zämänä Gondär, **ዘመነ ጎንደር**) (c. 17th - early 20th century): This period was marked by continued literary production by patristic figures but also by intense internal theological controversies (Qəbᶜat, **ቅብዐት**; Ṣägga, **ጸጋ**/Śost Lədät, **ሦስት ልደት**), which engaged the minds of leading scholars like Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**). Traditional church education, the nursery of future Fathers, remained central. The drive for doctrinal unification by emperors and conciliar Fathers like Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) also characterized this period.
- The Contemporary Period (20th century – Present): This era has been shaped by the achievement of autocephaly (**ራሷን የቻለች** Betä Krəstiyan), a patristic milestone realized through the efforts of figures like Emperor Haile Selassie I (**ቀዳማዊ ኃይለ ሥላሴ**) and the first Ethiopian Patriarch Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**). It has seen the establishment of modern theological colleges, growing efforts to publish and translate Gəᶜəz texts by scholar-Fathers like Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**) and Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአክ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**), and the Church's engagement with global theological dialogues, often led by its Patriarchs and bishops.

This study approaches Ethiopian Patrology not as an isolated phenomenon but as a dynamic, historically engaged tradition shaped by the spiritual lives and literary legacies of its Fathers. These ʾAbatočč have consistently striven to articulate their ancient faith with an authentic and enduring Ethiopian voice, contributing significantly to a "non-Eurocentric reading of the global Christian past" (Paulau & Tamcke, 2022, p. 1) and offering a powerful testament to the enduring power of indigenous faith and scholarship.

Review Questions for Chapter One

1. According to Paulau & Tamcke (2022), how has the traditional historiography of Christianity often marginalized traditions like the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, and what corrective does the study of Ethiopian Patrology offer?
2. Explain the significance of J. Tixeront's (1923) classical definition of "Patrology" and "Father of the Church" as a starting point for understanding Ethiopian Patrology, while also noting how the Ethiopian tradition, with its concept of a living tradition, expands upon or differs from these definitions, particularly regarding the "Patristic age."
3. Discuss the importance of the biblical name "Ethiopia" (ʾItyoppəya) and its connection to Kush (Kuš) for the EOTC's self-understanding, referencing at least one specific biblical passage or traditional narrative like the Ghion (Gihon, **ግዮን**) River.
4. Outline the five primary qualifications typically considered in the Ethiopian Orthodox tradition for recognizing an individual as a Church Father. How does "Ecclesiastical Reception" play a decisive role, and how does this differ from formal canonization?
5. Describe two key biblical or apostolic foundations (e.g., the Ethiopian Eunuch/Bacos, **ባኮስ**; the consecration of Abba Sälama, **አባ ሰላማ**) upon which the EOTC bases its claims to ancient origins and direct connection to the early Church (zämänä hawaryat, **ዘመነ ሐዋርያት**).
6. Briefly describe the four main periods in the developmental trajectory of Ethiopian patristic thought as outlined in this chapter, highlighting one key characteristic or figure for each period.
7. How does framing the study of Ethiopian Patrology within a decolonizing perspective, valuing indigenous knowledge and challenging Eurocentric narratives, contribute to a more complete understanding of Christian history?

Chapter Two

2 Aksumite Patristic Foundations

Chapter Objectives

- To examine the life and foundational patristic activity of St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama, **አባ ሰላማ**), the first bishop (**ኤጲስቆጶስ**), focusing on his episcopal ministry in establishing the Church, his initiative in Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) translations, and his role in laying the groundwork for Ethiopian Christian identity through his pastoral and literary endeavors.
- To explore the collective spiritual journey and contributions of the Nine Saints (Täsᶜatu Qəddusan, **ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**), detailing their pivotal impact on the establishment and flourishing of monasticism (**ምንኵስና**), their extensive translation efforts of crucial patristic and scriptural texts into Gəᶜəz, and their role in consolidating Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo, **ተዋሕዶ**) theology in Aksum through their teachings and writings.
- To highlight how the literary and pastoral legacies of these Aksumite Fathers—including the translation of texts like Qerəllos (**ቄርሎስ**) and the Life of St. Anthony—created the indispensable bedrock for all subsequent Ethiopian patristic thought and indigenous theological expression.
- To briefly situate these patristic endeavors within their historical Aksumite context, while maintaining a primary focus on the Fathers themselves, their spiritual witness (**ሕይወት**), and their specific contributions (**ሥራዎች**).

Venturing into the earliest formations of Ethiopian Patrology, we are immediately drawn to the Aksumite era (**ዘመነ አክሱም**). This period, stretching roughly from the formal establishment of the Church in the 4th century CE through the 7th or 8th century, was absolutely foundational for the entire subsequent history of Ethiopian Orthodox Christian thought, its unique spirituality, and its rich literary tradition, all shaped by the lives and impactful endeavors of its pioneering Fathers. It was within the dynamic, cosmopolitan civilization of Aksum—a significant "trading state" and a "centre of civilisation" with extensive international connections (Binns, 2017, p. 39; Esler, 2019, p. 12), a milieu that included pre-Christian religious practices involving deities like

Almaqah (**አልማቃሕ**) and Mahrem (**ማሕረም**) (Esler, 2019, pp. 13-17, 22)—that the Church in Ethiopia was formally established. It received its episcopal structure from Alexandria, and under the guidance of its first patristic teachers, began to cultivate its distinct theological and spiritual character. This chapter focuses on the spiritual lives and seminal contributions of these earliest Ethiopian ʾAbatočč (**አባቶች**): St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama), who laid the episcopal and initial literary cornerstone, and the Nine Saints, who were architects of monastic life and systematic textual transmission in Gəʿəz. Their collective efforts represent the genesis of patristic activity in Ethiopia, shaping a tradition that was, from its inception, deeply faithful to universal apostolic teaching yet remarkably creative in its indigenous expression.

2.1 St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama, **አባ ሰላማ**)

While the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (EOTC) proudly traces its very first Christian encounters to the Ethiopian Eunuch in the 1st century AD (Acts 8:26-40), the Father universally credited with the formal institutional establishment of Christianity in Aksum and its first episcopal leadership is Saint Frumentius. In Ethiopia, his memory is profoundly venerated, and he is honored with the titles Abba Sälama (**አባ ሰላማ** – Father of Peace) and Käśate Bərhan (**ከሣቴ ብርሃን** – Revealer of Light) (Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 10; Binns, 2017, p. 42). His life and dedicated episcopal ministry constitute the inaugural chapter in the narrative of Ethiopian Fathers.

2.1.1 His Life, Consecration and Episcopal Establishment

The primary historical accounts of Frumentius's early life, notably from Rufinus of Aquileia, describe his providential arrival in Aksum as a young Christian Syrian who, due to his wisdom and integrity, gained favor in the royal court (Tixeront, 1923, p. 136; Esler, 2019, pp. 28-29). Indigenous Ethiopian sources, such as the Dərsan zäQəddus Fərmənaṭos (**ድርሳን ዘቅዱስ ፍርማጦስ** – Homily of St. Frumentius), offer complementary perspectives, suggesting an encounter with an existing Christian understanding and a local priestly figure, ʾƎnbäräm Kahən (**እንበረም ካህን**). Under this priest, Frumentius is said to have learned "spiritual teaching" and the Gəʿəz language (gəʿzä ləsan, **ግዕዘ ልሳን**) before his historically pivotal journey to Alexandria (Atinafu & Amsalu, 2011).

The most significant contribution of St. Frumentius, and that which firmly establishes him as a Father, was his securing of apostolic succession and an organized episcopal structure for the burgeoning Church in Ethiopia. Around 330 AD, motivated by a pastoral concern for the growing Christian community in Aksum, Frumentius traveled to Alexandria. There, he appealed to the great Patriarch, St. Athanasius (**አትናቴዎስ**), a towering Father of the universal Church. Recognizing Frumentius's profound faith, wisdom, and suitability for the episcopal office, St. Athanasius consecrated him as the first Abun (**አቡን** – Bishop) of Aksum (Kaplan, 1982; Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 9).

This act of consecration was not merely administrative; it was a profound patristic undertaking that formally integrated the Ethiopian Church into the orthodox episcopal lineage of the wider Christian world and established a direct canonical link with the venerable See of Alexandria, a relationship that would shape Ethiopian ecclesiastical life for centuries.

2.1.2 The Patristic Contributions and Enduring Legacy of Abba Sälama

Upon his return to Aksum as its first bishop, Abba Sälama embarked on the multifaceted task of organizing and nurturing the Church. Under his spiritual leadership and with the support of the Aksumite ruler King Ezana, Christianity was declared the state religion (EOTC, 2000). The visible impact of this Father's ministry is evident in King Ezana's coins and inscriptions, which reflect a clear shift from pre-Christian symbols to distinctly Christian monograms and Trinitarian formulae (Esler, 2019, pp. 22-23, 35-40).

Abba Sälama's patristic contributions, stemming from his episcopal ministry and revered in Ethiopian tradition (e.g., Solomon Yohannes, 2010), are foundational:

- Initiating the Gəᶜəz Translation Movement: Abba Sälama is honored for initiating the monumental endeavor of translating the Holy Scriptures (**መጻሕፍት ቅዱሳት**) and essential liturgical texts into Gəᶜəz. This act of rendering the Word of God and core Christian texts into the indigenous vernacular is a quintessential patristic achievement, laying the very foundation for an Ethiopian Christian literary and theological tradition (Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 12).
- Systematizing the Gəᶜəz Alphabet (Fidel, **ፊደል**): Ethiopian tradition also attributes the systematization of the Gəᶜəz syllabary (fidelat, **ፊደላት**) to his era, particularly the development or refinement of vowel markings. This linguistic advancement was

indispensable for ensuring the accurate translation, pronunciation, and transmission of sacred texts (Solomon Yohannes, 2010; Ullendorff, 1951).

- Establishing Key Pastoral Structures: His pastoral activity involved laying the groundwork for the local church hierarchy (**ሥርዓተ ካህናት**), organizing the liturgy (**ቅዳሴ**), and establishing enduring pastoral practices such as the role of the father confessor (**የንስሐ አባት**) and the tradition of godparents in baptism (**የጥምቀት አባት/እናት**) (Solomon Yohannes, 2010).
- Fostering Spiritual Associations (**ማኅበር**) and Overseeing Church Construction: The development of spiritual fellowships (Mäḥəbär) centered around saints' commemoration days (**ተዝካር**) and the construction of the first church buildings (**ሕንጻተ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**) throughout Ethiopia are also linked to his guidance (Solomon Yohannes, 2010).
- He is also credited with asserting Ethiopian presence in Jerusalem (ʿIyerusalem, **ኢየሩሳሌም**).

The honorific titles "Abba Sälama" (Father of Peace) and "Käśate Bərhan" (Revealer of Light) beautifully encapsulate the essence of his life and legacy. He was truly a foundational Father who, through his episcopal ministry and pioneering literary efforts, established the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church on a firm patristic footing.

2.2 The Nine Saints (Täsʿatu Qəddusan, ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን)

Following the foundational episcopate of Abba Sälama, the next major patristic impetus in the Aksumite era arrived with the revered Nine Saints (**ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**). These monastic Fathers—whose names are celebrated in Ethiopian tradition: Abba Afse (**አባ አፍጼ**), Abba Alef (**አባ አሌፍ**), Abba Aragawi (**አባ አረጋዊ**), Abba Gärima (**አባ ገሪማ**), Abba Guba (**አባ ጉባ**), Abba Liqanos (**አባ ሊቃኖስ**), Abba Ṗänṭelewon (**አባ ጰንጠሌዎን**), Abba Sehma (**አባ ስሕማ**), and Abba Yəmat'a (**አባ ይምአታ**) (Esler, 2019, p. 47)—came to Ethiopia around 480 AD or shortly thereafter (Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 11). Tradition holds they originated from various parts of the Roman Empire (Syria, Constantinople, etc.), likely seeking refuge from the theological turmoil following the Council of Chalcedon (451 AD) due to their unwavering commitment to the Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo) Christology espoused by St. Cyril of Alexandria, a stance that Aksum shared (Teshome Zerihun, 2006). Their collective spiritual witness and literary

contributions as ascetic exemplars, dedicated translators of Gəʿəz texts, and theological consolidators profoundly shaped the spiritual landscape and intellectual heritage of the Ethiopian Church.

2.2.1 Their Lives as Monastic Pioneers and Spiritual Guides

The Nine Saints are venerated primarily as the great pioneers and organizers of monasticism (**ምንኵስና**) in Ethiopia. Their impact in this regard was multifaceted and deeply patristic:

- Founding and Revitalizing Monasteries (**ገዳማት**): Each of the Nine Saints is traditionally associated with the founding or revitalization of a major monastery, particularly in the region of Tigray. These include renowned centers like Däbrä Damo (**ደብረ ዳሞ**) (linked to Abba Aragawi), Däbrä Ṗänṭelewon (**ደብረ ጳንጠሌዎን**) (Abba Ṗänṭelewon), and the monastery of Abba Gärima (**አባ ገሪማ**) (Abba Gärima) (Teshome Zerihun, 2006). These monastic establishments, born from the endeavors of these Fathers, became powerhouses of spiritual life, rigorous ascetic discipline (**ተባሕትዎ**), theological learning, and manuscript copying.
- Modeling Ascetic Holiness (**ቅድስና ሕይወት**): The lives of the Nine Saints, as recounted in their respective Gädlät (**ገድላት** – hagiographies), emphasize their profound piety, dedication to prayer, and commitment to a life of evangelical poverty and detachment. They served as living exemplars of Christian holiness, their very existence being an inspiration that moved countless Ethiopians to embrace monasticism and deepen their spiritual commitment.
- Pastoral Counsel and Influence: Their wisdom and spiritual authority extended beyond the monastic enclosures. The Gädlä Ṗänṭelewon (**ገድለ ጳንጠሌዎን**), for instance, recounts the Aksumite Emperor Kaleb (**አፄ ካሌብ**) seeking counsel from Abba Ṗänṭelewon, illustrating the significant influence these monastic Fathers wielded in the spiritual and even political affairs of the kingdom (Sergew H. Selassie, 1972, p. 121).

2.2.2 Their Contribution

A critical aspect of the Nine Saints' enduring patristic legacy lies in their monumental contribution to the Gəʿəz translation movement and the consolidation of Orthodox doctrine.

Building upon the initial efforts of Abba Sälama, their activity in this domain was extensive and transformative:

- Advancing the Translation of Holy Scripture: The Nine Saints are credited with making significant contributions to the translation and revision of the Holy Scriptures into Gəʿəz. Their familiarity with Greek and possibly Syriac would have enabled them to refine existing translations and introduce new texts or readings (Knibb, 1999; EOTC, 2000, p. 7).
- Translating Key Patristic and Ascetic Works into Gəʿəz: Their most impactful literary achievement involved rendering a vast corpus of essential patristic and ascetic writings into Gəʿəz. These included:
    - Qerəllos (**ቄርሎስ**): A collection of writings by or attributed to St. Cyril of Alexandria, particularly his works defending the Miaphysite understanding of Christ. The translation of these texts was instrumental in firmly establishing Cyrillian Christology as the bedrock of Ethiopian Orthodox theology.
    - The Life of St. Anthony (Gädlä ʾAnṭonəyos, **ገድለ እንጦንዮስ**): The translation of St. Athanasius's classic work on the father of monasticism provided a foundational text and model for Ethiopian asceticism.
    - Monastic Rules and Ascetic Treatises: Works such as the Rule of St. Pachomius (Śərʿat zäʾAbunä Pakumis, **ሥርዓት ዘአቡነ ጳኩሚስ**) and other ascetic writings (e.g., Mäṣḥafä Mänäkosat, **መጽሐፈ መነኰሳት** – Book of Monks) were translated, providing practical guidance for the burgeoning monastic communities (Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 12). Essential liturgical and canonical texts like the Dəsqəlya (**ዲስቅልያ**, Didascalia Apostolorum) and ʾAbṭəlis (**አብጥሊስ**, Canons of the Apostles) were also part of this translation enterprise (Hammerschmidt, 1963).

This intensive translation endeavor was not merely a linguistic exercise; it was a profound theological undertaking. It provided the Ethiopian Church with direct access to the rich heritage of early Christian thought, equipped its scholars with a sophisticated theological vocabulary in Gəʿəz, and decisively shaped its unwavering commitment to Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo) Christology.

- The Garima Gospels (Wängelä Gärima, **ወንጌለ ገሪማ**): These remarkably early illuminated Gospel manuscripts, dated by some scholars to as early as the 5th to 7th centuries, are traditionally associated with Abba Gärima, one of the Nine Saints (Esler, 2019, pp. 103-104). Whether copied by his own hand or produced within the highly developed scribal and artistic environment that the Nine Saints fostered, these Gospels stand as a powerful testament to the advanced state of Christian literary culture in Aksumite Ethiopia during their era. They symbolize the dedication of these Fathers to the preservation and beautification of the sacred text.

The Nine Saints, through their exemplary monastic lives, their tireless translation activity, and their commitment to theological orthodoxy, are undeniably pivotal foundational Fathers of the Ethiopian Church. They built upon the episcopal and initial literary structures established by Abba Sälama, deeply entrenching the Orthodox faith, monastic spirituality, and a rich Gəʿəz literary tradition in the Ethiopian highlands. They are also traditionally credited with influencing Ethiopian church music (zema, **ዜማ**) and art, and St. Yared is often considered their disciple (Sergew H. Selassie, 1970, p. 12).

2.3 Patristic Foundations Laid in the Aksumite Era by its Fathers

The Aksumite era, through the collective spiritual witness and contributions of pioneering Fathers like St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama) and the Nine Saints, was thus undeniably formative for Ethiopian Patrology. It bequeathed to the Church its core identity and enduring characteristics:

- Apostolic Succession and Alexandrian Connection: The episcopal ministry of Abba Sälama, consecrated by St. Athanasius, established an unbroken line of orthodox leadership and a deep, lasting connection to the theological traditions of the See of Alexandria.
- A Gəʿəz Scriptural and Patristic Corpus: The monumental translation project undertaken by these Fathers provided the Ethiopian Church with its Holy Scriptures and a rich library of early Christian patristic and ascetic writings in its own sacred language, Gəʿəz.

- A Deep Monastic Heart: The Nine Saints, through their lives and teachings, instilled within Ethiopian Orthodoxy a profound monastic ethos, making monasticism a central pillar of its spiritual life, theological learning, and cultural preservation.
- Unalterable Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo) Theological Orientation: The selection and translation of texts, particularly the writings of St. Cyril, and the theological instruction provided by these Fathers, firmly established the Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo) understanding of Christ—emphasizing the one united divine-human nature—as the definitive doctrinal position of the Ethiopian Church.

The Eunuch Bacos, Abba Sälama, and the Nine Saints are, without question, foundational Fathers whose lives were dedicated to the establishment and nurturing of the Church in Ethiopia. Their collective labor and spiritual witness created a vibrant, indigenous Christian tradition that was not a mere passive reception of foreign influence but a profound inculturation of the Gospel. The legacies they established—episcopal organization, linguistic development, extensive translation, monastic institutionalization, and theological consolidation—set the stage for the unique spiritual and artistic genius of subsequent Ethiopian Fathers, such as St. Yared, and for the later Golden Ages of Ethiopian Christian thought and literature. Their accomplishments demonstrate the power of dedicated patristic leadership in shaping a Church that would endure and flourish for millennia. The decline of Aksum due to various geopolitical shifts (Binns, 2017, p. 61) eventually led the Christian kingdom to turn its focus inward and southward, but always drawing upon the rich patristic foundations laid by these Aksumite Fathers.

Review Questions for Chapter Two

1. Describe the religious and cultural milieu of the Aksumite kingdom before the formal establishment of Christianity, noting at least two specific pre-Christian religious elements present (e.g., Almaqah, **አልማቃሕ**; Mahrem, **ማሕረም**).
2. What was the primary historical and theological significance of St. Frumentius's (Abba Sälama, **አባ ሰላማ**) consecration by St. Athanasius for the Ethiopian Church's identity and its connection to the wider Christian world? Include insights from the Dərsan (**ድርሳን**) tradition concerning ʾƎnbäräm Kahən (**እንበረም ካህን**).
3. Explain why the Gəᶜəz translation movement during the Aksumite era is considered a crucial patristic endeavor. Name at least two types of texts, apart from the Bible, that were translated into Gəᶜəz.

4. Discuss two major contributions of the Nine Saints (**ዘጠኙ ቅዱሳን**) to the development of Ethiopian Orthodox Christianity, particularly in relation to monasticism (**ምንኩስና**) and theological consolidation, referencing their connection to textual production like the Garima Gospels (**ወንጌለ ገሪማ**).
5. How did the Aksumite period lay the "patristic foundations" for subsequent Ethiopian Christian thought and identity, especially in terms of its scriptural language (Gəʿəz, **ግዕዝ**), doctrinal orientation (Täwaḥədo, **ተዋሕዶ**), and spiritual practices?
6. Considering the decolonizing lens emphasized in Chapter One, why is it important to recognize the active role and indigenous agency of Aksumite Ethiopians in shaping their Christian tradition, rather than viewing it merely as a passive reception of external influences? How does the traditional story of Abba Sälama and ʾƎnbäräm Kahən, or the work of the Nine Saints, illustrate this?

Chapter Three

3 Early Indigenous Patristic Voices

Chapter Objectives

- To examine the life and divinely inspired literary and liturgical contributions of Saint Yared (Qəddus Yared, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**) as a foundational indigenous patristic figure, focusing on his Zema (**ዜማ**) as the wellspring of Ethiopian liturgical theology, particularly his teachings on Christology (**ነገረ ክርስቶስ**) and Soteriology.
- To explore the traditional accounts of St. Yared's divine inspiration for his compositions, as recorded in sources like the Gädlä Yared (**ገድለ ያሬድ**), and to understand the sacred authority attributed to his achievements, considering scholarly insights from Getatchew Haile (2017).
- To analyze the theological content, structure (including the main books of Zema like Dəggʷa (**ድጓ**); Məᶜraf (**ምዕራፍ**); Zəmmare (**ዝማሬ**); Mäwasəʾət (**መዋስዕት**); Ṣomä Dəggʷa (**ጾመ ድጓ**)), and unique characteristics of Yaredic Zema, including its melodic modes and notation (məlkkətočč, **ምልክቶች**), as the defining legacy of this Father.
- To articulate St. Yared's enduring patristic significance, demonstrated by how his creative output continues to shape Ethiopian Orthodox worship (ʾamləko, **አምልኮ**), doctrine (təmhərtä haymanot, **ትምህርተ ሃይማኖት**), and cultural identity.
- To discuss the continuation and expression of patristic themes during the Zagwe era, particularly through the life and monumental achievements of St. Lalibela, interpreting the rock-hewn churches as profound theological and patristic statements, and noting the continued importance of literary compositions including those sometimes broadly referred to as ʾƏlatqärfa (**እልአትቀርፋ**).
- To reflect on the overall importance of the spiritual witness and creative legacies of these early indigenous Fathers in shaping a distinct Ethiopian Christian patristic tradition.

Having explored the foundational Aksumite era in Chapter Two—a seminal period marked by the Church's institutional establishment through the ministry of Fathers like Abba Sälama (**አባ ሰላማ**), the monumental Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) translation efforts, and the Nine Saints (**ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**)

solidifying Miaphysite (Täwaḥədo, **ተዋሕዶ**) monastic theology—we now transition to an epoch where these carefully sown patristic seeds burgeoned into uniquely Ethiopian expressions of theological and spiritual genius. This represents a subtle yet profound shift. While earlier centuries were, understandably, characterized by the indispensable activity of receiving, translating, and adapting foundational Christian texts and traditions from the broader Christian oikoumene (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 9), this subsequent phase, luminously illuminated by the towering figure of Saint Yared (**ቅዱስ ያሬድ**) in the 6th century and continuing through the Zagwe era, showcases a remarkable efflorescence of indigenous patristic creativity.

The Church in Ethiopia, now more firmly rooted with its Holy Scriptures (Mäṣaḥəft Qəddusat, **መጻሕፍት ቅዱሳት**) and core doctrines increasingly articulated in the vernacular Gəʿəz language thanks to the labors of earlier patristic teachers, began to produce its own profound theological insights and unparalleled liturgical art. Saint Yared stands as the paramount exemplar of this creative dynamism, his spiritual journey and creative output resulting in a comprehensive system of sacred music and hymnody that is not only artistically unique but also serves as a deep wellspring of Ethiopian Orthodox theology. Subsequently, during the Zagwe dynasty (c. 10th – 13th centuries), this rich Christian heritage continued to be nurtured, with figures like Saint Lalibäla (Qəddus Lalibäla, **ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**) leaving an indelible mark through monumental expressions of faith in stone. This chapter, therefore, delves into the lives and defining contributions of these crucial early indigenous Fathers, examining how Ethiopian Christianity began to produce its own distinct theological fruit.

3.1 Saint Yared (Qəddus Yared, ቅዱስ ያሬድ)

The heart of Ethiopian Orthodox theology beats with a profound understanding of Jesus Christ – His person, His nature, and His saving work. This is what we call Christology (Nägärä Krəstos, **ነገረ ክርስቶስ**). Following the foundational activity of Abba Sälama and the Nine Saints, the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church was poised for a uniquely indigenous expression of this faith. This arrived most powerfully through the life and creative genius of Saint Yared (Qəddus Yared), who flourished in the 6th century CE (Teshome Zerihun, 2006). He is revered as a preeminent scholar (liq, **ሊቅ**), an inspired composer (därasi, **ደራሲ**), and, most importantly, the

divinely gifted wellspring of Ethiopian liturgical chant (Zema, **ዜማ**). His legacy is a hallmark of this era (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 31).

St. Yared's Zema is far more than mere 'church music'; it is profound liturgical theology. This sacred chant, his primary contribution, conveys doctrine, expresses spiritual experience, and narrates the entire economy of salvation. His hymns are a primary indigenous source for understanding Ethiopian Christology, expressing complex doctrines in poetic and worshipful language. His compositions constantly emphasize the Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) – the one, united divine-human nature of Christ, His eternal pre-existence with the Father, and the reality of His Incarnation for our salvation. A powerful encapsulating phrase often attributed to the spirit of St. Yared's understanding of the Incarnation and its effect is (**ወረደ ሰማያዊ ፥ ውኅሰብሐ መሬታዊ ።** - "The Heavenly descended, and the earthly became exalted/glorified."). This simple yet profound statement captures the essence of the salvific exchange that occurred in Christ.

3.1.1 The Life of St. Yared

The primary traditional source for St. Yared's life is his Gädl (**ገድል** – hagiography). However, as Getatchew Haile (2017, p. 270) points out in his review of sources, a "common and widely copied gädl" for St. Yared might actually be missing or even suppressed. He notes that the text published by Conti Rossini (1904) as *Acta Yārēd* is structured more like a dərsan (**ድርሳን** – homily) than a traditional gädl, and that this *Acta* itself quotes from an "unidentified gädl," suggesting an earlier, perhaps suppressed, hagiography (Getatchew Haile, 2017, pp. 271-273). Despite these textual complexities, these sources, along with the Sənkəssar (**ስንክሳር**) entry for Gənbot 11 (**ግንቦት ፲፩**), provide the core narrative of this Father's life, his birth in Aksum, his initial struggles in learning, and his eventual divine inspiration, famously sparked by observing a caterpillar's perseverance (Getatchew Haile, 2017, p. 271).

The Ethiopian tradition is unwavering: St. Yared's unparalleled musical and theological genius, the very essence of his creative output, was a direct gift from God (**ሀብተ እግዚአብሔር**). The *Acta Yārēd* depicts him learning sublime melodies directly from the Twenty-Four Heavenly Elders (**ካህናተ ሰማይ**) during a visionary ascent to Paradise (Conti Rossini, 1904, p. 9, as cited in Getatchew Haile, 2017, p. 272).

Getatchew Haile (2017, pp. 273-277) further discusses the possibility that an earlier Gädlä Yared might have been suppressed by figures like Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) due to

concerns about elements like asmat (**አስማት** - incantations/spells) or views such as the Virgin Mary conceiving Christ through her ear (bäʾəntä mäskotä ʾəzna, **በእንተ መስኮተ እዝና**), a teaching that Zärʾa Yaʿəqob is known to have refuted. This account of divine revelation and potential historical textual complexities underscores the sacred authority attributed to his compositions and his status as an inspired Father whose legacy has been carefully transmitted and, at times, possibly curated.

3.1.2 The Compositions of St. Yared

The enduring legacy of St. Yared consists of the foundational collections of Ethiopian liturgical chant, the Zema. These major literary and musical compositions are:

- Dəggʷa (**ድጓ**): The main collection of hymns for the entire church year. Getatchew Haile (2017, p. 270), citing Taddesse Tamrat (1985), notes that while tradition attributes the Dəggʷa to St. Yared, it is likely "not the work of one single individual or the product of a single period" but a cumulative corpus built upon Yared's foundational genius.
- Ṣomä Dəggʷa (**ጾመ ድጓ**): Hymns specifically for the Great Fast (Lent).
- Məʿəraf (**ምዕራፍ**): Chants for daily prayer, Sabbath, and important feasts.
- Zəmmare (**ዝማሬ**): Chantal responses sung after the Holy Communion (Qurban, **ቁርባን**).
- Mäwasəʾət (**መዋስዕት**): Chants for funeral services and commemorations of the dead.

(Liqä Śəlṭanat Habtä Maryam Wärqnäh, 1965 E.C.). Tradition also specifically attributes to St. Yared the composition of the sublime hymn Aryam (**አርያም**) and famous Marian hymns like Anqäṣä Bərhan (**አንቀጸ ብርሃን** – Gate of Light) following his heavenly vision (Getatchew Haile, 2017, pp. 282-288).

Integral to St. Yared's systematizing achievement was his establishment of the three fundamental melodic modes Gəʿəz (**ግዕዝ**), ʾƎzəl (**ዕዝል**), and Araray (**አራራይ**). Getatchew Haile (2017, pp. 287, 292) discusses traditional accounts that provide symbolic interpretations linking these modes to the Persons of the Holy Trinity. Furthermore, St. Yared developed a sophisticated system of indigenous musical notation using signs (məlkkətočč, **ምልክቶች**) – such as Dəfat (**ድፋት**), Ḥidät (**ሐደት**), Qənat (**ቅናት**), Yəzät (**ይዘት**), Qurṭ (**ቁርጥ**), Č̣ärät (**ጭረት**), Rəkərk (**ርክርክ**), and Därät (**ደረት**) – to indicate melody, rhythm, and vocal inflection (Powne, 1968/1980; Shelemay, 1982).

3.1.3 St. Yared's Expression of Christology through Hymns

St. Yared's hymns are rich Christological statements, profoundly shaping the EOTC's understanding of the Person of Christ.

- Union of Natures (Täwaḥədo, **ተዋሕዶ**): His poetry beautifully articulates the mystery of the Incarnation. For instance, regarding the Eucharist, a hymn in the Dəggʷa expresses the indivisible unity:
  (**ደምረነ ነሀሉ ፥ ምስለ ኵሉሙ ቅዱሳኒከ ። ደምረነ ነሀሉ ፥ ቅድመ ገጽከ ፥ በስብሐት ። ከመ ዝንቱ ጽዋዓ ወይን ፥ ዘቱሶሕ ደምከ ውስቴቱ ፥ አልቦ ዘይክል ሌልዮቶ ፥ ፩ዱ ውእቱ መለኮቱ ።** - "Unite us to be with all Your saints. Unite us to be before Your face in glory. As this cup of wine, in which Your blood is mingled, none can separate its unity, for His Divinity is one.") (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, BD127).
- Eternal Pre-existence and Divine Origin: St. Yared clearly teaches Christ's eternal being: (**ኢኃሠሠ አበ ፥ በዲበ ምድር ፥ ወኢእመ በሰማያት ።** - "He sought neither a father on earth, nor a mother in heaven.")
- Incarnation as God's Act: The Word became flesh is a constant theme: "Qal śəga konä." (**ቃል ሥጋ ኮነ** - "The Word became flesh.") He connects Old Testament prophecies to Christ, interpreting Isaiah 19:1: (**በከመ ይቤ ኢሳይያስ ነቢይ ናሁ ይወርድ እግዚአብሔር ውስተ ግብጽ ተፅዒኖ ዲበ ደመና ቀሊል ደመናሰ ዘይቤ ይእቲኬ ድንግል ዘሐዘለቶ በዘባና ለአማኑኤል** - "As Isaiah the prophet said, 'Behold, the LORD is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt.' The cloud is the Virgin that carried Emmanuel on her back.") (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, BD, 327).

3.1.4 St. Yared's Articulation of Soteriology

For St. Yared, Christology is inseparable from Soteriology. His hymnodic compositions trace God's saving plan.

- Creation and the Fall: Humanity is exalted (**እምኵሉ ዕለት ሰንበተ አክበርከ ፤ እምኵሉ ፍጥረት ፥ ሰብአ ዘአዕበይከ ።** - "From every day You have honored the Sabbath; from all creation, You have exalted humanity.") (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, 143, 147, 160). Adam's transgression brought death, but Christ's redemptive act erases sin (**ዘበልዓ አዳም ውስተ**

ገነት ፥ ክርስቶስ ውእቱ ፥ ደምሰሰ ለነ አበሳነ ፥ እስመ በመስቀሉ ተጋድገ ለነ ፥ ኃጢአተነ ።)

- Salvation through Incarnation: God's mercy was promised (**ወይቤሎ ለአቡነ አዳም ፥ ከመ ያስተርኢ ምሕረትየ በላዕሌከ ፥ እትወለድ እምወለትከ ፥ ወእድኅክ ውስተ መርገብከ ፥ ወእከውን ሕፃነ በእንቲአከ ።**) The birth of Christ is the climax (**ተወልደ በተድላ መለኮት ብሑተ ልደት እማርያም እም ቅድስት ድንግል**) (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, BD, 186, 188, 189). Christ came to redeem (**ርእይዎ ኖሎት... ተወልደ ወመጽአ ኀቤነ ፤ ወለብሰ ሥጋነ ፥ ከመ ይቤዙ ወያድኅን ዓለመ**...) (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, BD, 205). His descent into Hades (Siʾol, **ሲኦል**) is key (**እስመ በእንቲአከ**... **ወረድኩ ውስተ ሲኦል**...) (St. Yared, Dəggʷa, BD, 307, 219).
- Salvation through His Crucifixion and Precious Blood: The Cross is central. Through Christ's voluntary suffering, eternal life is offered (**እስመ ከፈለነ ሕይወተ ዚአሁ ወአብአነ ውስተ ፍሥሐሁ**). St. Yared emphasizes the unique, redemptive power of Christ's blood (Zəmmare, BZM, 163-164).
- Salvation through the Sacraments: Baptism (ṭəmqät, **ጥምቀት**) and the Eucharist (Qurban, **ቁርባን**) are essential. (**ክርስቶስ ተጠምቀ ፥ ወለደነ ዳግመ ፥ እማይ ወእመንፈስ ቅዱስ ።**)

3.1.5 St. Yared's Enduring Patristic Significance from His Creative Output

The legacy of St. Yared has had an immeasurable and enduring impact. He gave the Church its distinctive liturgical voice, a Zema that is uniquely Ethiopian (Shelemay, 1982) and a primary vehicle of theology. His hymns articulate faith's mysteries, shaping the nation's spiritual consciousness. His liturgical compositions laid groundwork for Qəne (**ቅኔ**) (Teshome Zerihun, 2006). His veneration (Sənkəssar, Gənbot 11) underscores his patristic stature. The Yaredic heritage, a living tradition (ḥəyaw təwəfit, **ሕያው ትውፊት**), was further developed by later Fathers and schools of Zema (Liqä Śəlṭanat Habtä Maryam Wärqnäh, 1963 E.C.).

3.2 Patristic Themes in the Zagwe Era

Following the Aksumite period, the Zagwe dynasty (c. 10th – 1270 CE) continued the Christian tradition. The paramount Father of this era is Saint Lalibäla (Qəddus Lalibäla, **ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**), the Zagwe king-saint. His enduring "patristic" contribution is not primarily textual but monumental:

the creation of the eleven awe-inspiring rock-hewn churches at Roha (now Lalibäla). This architectural achievement is a profound theological statement, a "New Jerusalem" carved into living stone (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 16).

The churches themselves—like Betä Giyorgis (**ቤተ ጊዮርጊስ**), Betä Maryam (**ቤተ ማርያም**), and Betä Mädhane Aläm (**ቤተ መድኃኔ ዓለም**)—are imbued with theological meaning, a "sermon in stone" representing a unique form of indigenous patristic expression. During this era, literary activity also continued, including translations often from Arabic into Gəᶜəz, and the preservation of sacred texts, including those broadly referred to as ʾƏlatqärfa (**እልአትቀርፋ**) or Täʾammərä Iyäsus (**ተአምረ ኢየሱስ**).

3.3 The Enduring Legacy of Early Indigenous Fathers

The period spanning the later Aksumite era and the Zagwe dynasty was a time when the patristic foundations laid earlier burst forth into a vibrant, uniquely Ethiopian flowering of theological expression and spiritual identity, primarily through the spiritual witness and creative endeavors of St. Yared and St. Lalibäla. St. Yared's divinely inspired Zema became an embodied expression of doctrine and spiritual insight. His creative synthesis of scripture, theology, and uniquely Ethiopian melodic structures is a powerful testament to indigenous patristic genius. The Zagwe era, with St. Lalibäla as its leading patristic figure, demonstrated remarkable continuity in Christian devotion. The rock-hewn churches, his primary legacy, stand as the most stunning embodiment of this era's spiritual and theological passion. What we truly see in the lives and contributions of these Fathers is the Ethiopian Church finding and articulating its own authentic voice. The lasting legacies of St. Yared's Zema and the churches of Lalibäla stand as powerful witnesses, setting the stage for the even richer theological and literary developments of later Ethiopian Fathers.

Review Questions for Chapter Three

1. Explain the traditional understanding of divine inspiration in St. Yared's (Qəddus Yared, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**) composition of Zema (**ዜማ**), and how does Professor Getatchew Haile's research on the Gädlä Yared (**ገድለ ያሬድ**) add nuance to this tradition, including the possible role of Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**)?

2. Describe the three main melodic modes of Yaredic Zema (Gəʿəz, **ግዕዝ**; ʾƎzəl, **ዕዝል**; Araray, **አራራይ**) and briefly discuss one traditional symbolic interpretation of their meaning. What are some of the məlkkətočč (**ምልክቶች**) or notational signs, and their symbolic interpretations (e.g., Dəfat, **ድፋት**; Rəkərk, **ርክርክ**)?
3. Name the five major books of St. Yared's Zema (e.g., Dəggʷa, **ድጓ**; Məʿraf, **ምዕራፍ**) and briefly describe the purpose of one of them. How does Zema function as "sung theology" in the EOTC, conveying doctrines like Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**)?
4. In what ways does the patristic contribution of St. Lalibäla (Qəddus Lalibäla, **ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**), particularly through the rock-hewn churches, differ from that of St. Yared? How do both represent early indigenous Ethiopian patristic voices expressing faith (haymanot, **ሃይማኖት**) and tradition (təwəfit, **ትውፊት**)?
5. Why are figures like St. Yared particularly significant for asserting the value of indigenous African Christian theological and artistic creativity, especially in the context of Zema and the Yaredic tradition (Yaredawi Zema, **ያሬዳዊ ዜማ**)?

Chapter Four

4 Monastic Theologians and Literature

Chapter Objectives

- To describe the context of the "Solomonic Restoration" under Emperor Yəkunno Amlak (**ይኩኖ አምላክ**) and its implications for a renewal in patristic activity, focusing on the theological significance of the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**) and the role of rulers like Emperor Amdä Ṣəyon (**አፄ ዓምደ ጽዮን**) in patronizing the Church and its scholarly figures.
- To examine in detail the lives, theological legacies, and enduring institutional contributions of key monastic Fathers (**አባቶች መነኰሳት**) of the early Solomonic era:
    - Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**), focusing on his foundational role in establishing the Däbrä Hayq (**ደብረ ሃይቅ**) school of learning.
    - Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), detailing his impact through ascetic theology, evangelization, and the founding of the Däbrä Libanos (**ደብረ ሊባኖስ**) tradition.
    - Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**), analyzing his advocacy for Sabbath (Sänbät, **ሰንበት**) observance and the impact of his movement.
- To highlight the crucial literary activity of figures like Abba Sälama "the Translator" (**ሰላማ መተርጉም**) and the theological influence of the office of the ʾAqabe Säᶜat (**ዐቃቤ ሰዓት**) in enriching Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) patristic literature and consolidating Orthodox doctrine (Rətuᶜa Haymanot, **ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**), including the compilation of the Rətuᶜa Haymanot Compendium.
- To characterize the overall maturation of Gəᶜəz patristic literature through the specific contributions of these revered teachers.
- To provide a concluding reflection on the key patristic developments shaped by the spiritual journeys and scholarly endeavors of the Fathers of the early Solomonic period.

The year 1270 AD marks a pivotal transition in Ethiopian history and, consequently, in the trajectory of its patristic development. The Zagwe dynasty, whose spiritual leaders like St.

Lalibäla (**ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**) had left indelible marks of faith in stone (as discussed in Chapter Three), gave way to what historians term the "Solomonic Restoration" under Emperor Yəkunno Amlak (**ይኩኖ አምላክ**). This was more than a mere dynastic shift; it ushered in a period of renewed spiritual vigor, significant monastic expansion, and a remarkable maturation of indigenous Gəʿəz (**ግዕዝ**) patristic literature.

The Fathers of this era, building upon the foundations laid in Aksum and enriched by centuries of lived Christian experience, embarked on new theological reflections, institutional organization, and literary productions that would profoundly shape the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (EOTC). This chapter will focus on the lives and influential contributions of these key monastic theologians and literary figures, exploring how they deepened the Church's understanding of its faith and expanded its spiritual and intellectual treasury.

4.1 Patristic Renewal and the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**)

The newly established Solomonic dynasty ardently promoted its claim of direct descent from the biblical King Solomon (**ንጉሥ ሰሎሞን**) and Makeda, the Queen of Sheba (**ንግሥተ ሳባ**). This claim received its most profound theological and literary articulation in the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት** – "The Glory of Kings"). This foundational text, which achieved its definitive Gəʿəz form around this time (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 18), was far more than a national epic; it was a patristic composition that functioned as a theological and political charter. It deeply shaped Ethiopia's national identity, fostering a self-understanding as a new Israel, a chosen people with a sacred destiny (Levine, 1974; Ullendorff, 1968).

The Kəbrä Nägäśt itself can be seen as a product of the patristic mindset of the era, articulating a theology of divine election, covenant (kidan, **ኪዳን**), and the sanctity of the Ethiopian Christian kingdom, with the Ark of the Covenant (Tabotä Kidan, **ታቦተ ኪዳን**) at its spiritual heart.

The reign of Emperor Amdä Ṣəyon (**አፄ ዓምደ ጽዮን**, r. 1314-1344), Yəkunno Amlak's grandson, was particularly instrumental in promoting this Solomonic ideology and fostering an environment conducive to patristic activity (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 19). The early Solomonic period, stretching to the close of the 14th century, thus ignited a new era of intense spiritual activity. Monastic life (**ሕይወተ ምንኩስና**) flourished, and new spiritual giants emerged, their lives and legacies becoming central to Ethiopian Orthodoxy. Among the literary

compositions written or translated during this era were texts like Wəddase Maryam (**ውዳሴ ማርያም**, Praise of Mary) and Gəbrä Ḥəmamat (**ግብረ ሕማማት**, Rite of Passion Week). Efforts to strengthen Church structure also occurred, with Abunä Yaʿəqob (**አቡነ ያዕቆብ**), a bishop from Egypt, reportedly appointing Filipp̣os of Däbrä Libanos (**ፊሊጶስ ዘደብረሊባኖስ**) to the episcopacy and twelve Nəburanä Ǝd (**ንቡራነ ዕድ** – chief abbots), whose mission was to "irrigate the whole of Ethiopia with the Gospel" (Dəyaqon Sälamon Yoḥanəs, 2010 E.C.). The patristic figures of this era—monks (**መነኰሳት**), ascetics and scholars (liqawənt, **ሊቃውንት**)—actively engaged with the inherited faith through their teachings, writings, and institutional endeavors.

4.2 Key Monastic Fathers and Their Theological Legacies

The early Solomonic period is particularly distinguished by the lives and achievements of key monastic Fathers who founded or revitalized influential spiritual and intellectual traditions.

4.2.1 Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and His Activity at Däbrä Hayq (**ደብረ ሃይቅ**)

Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) (d. c. 1292) stands as a towering monastic Father whose influence bridged the Zagwe and Solomonic periods. While he may not have left an extensive corpus of original written treatises, his patristic contribution is immense, primarily realized through his visionary monastic founding, his spiritual guidance, and his profound impact on the shaping of monastic learning (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, pp. 156-160).

- Life and Monastic Foundation: Born in Lasta, Abba Iyäsus Mo'a studied at the ancient monastery of Däbrä Damo under Abba Yohanni, thus connecting his spiritual lineage back to the Nine Saints (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 29). Around 1248, he undertook the significant task of establishing a school at Lake Hayq, which rapidly developed into Däbrä Hayq Istifanos (**ደብረ ሃይቅ እስጢፋኖስ** – St. Stephen's of Lake Hayq). This monastery became "very famous as the first center of higher Christian education south of Lasta" (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 29).
- Däbrä Hayq as a Center of Learning: Däbrä Hayq, under Abba Iyäsus Mo'a's leadership, became a powerhouse for spiritual life, advanced theological learning, strict ascetic discipline (ṣənuʿ täbaḥtəwo, **ጽኑዕ ተባሕትዎ**), and manuscript production. Known as an "outstanding calligraphist," Abba Iyäsus Mo'a's dedication to the preservation of the

written tradition was itself a core patristic activity. The monastery served as a "spiritual nursery" for many subsequent monastic leaders, most notably Abunä Täklä Haymanot (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, p. 161).

- The Office of the ʾAqabe Säᶜat (**ዐቃቤ ሰዓት**): Däbrä Hayq also gained political and ecclesiastical importance through the office of the ʾAqabe Säᶜat (**ዐቃቤ ሰዓት** – "Keeper of the Hour/Time"), a high-ranking abbot, often from Däbrä Hayq, who advised the emperor on spiritual matters and oversaw the imperial clergy. Tradition links the prominence of this office to Abba Iyäsus Mo'a's close relationship with Emperor Yəkunno Amlak (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, p. 158). Successive ʾAqabe Säᶜatat from Däbrä Hayq, such as Säräqä Bərhan (**ሠረቀ ብርሃን**) and Yosef (**ዮሴፍ**), continued the work of patristic enrichment by overseeing translations of dərsanat (**ድርሳናት**, homilies) and Gädlät, contributing to the tərgʷame (**ትርጓሜ**, interpretation) of sacred texts. Thus, Abba Iyäsus Mo'a's primary legacy was the creation of a vibrant monastic community and a tradition of learning that had a lasting impact on Ethiopian Orthodoxy.

4.2.2 Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**)

Perhaps no Ethiopian saint is more widely known or deeply venerated than Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት** – "Our Father, Plant of Faith," c. 1215-1313 AD). An undisputed pillar of Ethiopian Orthodox spirituality and an outstanding pupil of Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, p. 160; Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 30), his life and spiritual influence have profoundly shaped the Church.

- Life and the Gädlä Täklä Haymanot (**ገድለ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) as a Patristic Text: His life and teachings are primarily transmitted through the Gädlä Täklä Haymanot (**ገድለ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) (Budge, 1906; Conti Rossini, 1896). This Gädl itself functions as a rich patristic text, a composition that profoundly teaches the theology of asceticism (täbaḥtəwo, **ተባሕትዎ**). Accounts of his extraordinary spiritual disciplines—prolonged fasts (ṣom, **ጾም**), unceasing prayer vigils (ṣälot, **ጸሎት**), profound humility (təḥətənna, **ትሕትና**), and rigorous self-mortification (often symbolized by the tradition of him standing in prayer for so long that one leg atrophied)—articulate a deep theological understanding of asceticism as conformity to Christ and a path to spiritual power and holiness.

- Activity as Evangelist and Monastic Founder: Abunä Täklä Haymanot is renowned as a great evangelist (səbəkä wängel, **ስብከተ ወንጌል**), particularly in southern Ethiopia, an endeavor that earned him the title "New Apostle" (Ḥaddis Hawarya, **ሐዲስ ሐዋርያ**) (Teshome Zerihun, 2006). His most lasting institutional achievement was the founding of Däbrä Libanos (**ደብረ ሊባኖስ**) in Shoa. This monastery became a "mother-house" for a vast monastic network and "one of the most important religious centers of Christian Ethiopia" (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 30). The head of Däbrä Libanos, the Ǝčč̣äge (**እጨጌ**), eventually became the highest-ranking Ethiopian-born church official, demonstrating Abunä Täklä Haymanot's enduring patristic impact through the institution he founded. His life and spiritual example solidified a model of sanctity that combined intense asceticism with widespread missionary zeal.

4.2.3 Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) and His Advocacy

Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ** – Eustathius, c. 1273-1352) is another significant monastic Father whose ministry centered on a major theological and disciplinary controversy (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, pp. 206-230).

- Life and Advocacy for Sabbath Observance: Abba Ewosṭatewos's primary theological legacy revolves around his staunch advocacy for observing both Saturday (Qädamit Sänbät, **ቀዳሚት ሰንበት** – the first Sabbath) and Sunday (Sänbätä Krəstiyan, **ሰንበተ ክርስቲያን** – the Christian Sabbath) as holy days. His efforts in this regard involved articulating arguments based on his understanding of Holy Scripture and apostolic tradition, possibly drawing from canonical collections like the Sənodos (**ሲኖዶስ**).
- The Ewostatean Movement (Betä Ewosṭatewos, **ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**): Despite opposition from the Egyptian Abun (**አቡን**, metropolitan) and other church leaders who viewed his teaching as "Judaizing" (kämä Ayhud **ከመ አይሁድ** – "living like the Jews"), Abba Ewosṭatewos remained unwavering in his convictions, even enduring a fourteen-year self-exile (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 30). His disciples formed the influential "House of Ewosṭatewos" (Betä Ewosṭatewos, **ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**), a monastic confederation that became particularly strong in northern Ethiopia and Eritrea. The Sabbath controversy initiated by his advocacy would remain a major theological debate, engaging many Fathers, until its eventual resolution under Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob in the following

century. His life demonstrates a Father willing to endure hardship for what he believed to be scripturally mandated truth.

4.3 Maturing Gəᶜəz Patristic Literature

This era witnessed the continued maturation of Gəᶜəz as a sophisticated language for theological expression, fueled by the flourishing monastic schools established or influenced by Fathers like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a and Abunä Täklä Haymanot (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, pp. 31-33). A pivotal figure in the literary activity of this period was Abba Sälama "the Translator" (Sälama Mätərgʷəm, **ሰላማ መተርጉም**).

4.3.1 The Literary Contribution of Abba Sälama "the Translator" (**ሰላማ መተርጉም**)

Distinct from the first bishop, this Ethiopian scholar, who became metropolitan around 1348 (d. 1388), is renowned for his monumental translation of a vast body of Christian literature from Arabic into Gəᶜəz. This endeavor involved careful selection of texts, skilled adaptation to the Ethiopian context, and the further development of Gəᶜəz theological vocabulary. Among the significant texts translated or revised under his impetus, forming a core part of his patristic contribution, were:

- Haymanotä Abäw (**ሃይማኖተ አበው** - Faith of the Fathers): Significant portions of this vital compendium of patristic writings were translated, providing Ethiopian scholars with direct Gəᶜəz access to the teachings of universal Church Fathers like Athanasius, Cyril, Chrysostom, and Gregory. This translation became a cornerstone for theological education and the articulation of Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት** – Correct Faith).
- Gädlä Qəddusan wäSämaᶜətat (**ገድለ ቅዱሳን ወሰማዕታት** – Acts of Saints and Martyrs): The translation of hagiographies further enriched Ethiopian devotional life and provided models of sanctity.
- Marian Literature: Works like Nägärä Maryam (**ነገረ ማርያም** – Story of Mary) were translated, fostering Marian piety.
- Other Patristic and Ascetic Texts: His translation activity also included texts like Filkəsyus (**ፊልክስዩስ** – Philoxenus) and the Gəbrä Ḥəmamat (**ግብረ ሕማማት** – Passion Week Lectionary).

Abba Sälama the Translator's efforts were crucial for connecting the Ethiopian Church to the broader currents of Orthodox thought while simultaneously fostering an increasingly rich indigenous intellectual and literary tradition.

4.3.2 The "Rətuʿa Haymanot (ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት)"

The term Rətuʿa Haymanot (**ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት** – Orthodox Faith/The Orthodox One) is significant, functioning both as an epithet for orthodox Fathers and as a pen name. Scholarly analysis points to a significant compilation assembled around 1375 AD by a scholar (or group of scholars) using this pen name. The Rətuʿa Haymanot Compendium became a cornerstone for theological instruction, particularly on the Incarnation (bäʾəntä täwaḥədo, **በእንተ ተዋሕዶ** – concerning the Union) (Getatchew Haile, EAe). This literary work included homilies like (**ዘይትነበብ በቀበላ ጾም** – Read on the Eve of the Fast) and discourses on the Incarnation. Notably, this compendium contained a teaching on post-mortem penance (**ይሁብዎ ንስሐ በውስተ ገሃነም መጠነ ምግባሩ ወእምዝ ይድኅን** – "they will give him penance in Hell according to the measure of his deeds, and then he will be saved") (Getatchew Haile, 2020), reflecting beliefs associated with täzkar (**ተዝካር** – memorial prayers/feasts). This compiled text exemplifies a conscious movement by the Fathers of this era to consolidate and disseminate "Orthodox Faith" (Mäməhər TäsfaMikaʾel Takälä, 2004 E.C.).

4.4 The Enduring Legacies of Early Solomonic Fathers

The early Solomonic era (c. 1270 – c. 1400) was a period of vibrant spiritual renewal and significant patristic activity, largely driven by the spiritual examples and contributions of its monastic Fathers. Figures like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a, Abunä Täklä Haymanot, and Abba Ewosṭatewos established powerful spiritual, institutional, and intellectual lineages through their dedicated endeavors. The imperial court, through emperors like Amdä Ṣəyon and influential offices like the ʾAqabe Säʿat, played a crucial role in promoting patristic literature and forging a distinct national-religious identity, most notably through the Kəbrä Nägäśt. Critically, the translation projects spearheaded by Fathers like Abba Sälama the Translator, and the compilation efforts represented by the Rətuʿa Haymanot compendium, enriched the Church immeasurably with vital patristic texts.

This period witnessed Gəʿəz literary theology truly coming into its own, with original poetic masterpieces and a fresh wave of translations ensuring the EOTC remained dynamically connected to wider Christian thought while simultaneously developing its unique, indigenous patristic heritage. These Fathers—through their legacies as monastic founders, ascetics, evangelists, defenders of doctrine, literary theologians, and translators—all contributed immensely to a deeper understanding of the faith, expanded its reach, and produced a rich body of texts and traditions (təwfit, **ትውፊት**) that continue to nourish the Church. They built solidly on Aksumite foundations and meticulously prepared the fertile ground, through their lives and diverse contributions, for the even more intense theological systematization of the 15th century—the era of Abba Giyorgis and Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob.

Review Questions for Chapter Four

1. Explain the significance of the "Solomonic Restoration" for Ethiopian patristic renewal. How did the Kəbrä Nägäśt (**ክብረ ነገሥት**) and Emperor Amdä Ṣəyon's (**አፄ ዓምደ ጽዮን**) efforts, including the appointment of Nəburanä Ǝd (**ንቡራኔ ዕድ**), contribute to this?
2. Describe the patristic legacy of Abba Iyäsus Moʾa (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and the Däbrä Hayq (**ደብረ ሃይቅ**) school. What was the significance of the office of the ʾAqabe Säʿat (**ዐቃቤ ሰዓት**) in this context?
3. Discuss Abunä Täklä Haymanot's (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**) contribution in terms of ascetic theology (täbaḥtəwo, **ተባሕትዎ**) and evangelization (**ስብከተ ወንጌል**). What is the importance of Däbrä Libanos (**ደብረ ሊባኖስ**) and the office of the Ǝčč̣äge (**እጨጌ**)?
4. What was the central theological argument of Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) concerning Sänbät (**ሰንበት**), and what was the long-term impact of the Betä Ewosṭatewos (**ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**)?
5. Explain the importance of Abba Sälama "the Translator" (Sälama Mätərgʷəm, **ሰላማ መተርጉም**), referencing his translation of works like the Haymanotä Abäw (**ሃይማኖተ አበው**), Gädlä Sämaʿətat (**ገድለ ሰማዕታት**), and Filkəsyus (**ፊልክስዩስ**). How did his efforts contribute to the development of Ethiopian patristic thought and the articulation of Rətuʿa Haymanot (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**)? What is the significance of the "Rətuʿa Haymanot" compendium?

Chapter Five

5 Climax of Medieval Patristics

Chapter Objectives

- To characterize the 15th and early 16th centuries as a high point of indigenous Ethiopian theological writing and patristic systematization, where the spiritual lives and intellectual contributions of the Fathers reached a new level of articulation and influence.
- To examine in detail the life, intellectual formation, and major theological compositions of Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘሰግላ/ጋሥጫ**), particularly his Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir (**መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**) and Arganonä Maryam (**አርጋኖነ ማርያም**), exploring their doctrinal content and articulating his enduring stature as a "Doctor" (Liq, **ሊቅ**) of the Ethiopian Church based on these achievements.
- To analyze in detail the patristic contributions and theological vision of Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) as a theologian-emperor, focusing on the content and impact of his writings like Mäṣḥafä Bərhan (**መጽሐፈ ብርሃን**), and his activity in doctrinal standardization through actions like the Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (**ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**).
- To provide a comprehensive understanding of the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) tradition, its history, methodology (including Yä-Lay Bet, **የላይ ቤት**, and Yä-Tačč Bet, **የታች ቤት**), and its crucial role as the indigenous hermeneutical framework informing the exegetical endeavors of Ethiopian patristic scholars during this period.
- To briefly discuss other notable literary and liturgical compositions of this era, such as Maḥəletä Ṣəge (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ**) and various Mälkəʾ (**መልክዕ**) compositions, as expressions of this patristic flourishing.
- To offer a defining reflection on the key characteristics, achievements, and enduring legacy of medieval Ethiopian patristic thought, as revealed through the spiritual witness and scholarly output of its Fathers, emphasizing its unique contributions from a decolonizing perspective.

The 15th century, an era stretching into the early decades of the 16th, stands as a veritable zenith, a true high-water mark in the long and distinguished narrative of medieval Ethiopian patristic thought. This was not merely a continuation of what came before; it was an intensification, a remarkable flourishing of original theological writing and a significant impulse towards patristic systematization, all embodied in the lives and monumental contributions of the Fathers of this period. The intellectual and spiritual groundwork meticulously laid in the preceding centuries by earlier patristic figures—their translations, liturgical innovations, and monastic fervor (as explored in Chapters Two, Three, and Four)—now bore extraordinary, mature fruit. The Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (**የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**), having spent generations absorbing, translating, and profoundly indigenizing Christian tradition through the endeavors of its scholars, now produced thinkers whose own literary and theological legacies articulated the Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት** - Orthodox Faith) with unparalleled confidence, rigorous intellectual depth, and penetrating spiritual insight. These compositions, it must be stressed, were not mere echoes of foreign learning; they were deeply imbued with Ethiopia's unique cultural ethos (baḥəlawi mannənät, **ባሕላዊ ማንነት**) and historical experience, yet they grappled courageously with universal Christian verities, thereby adding a distinct and invaluable voice to the global symphony of patristic expression.

5.1 The Synergy of Monastic and Imperial Patristic Activity

What truly defines this epoch as an apex is the extraordinary synergy that developed between profound monastic scholarship and an assertive imperial theological engagement. On one hand, the monastic schools (ʾabəyatä təmhərt, **አብያተ ትምህርት**), with lineages tracing back to Fathers like Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), had cultivated a deep tradition of sacred learning. This dedicated cultivation culminated in intellectual giants such as Abba Giyorgis of Gasəççˀa (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**), whose theological acumen and sheer literary output were almost unparalleled. On the other hand, the imperial throne (zufanä mängəśt, **ዙፋነ መንግሥት**) itself, especially under the formidable theologian-king Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**), became an active force in shaping the Church's doctrinal (təmhərtä haymanot, **ትምህርተ ሃይማኖት**) and liturgical life (śərᶜatä qəddase, **ሥርዓተ ቅዳሴ**) through his own theological compositions and conciliar actions. The royal court (däğğ,

ደጅ) transformed into a vibrant center for theological debate and the patronage of religious literature. This potent interplay spurred the production of comprehensive systematic theological treatises, elegant Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) poetry, and decisive imperial interventions, all constituting significant patristic achievements that defined a mature Ethiopian Orthodox voice.

5.2 Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘሰግላ/ጋሥጫ**)

Among the luminous constellation of minds that brilliantly defined the 15th century, Abba Giyorgis of Sägla, also known as Giyorgis of Gasəčča (Abba Giyorgis zäGasəčča/Sägla, **አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ/ሰግላ**) (c. 1365 – 1425 CE) (Abba Hiruie Ermias, 2024, p. x; Bantu, 2024), shines forth as an intellectual and spiritual colossus. His life was dedicated to profound learning and the production of extensive literary compositions that represent a pinnacle of Ethiopian patristic thought.

5.2.1 His Life, Intellectual Formation, and Contribution as Mämhər (**መምህር**)

Born to noble parents, Hizbe Sion (**ሕዝበ ጽዮን**) and Emne Sion (**እምነ ጽዮን**) (Bantu, 2024), Abba Giyorgis's initial church education (təmhərt, **ትምህርት**) began under his father. After early struggles, he was entrusted to the renowned monastic center of Däbrä Hayq Istifanos Gädam (**ደብረ ሃይቅ እስጢፋኖስ ገዳም**) (Bantu, 2024). Through prayer (ṣälot, **ጸሎት**) and, as tradition holds, the intervention of the Holy Virgin Mary (Qəddəst Dəngəl Maryam, **ቅድስት ድንግል ማርያም**), he was granted extraordinary intellectual gifts (həbätä ṭəbäb, **ሀብተ ጥበብ**) (Bantu, 2024). This rigorous grounding in Scriptures, Gəᶜəz philology, liturgical traditions, the translated contributions of earlier Fathers (especially the Haymanotä Abäw, **ሃይማኖተ አበው**), and the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) method shaped him into a formidable scholar (Sergew, 1975, p. 17).
His erudition led him to the imperial court of Emperor Dawit I (**ዳግማዊ ዳዊት**), where his activity included serving as chaplain and tutor to the royal princes, notably the future Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (Bantu, 2024). He became a celebrated Mämhər (**መምህር** – authoritative teacher), and later served as Nəburä Ǝd (**ንቡረ እድ** – Chief Abbot) of Däbrä Damo (Bantu, 2024).

5.2.2 Major Theological Compositions of Abba Giyorgis

Abba Giyorgis's literary output is vast, marked by theological sophistication, scriptural depth, poetic skill, and fervent devotion. These writings became foundational for Ethiopian Orthodoxy.

- Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir (**መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር** – "Book of Mystery"): His capstone composition (completed 1424 CE) is a comprehensive systematic theology and powerful apologetic (Dickinson, 2020, p. 1; Abba Hiruie Ermias, 2024). In thirty discourses, Abba Giyorgis expounds core Orthodox doctrines (Trinity, Christology) and refutes various theological deviations (Origen, Arius, Nestorius, Eutyches, local views of Bitu, Manichaeism) (Getatchew Haile, n.d.-b, CE:984b). His defense of Christ's true humanity against Mani is particularly incisive, employing scriptural proofs like Luke 24:39 ("ʾAnä śəga wäᶜaṣəm bəyä," **አንሰ ፥ ሥጋ ፥ ወዓፅም ፥ ብየ ፥** - "I indeed have flesh and bone") (Dickinson, 2020, p. 4). This text also offers profound Mariology, defending traditional understandings like Christ's conception through the ear (Dickinson, 2020, p. 5).
- Arganonä Maryam (**አርጋኖነ ማርያም** – "Harp/Organ of Mary"): This collection of hymns is a pinnacle of Ethiopian Marian devotional literature and poetic theology (Leander, 1922; Sergew, 1975, p. 23). Organized for daily praise, this work is celebrated for its rich symbolism and profound meditation on the Virgin Mary's role in salvation.
- Saᶜatat (**ሰዓታት** – "The Hours"): This liturgical contribution involved Abba Giyorgis adapting and expanding the Coptic liturgical hours to include indigenous Ethiopian saints, thus shaping the Church's prayer life (Bantu, 2024).
- Fəkare Haymanot (**ፍካሬ ሃይማኖት** - "Exposition of Faith"): A treatise written to explain and defend Orthodox doctrine (Rətuᶜa Haymanot), highly esteemed by his contemporaries (Getatchew Haile, 2012).
- Mäṣḥafä Dəngəl Ḥəywätä Maryam (**መጽሐፈ ድንግል ሕይወተ ማርያም** – "Book of the Virgin, Life of Mary"): Also known as Mäzmurä Dəngəl (**መዝሙረ ድንግል** – Psalm of the Virgin), this text is a theological poem detailing Mary's life, patterned after biblical poetic structures.
- Other Hymnodic and Liturgical Compositions: His prolific output includes Mäṣḥafä Səbḥat (**መጽሐፈ ስብሐት** – Book of Praising); Ḥoḫətä Bərhan (**ኖኀተ ብርሃን** – Portal of Light); Wəddase Mäsqäl (**ውዳሴ መስቀል** – Praise of the Cross); an Anaphora (Qəddase

ʾƎgziʾ zäʾAbba Giyorgis, **ቅዳሴ እግዚእ ዘአባ ጊዮርጊስ**); and numerous other prayers and praises (EOTC Keraneyo, 2022; Behailu, 2024).

The literary environment of the 15th century, which saw the translation of the Sənkəssar (**ስንክሳር**) and the Gəbrä Ḥəmamat (**ግብረ ሕማማት**), provided a fertile ground for such patristic compositions (Behailu, 2024).

5.2.3 Abba Giyorgis's Enduring Patristic Stature from His Writings

Abba Giyorgis's position as a foremost Ethiopian Church Father is unassailable. His systematic articulation of doctrine in Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir, his liturgical innovations in Saᶜatat, and the devotional theology of Arganonä Maryam are contributions that provided the EOTC with indigenous theological landmarks. He skillfully defended Täwaḥədo faith and the honor of St. Mary (ʾƎgəzʾətənä Maryam, **እግዝእትነ ማርያም**) (Sergew, 1975, p. 26). His writings became canonical texts, cementing his status as a preeminent "Doctor" of the Ethiopian Church.

5.3 Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**)

Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) (r. 1434-1468) was not only a powerful ruler but also a deeply committed theologian, whose own writings and conciliar activities constitute a significant chapter in Ethiopian patristic history (Dickinson, 2017, p. ii). His reign was characterized by an intense effort to unify the Church doctrinally and liturgically through his authoritative pronouncements and compositions.

5.3.1 Theological Vision and Writings as Patristic Texts

Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob possessed a powerful vision for a unified Ethiopian Christian empire, cohesive in faith (haymanot, **ሃይማኖት**) and uniform in practice (śərᶜat, **ሥርዓት**) (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, p. 221). He actively worked to suppress "pagan" survivals and magical practices (mətəḥat, **ምትሐት**) by promoting and authoring orthodox teachings. His writings served as official statements of doctrine:

- Mäṣḥafä Bərhan (**መጽሐፈ ብርሃን** – "Book of Light"): Arguably his most comprehensive theological composition, a collection of homilies (dərsanat, **ድርሳናት**) designed to instruct and reform (Conti Rossini & Ricci, 1964-1965). It expounds on Sabbath

observance, Marian devotion, veneration of icons and the Cross, and critiques magic (Dickinson, 2017, p. 11).

- Mäṣḥafä Milad (**መጽሐፈ ሚላድ** – "Book of Nativity") and Mäṣḥafä Śəllase (**መጽሐፈ ሥላሴ** – "Book of the Trinity"): Homiletic treatises on the Nativity and Trinitarian theology, containing polemics against groups like the Stephanites (Dickinson, 2017, p. 12; Wendt, 1962-1963).
- Ṭomarä Təsbʾət (**ጦማረ ትስብእት** – "Epistle of Humanity/Incarnation"): A Christological text affirming Täwaḥədo doctrine and refuting diviners (Dickinson, 2017, p. 10).
- Marian Compositions: His devotion to Mary led to the expansion of the Täʾammərä Maryam (**ተአምረ ማርያም** – Miracles of Mary) and the composition or commissioning of numerous hymns, possibly including Mälkəʾa Maryam (**መልክአ ማርያም**) types.
- Other Polemical and Liturgical Texts: These include Kəḥdätä Säyṭan (**ክህደተ ሰይጣን** – Abjuration of Satan), Mäṣḥafä Baḥrəy (**መጽሐፈ ባሕርይ** – Book of the Pearl/Essence), and the hymnal ʾƎgziʾabəḥer Nägśä (**እግዚአብሔር ነግሠ** – God has Reigned) (Dickinson, 2017, pp. 12-13). Other attributed writings include Täʿaqəbo Məśṭir (**ተዐቅቦ ምሥጢር**) and Mängädä Sämay (**መንገደ ሰማይ**) (Behailu, 2024).

These imperial compositions are patristic due to their theological content and their intent to teach and unify the Church.

5.3.2 Flourishing of Qəne (ቅኔ) and Other Literary Compositions

While Zärʾa Yaʿəqob's writings dominated, the 15th century also saw the flourishing of Qəne (**ቅኔ** – sacred poetry) and other literary compositions. Arkä Śəllus (**አርከ ሥሉስ**), a traditional disciple of Abba Giyorgis, is associated with the Arke (**አርኬ**) poetic style and a collection of ʾƎgziʾabəḥer Nägśä hymns (Habtemichael Kidane, EAE). Abba Giyorgis himself is credited with a distinct ʾƎgziʾabəḥer Nägśä collection (Habtemichael Kidane, EAE). Other notable texts include:

- Maḥəletä Ṣəge (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ** – Canticle of the Flower/Rose): A beloved Marian hymn cycle, traditionally attributed to Abba Ṣəge Bərhan (**አባ ጽጌ ብርሃን**) and Abba Gäbrä Maryam (**አባ ገብረ ማርያም**) (Behailu, 2024 unpublished Module T.E.F.).
- Mäṣḥafä Qeder (**መጽሐፈ ቂዶር** – Book of Absolution/Purification): A translated ritual book (Behailu, 2024 unpublished Module T.E.F.).

- Mälkəʾ (**መልክዕ** – Image/Portrait) Poetry: This genre, with hymns like Mälkəʾa Maryam (**መልክአ ማርያም**), saw significant development (Dawit Girma, 2019, p. 3).

5.3.3 Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (**ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**)

Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob's most decisive act in doctrinal standardization was convening the Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (**ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**) around 1450 CE (Taddesse Tamrat, 1972, pp. 230-231). This council officially resolved the Sabbath controversy, endorsing the observance of both Saturday and Sunday, thus unifying the "House of Ewosṭatewos" (Betä Ewosṭatewos, **ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) with the main body of the Church (Dickinson, 2017, pp. 5-6). He also used his authority to deal with the Stephanites (Däqiqä ʾƎsṭifanos, **ደቂቀ እስጢፋኖስ**), who rejected certain imperial and Marian prostrations (Heldman, n.d). Through these conciliar and polemical activities, Zärʾa Yaʿəqob actively shaped the doctrinal landscape.

5.4 The Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) Tradition

The profound theological compositions of the 15th-century Fathers were deeply rooted in Ethiopia's unique system of exegetical commentary, the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) tradition. This indigenous hermeneutical approach, the collective achievement of generations of teaching Fathers, provided the intellectual framework for their scholarship (Mersha Alehegne, 2003). The Amharic word Andəmta means "one says," signifying the presentation of various layers of traditional explanations for a Gəʿəz text (Cowley, 1988). It explores literal/historical (nəbab, **ንባብ**), allegorical/mystical (məsṭərawi tərgʷame, **ምሥጢራዊ ትርጓሜ**), theological/dogmatic (haymanotawi tərgʷame, **ሃይማኖታዊ ትርጓሜ**), and moral/practical (śərʿatawi tərgʷame, **ሥርዓታዊ ትርጓሜ**) meanings. It relies heavily on tradition (təwəfit, **ትውፊት**), often employing a question-and-answer format with illustrative stories (tarik, **ታሪክ**) and scriptural cross-references (ṭəqs, **ጥቅስ**) (Mersha Alehegne, 2003).

During the 15th century, this well-developed Andəmta tradition was the primary intellectual tool for Fathers like Abba Giyorgis and the scholars surrounding Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob. Their treatises, homilies, and poetry were deeply informed by Andəmta's methods. The scholars, often described as "four-eyed" (ʾarat ʿayna, **አራት ዓይና**) for their ability to perceive multiple layers of meaning, utilized this method to make ancient truths relevant and defend the Rətuʿa Haymanot.

The sophisticated teaching system of the Qes Təmhərt Bet, particularly the Mäṣaḥəft Bet (**መጻሕፍት ቤት** - House of Books) where Andəmta was mastered, ensured the transmission of this vital hermeneutical framework.

5.5 Defining Medieval Ethiopian Patristic Contributions

The 15th century, extending into the early 16th under Emperor Ləbnä Dəngəl (**ልብነ ድንግል**) before the wars of Ahmad "Grañ" (**አሕመድ ግራኝ**) (Blatten Geta Həruy Wäldä Śəllase, 1999 EC), unquestionably marks the apex of medieval Ethiopian patristic thought, defined by the profound and original theological compositions of Fathers like Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčča and Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob. Their systematic treatises, sublime devotional poetry, authoritative imperial decrees, and landmark conciliar decisions firmly established a mature, sophisticated, and distinctively Ethiopian Orthodox patristic voice. Literary activity continued under Ləbnä Dəngəl, with compositions attributed to Ras Səmeʾon (**ራስ ስምዖን**) and figures like Abba Ṣəge Bərhan (**አባ ጽጌ ብርሃን**) and Abba Gäbrä Maryam (**አባ ገብረ ማርያም**) (Behailu, 2024 unpublished Module T.E.F.).

This distinct Ethiopian patristic voice, deeply rooted in apostolic tradition yet uniquely shaped by centuries of Ethiopian spiritual experience, articulated with clarity the nuances of Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) faith and Marian doctrines. The intellectual framework of Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) undergirded this flourishing. This period solidified the theological foundations of the EOTC, bequeathing a rich and enduring intellectual and spiritual heritage through the spiritual lives and scholarly achievements of its Fathers, a testament to their wisdom (ṭəbäb, **ጥበብ**) and creative capacity.

Review Questions for Chapter Five

1. Why is the 15th century often considered the "climax" or "high point" of medieval Ethiopian patristic thought? Describe one key dynamic, such as the synergy between monastic scholarship and imperial engagement, that contributed to this flourishing.
2. Discuss the significance of Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘሰግላ/ጋሥጫ**). Examine in some detail two of his major theological works (e.g., Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir, **መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር**; Arganonä Maryam, **አርጋኖነ ማርያም**; Saʿatat,

ሰዓታት), explaining their primary theological contribution (e.g., to Täwaḥədo, **ተዋሕዶ**; Mariology; liturgy, śərʿatä qəddase, **ሥርዓተ ቅዳሴ**).

3. How did Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) function as a "theologian-emperor"? Analyze one of his key writings (e.g., Mäṣḥafä Bərhan, **መጽሐፈ ብርሃን**; or his ʾƎgziʾabəḥer Nägśä, **እግዚአብሔር ነግሠ**, collection) and one of his conciliar actions (e.g., Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq, **ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**), explaining how they demonstrate his patristic role in shaping doctrine (təmhərtä haymanot, **ትምህርተ ሃይማኖት**), combating perceived deviations like magic (mətəḥat, **ምትሐት**), or promoting specific devotions.
4. Briefly describe the nature and purpose of compositions like Maḥəletä Ṣəge (**ማሕሌተ ጽጌ**) or the Mälkəʾ (**መልክዕ**) genre as examples of other notable literary and liturgical contributions from this era, highlighting their theological importance.
5. From a decolonizing perspective, what is the importance of recognizing figures like Abba Giyorgis and Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob, their literary contributions in Gəʿəz (**ግዕዝ**), and the broader intellectual climate of this era in the global history of Christian thought?

Chapter Six

6 Ethiopian Patristic Voices in the Compositions of 16th C. Fathers

Chapter Objectives

- To present in detail the lives, historical contexts, and major theological and literary contributions of key Ethiopian Church Fathers and theologian-rulers of the 16th century, specifically:
    - Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom (**እጫጌ ዕንባቆም**), focusing on his life of conversion and his apologetic treatise, the Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን**).
    - Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዲዮስ**), detailing his life as a confessor-king and his theological testament, the Ṭomarä Gälawdewos (**ጦማረ ገላውዲዮስ**).
    - Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**), exploring his life as a monastic chronicler and poet, and his compositions like Mäzmurä Krəstos (**መዝሙረ ክርስቶስ**).
- To analyze their patristic responses—grounded in Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) scriptural and traditional resources and evident in their specific literary achievements—to the devastating wars of Ahmad Grañ (**አሕመድ ግራኝ**) and the subsequent theological challenges posed by Jesuit missionaries.
- To explore how the writings of these 16th-century Fathers, in defending the Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) faith, established a crucial foundation for understanding subsequent internal doctrinal developments.
- To highlight the decolonizing aspects inherent in the lives and literary output of these Fathers as they articulated and defended an indigenous Ethiopian Orthodox identity against external religious and political pressures.
- To reflect on the enduring legacy of the spiritual journeys and intellectual contributions of these 16th-century Fathers in shaping Ethiopian Orthodox resilience and theological self-understanding.

The intellectual and spiritual efflorescence that so brightly characterized the 15th century in Ethiopia, an era witnessing the monumental achievements of Fathers like Abba Giyorgis of Gasəčč̣a (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**) and Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**) (as discussed in

Chapter Five), was, with tragic swiftness, succeeded by a century of profound and truly existential crisis. The 16th century dawned as an age of unprecedented trial (məkəra, **መከራ**) for the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church and the Christian Solomonic kingdom. Two immense external forces converged upon the land: the ferocious military onslaught led by Ahmad ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi, known in our chronicles as Grañ Mohammed (**ግራኝ መሐመድ** – "the Left-Handed Mohammed"), aimed at the extirpation of Christianity; and, following closely, the arrival of Portuguese Jesuit missionaries, whose initial alliance transformed into a concerted effort to subordinate the ancient Ethiopian Church to the See of Rome.

These dual pressures demanded extraordinary responses. It is within this crucible of existential struggle that the Fathers of this era forged their enduring legacies. Through their courageous personal witness (səmaᶜətənnät, **ሰማዕትነት**), their profound learning, and their articulate defense of the RətuᶜaHaymanot (**ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት** – Right/Orthodox Faith) in their specific compositions, they ensured the survival of Ethiopian Orthodoxy. This chapter explores the lives and, most importantly, the specific literary and theological contributions of three such pivotal 16th-century patristic voices: Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom, Emperor Gälawdewos, and Abba Baḥrəy. Their writings stand as testaments to Ethiopian Orthodox resilience and theological self-articulation.

6.1 Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom (እጨጌ ዕንባቆም)

In the venerable succession of Ethiopian Church Fathers, Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom (**እጨጌ ዕንባቆም**) holds a unique position. His life, marked by a dramatic conversion from Islam, and his seminal apologetic composition, the Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን** – Gate of Faith), are compelling testaments to the transformative power of Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) Christianity.

6.1.1 His Life

Born in Yemen around 1470 as Abu l-Fath, Ǝnbaqom came from a princely family and was initially a Muslim merchant (van Donzel, EAE "Ǝnbaqom"). His journey to Ethiopia around 1489 for trade (Getatchew Haile, 2012, p. 415) led to a profound spiritual transformation. After diligent examination of the Holy Scriptures (Mäṣaḥəft Qəddusat, **መጻሕፍት ቅዱሳት**) and the teachings (təmhərt, **ትምህርት**) of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, he embraced the Täwaḥədo faith. He was tonsured a monk (mänokse, **መነኰሴ**) and, through his piety and learning, rose to

become Abbot (ʾAbä Mənet, **አበምኔት**) of the illustrious Däbrä Libanos (**ደብረ ሊባኖስ**) monastery in 1523, and eventually Ǝčča̱ge (**እጨጌ**), the highest indigenous spiritual leader (van Donzel, EAE "Ǝnbaqom"). His tenure as Ǝčča̱ge coincided with the turmoil of Grañ's invasions. He died around 1560 (van Donzel, EAE "Ǝnbaqom"). His very life journey is a powerful patristic narrative of conversion and dedication.

6.1.2 The Patristic Contribution of Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን** – Gate of Faith)

The most enduring literary and theological achievement of Ǝčča̱ge Ǝnbaqom is his magnum opus, the Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን** – Gate of Faith), authored around 1540. Composed in sacred Gəʿəz (**ግዕዝ**), this treatise is a monumental achievement in Christian apologetics, written to provide an intellectually robust and spiritually grounded response to Islamic polemics.
He commences this profound composition with a solemn invocation to the Holy Trinity (Śəllase, **ሥላሴ**): (**በስመ ፥ እግዚአብሔር ፥ ሥሉስ ፥ ዘኢይትፈለይ ፣ ዕሩየ ፥ መለኮት ፥ ወዕበይ ፥ ዘልዑል ፥ እምሰማይ**... – "In the Name of God, the Trinity that is not separated, Equal in Godhead and Greatness, Who is more exalted than heaven..."). He then invokes divine assistance for writing this book, the "Gate of Faith" (Getatchew Haile, 2012, p. 415).
Throughout this meticulously structured text, Ǝnbaqom systematically defends core Orthodox mysteries (məśṭirat, **ምሥጢራት**): the Trinity, the Incarnation of the Word (Qal, **ቃል**) from the Virgin Mary, the Divine Motherhood of the Wälədəttä ʾAmlak (**ወላዲተ አምላክ** – Mother of God), and the sanctity of the Holy Cross (Mäsqäl, **መስቀል**) (Cerulli, 1958). His apologetic method relies on reasoned argumentation, abundant scriptural proofs (ṭəqsä mäṣḥaf, **ጥቅሰ መጽሐፍ**) from the Gəʿəz Bible, and astute comparative theology, often directly engaging and refuting arguments from the Qur'an (van Donzel, EAE, "Anqäṣä amin"). This composition was intended to fortify the faithful and demonstrate the coherence of Christian revelation.

6.1.3 Other Literary Contributions

Beyond the Anqäṣä Amin, Ǝčča̱ge Ǝnbaqom's literary activity included significant translations (tərgʷame, **ትርጓሜ**) from Arabic into Gəʿəz, vital for enriching Ethiopian Orthodoxy (van Donzel, EAE, "Ǝnbaqom"):

- John Chrysostom’s Commentary on Hebrews (1523): Providing deeper insights into this epistle.
- Bärälam wäYəwasəf (**በረላም ወይዋሴፍ** – Barlaam and Josaphat) (1553): A popular Christianized legend offering moral instruction, translated at the order of Emperor Gälawdewos.
- Chronology of Abu Šakir (Abušakər, **አቡሻክር**): Important for historical understanding.
- The Revelation of St. John (Raʾəyä Yoḥannəs, **ራእየ ዮሐንስ**): Ensuring accessibility of this apocalyptic text.
- Arägawi Mänfäsawi (**አረጋዊ መንፈሳዊ** – Spiritual Elder): An ascetic/mystical text nourishing spiritual life.

These translation endeavors demonstrate Ǝnbaqom's linguistic skills and commitment to making the broader Christian heritage accessible, a significant patristic act.

6.2 Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዴዎስ**)

Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዴዎስ**, r. 1540-1559), son of Emperor Dawit II and Queen Seble Wongel (**ንግሥት ሰብለ ወንጌል**), ascended the throne amidst the devastation of Grañ's wars. His life was one of military leadership, culminating in Grañ's defeat in 1543, and profound theological defense.

6.2.1 His Life as a Defender of Faith and Nation

Gälawdewos faced the monumental task of national and spiritual restoration. The alliance with Portuguese forces, instrumental in military victory, soon brought the challenge of Jesuit missionaries aggressively seeking to bring the Ethiopian Church under Roman dominion (Lule Melaku, 2010). They assailed cherished Ethiopian apostolic traditions such as dietary observances, Sabbath (Sänbät, **ሰንበት**) observance, circumcision (Gəzrät, **ግዝረት**), and the reverence for the Old Testament in liturgy (Qəddase, **ቅዳሴ**).

6.2.2 The Patristic Significance of the Ṭomarä Gälawdewos (ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ)

In this charged atmosphere, Emperor Gälawdewos, a ruler learned in the Haymanotä ʾAbäw (**ሃይማኖተ አበው** – Faith of his Fathers), composed his celebrated Confession around 1555. This text is a patristic masterpiece of clarity and courageous defense.

His Confession begins by unequivocally affirming the core Trinitarian faith and the Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (Ṣälotä Haymanot, **ጸሎተ ሃይማኖት**): (**በስመ አብ ወወልድ ወመንፈስ ቅዱስ አሐዱ አምላክ አሜን ዝንቱ ውእቱ ሃይማኖትየ ወሃይማኖተ አበውየ ነገሥት እስራኤላውያን ወሃይማኖተ መርዔትየ እለ ሀለው በዐፀደ መንግሥትየ** - "In the Name of the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen. This is my faith, and the faith of my fathers, the Israelite kings, and the faith of my flock which is within the fold of my kingdom.")

He then confesses belief in One God; His only-begotten Son, Jesus Christ—His eternal Word (Qalu, **ቃሉ**), Power (Ḫaylu, **ኃይሉ**), Counsel (Məkru, **ምክሩ**), and Wisdom (Ṭəbäbu, **ጥበቡ**)—made man by the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary. He affirms Christ's baptism, crucifixion, resurrection (tənśaʾe, **ትንሣኤ**), ascension (ʿərgät, **ዕርገት**), and second coming (Dagəmä Məṣʾat, **ዳግመ ምጽአት**). Critically, this composition grounds Ethiopian faith in apostolic tradition: (**ንሕነሰ ፡ ነሐውር ፡ በፍኖተ ፡ ንጉሥ ፡ ጽዮሕ ፡ አማናዊ ፡ ወኢናጸንን ፡ ኢለ የማን ፡ ወኢለፀጋም ፡ እምትምህርተ ፡ አበዊነ ፡ ፲ወ፪ሐዋርያት ፡ ወጳውሎ ስ ፡ ፈልፈለ ፡ ጥበብ ፡ ወ፫ወ፪አርድእት ፡ ወ፫፻፲ወ፰ ፡ ርቱዓነ ፡ ሃይማኖት ፡ ዘተጋብኡ ፡ በኒቅያ ፡ ወ፪ወ፱ ፡ በቀ፦ስጥንጥንያ ፡ ወ፪፻በኤፌሶን ።።** - "And we walk in the King's Highway... we turn aside from the doctrine of our fathers, the Twelve Apostles; and of Paul... and of the three-hundred and eighteen Orthodox [Fathers]... Nicaea... Constantinople... Ephesus.")

This text situated Ethiopian Orthodoxy firmly within the consensus of the first three Ecumenical Councils (gubaʾeyat, **ጉባኤያት**). Gälawdewos astutely defended distinctive Ethiopian Christian practices as national customs (**ልማደ ሀገር**) or apostolic traditions, not Jewish legalism. His Confession is a monumental patristic statement defending indigenous Orthodox identity. He achieved martyrdom in 1559.

- On Sabbath observance: (**ወበእንተ ፡ ምክንያተ ፡ አክብሮትነ ፡ ዕለተ ፡ ቀዳሚት ፡ ሰንበት ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘናከ ብራ ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡ እለ ፡ ሰቀልዎ ፡ ለክርስቶስ ፡… ንሕነ ሰ ፡ ናከብራ ፡ እንዘ ፡ ናዓርግ ፡ ባቲ ፡ቀ፦ርባን ፡ ወንገብር ፡ ባቲ ፡ ምሳሐ ፡ በ ከመ ፡ አዘዙነ ፡ አበዊነ ፡ ሐዋርያት ፡ በዲድስቅልያ ።።** - "Now, with regard to observance of the Original Sabbath

[Saturday], we do not keep it as the Jews do, who crucified Christ... but we keep it, in that we celebrate, thereon, the Lord's Supper, and hold love feasts, as our fathers, [the Apostles], have instructed us, in the Didascalia.")

- Sunday observance: (**አኮ ፡ ዘናከብራ ፡ ከ መ ፡ ሰንበተ ፡ እሑድ ፡ እንተ ፡ ይእቲ ፡ ዕለተ ፡ ሐደስ ፡**… **እስመ ፡ ባቲ ፡ ተንሥአ ፡ እግዚእነ ፡ ኢየሱስ ፡ ክርስቶስ ፡ ወባ ቲ ፡ ወረደ ፡ መንፈስ ፡ ቅዱስ ፡ ላዕለ ፡ ሐዋርያት ፡**… - "We don't observe it as the Sabbath of the first day of the week, [Sunday], which is a new day... because, on it, our Lord Jesus Christ rose again and, on it, the Holy Ghost descended on the Apostles...") Sunday is also affirmed as the day of Incarnation and the future Second Coming.
- On circumcision: (**ወበእንተ ፡ ሥርዓተ ፡ ግዝረትኒ ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘንትገዘር ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡ እስ መ ፡ ንሕነ ፡ ናአምር ፡ ቃለ ፡ ምህሮሁ ፡ ለጳውሎስ ፡**… **ተገዝሮሂ ፡ ኢይበቍዕ ፡ ወኢተገዝሮሂ ፡ ኢያሠልጥ ፡ ዘእንበለ ፡ ዳእ ሙ ፡ ሐደስ ፡ ፍጥረት ፡**… - "Again, concerning the question of circumcision; we are not circumcised as the Jews, because we know the words of the doctrine of Paul... 'Neither is circumcision anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature...'" (Galatians 5:6, 6:15)). He explains it as a national custom (**ወባሕቱ ፡ ግዝረት ሰ ፡ ዘኮነ ፡ በጎቤነ ፡ በልማደ ፡ ሀገር ፡**… **ዘንተሰ ፡ ዘንገብር ፡ አኮ ፡ በዐቂበ ፡ ሕገገ ፡ ኦሪት ፡ ዳእሙ ፡ በልማደ ፡ ሰብእ ።** - "But circumcision, amongst us, is according to the custom of the country... And what we do is not in observance of the Mosaic Law, but according to the custom of men.").
- On dietary laws: (**ወበእንተ ፡ በሊዐ ፡ ሐራውያኒ ፡ አኮ ፡ ዘንትከላእ ፡ በዐቂበ ፡ ሕገገ ፡ ኦሪት ፡ ከመ ፡ አይሁድ ፡**… **ለዘኒ ፡ በልዐ ፡ ኢናስቆርሮ ፡ ወኢናረኵሶ ፡ ወለዘኒ ፡ ኢበ ልዐ ፡ ከመ ፡ ይብላዕ ፡ ኢናጌብሮ ።** - "Finally, with regard to eating the flesh of swine; we are not prohibited from it, as the Jews are, by observance of the Law of Moses... But he who eats thereof, we do not despise or consider unclean; and him who doesn't eat thereof, we do not compel to it."). He frames dietary choices as personal preference: (**ከመዝ ፡ ውእቱ ፡ ሥምረቱ ፡ ወፈቃዱ ፡ ለሰብእ ። በእንተ ፡ መብልዐ ፡ ሥጋ ፡ እንስሳሰ ፡ አልቦ ፡ ሕገ ፡ ወአልቦ ፡ ቀኖና ፡ ውስተ ፡ መጽ ሐፍ ፡ ሐደስ ፡ ኵሉ ፡ ንጹሕ ፡ ለንጹሐን ።** - "This is the good will and pleasure of men. And touching the eating of animal food, there is no law or canon in the New Testament: 'All is clean, to the clean'" (Titus 1:15)).

6.3 Abba Baḥrəy (አባ ባሕርይ)

The latter 16th century also produced Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**), a discerning monastic Father from Gamo. His literary and theological compositions offer a profound patristic lens on a period of dramatic societal transformation.

6.3.1 His Life as an Observer and Interpreter of His Times

Details of Abba Baḥrəy's life are primarily gleaned from his writings. He was a monk who witnessed the profound impact of the Oromo migrations on the Christian kingdom and sought to understand these events theologically.

6.3.2 The Patristic Compositions of Abba Baḥrəy

Professor Getatchew Haile's research has illuminated Abba Baḥrəy's multifaceted patristic legacy (Getatchew Haile, *YeAbba Bahriy Dirsetoch*).

- History of the Oromo Peoples (ca. 1593): While an ethnographic and historical account, this text is imbued with theological reflection. Baḥrəy grappled with why the Christian state was challenged, offering socio-political analysis but also seeking to understand God's providence (fəqadä ʾƎgziʾabḥer, **ፈቃደ እግዚአብሔር**) (Baxter, EAE, "Bahrəy"). This engagement with history through a faith lens is a patristic endeavor.
- Mäzmurä Krəstos (**መዝሙረ ክርስቶስ** – Psalm of Christ): This collection of 151 Gəʿəz hymns (mäzmurat, **መዝሙራት**) is a significant poetic and theological composition. It articulates the Church's faith in Christ, reinforcing Täwaḥədo Christology and the mysteries of salvation through sacred verse.
- Other Poetic and Devotional Texts: His literary output also includes Mäṣḥafä Bərhänat (**መጽሐፈ ብርሃናት** – Book of Lights), Sərhätä Gəbr (**ሥርዓተ ግብር** – Order of Action/Work), Mäṣḥafä Səlamä Qəddusan (**መጽሐፈ ሰላመ ቅዱሳን** - Book of the Peace of the Saints), and Məlkəʿa Gäbrəʾel (**መልክዐ ገብርኤል** - Image of Gabriel). These demonstrate his contribution to the Church's devotional literature and his piety.

Abba Baḥrəy's writings reveal a Father grappling with historical crises through theological reflection and enriching the Church's spiritual life with enduring devotional poetry.

6.4 The Enduring Legacy of the 16th C. Fathers' Contributions

The 16th century was a crucible. The literary and theological compositions of Fathers like Ǝṭṭäge Ǝnbaqom, Emperor Gälawdewos, and Abba Baḥrəy were forged in response to existential threats. Their apologetics, confessions, chronicles, and hymns, all composed in Gəʿəz and drawing deeply from Scripture and tradition, not only defended Ethiopian Orthodoxy but also articulated its core tenets with clarity and conviction.

This intense engagement, particularly the defense against Jesuit dyophysitism, sharpened theological self-awareness. The intellectual tools and refined Gəʿəz theological vocabulary developed in these compositions paradoxically became instrumental in the complex internal doctrinal discussions of the subsequent Gondarine period (Chapter Seven). The 16th-century Fathers, through their lives of steadfast faith and their enduring literary achievements, laid a vital, if complex, foundation for the future trajectory of Ethiopian patristic thought, demonstrating remarkable resilience and intellectual creativity in the face of adversity. Their contributions are a testament to the decolonizing power of indigenous theology asserting its own voice and identity.

Review Questions for Chapter Six

1. Discuss the primary patristic contributions of Ǝṭṭäge Ǝnbaqom through his Anqäṣä Amin (**አንቀጸ አሚን**). How did he use his knowledge of both Christian and Islamic sources to defend the Śəllase (**ሥላሴ**) and the Incarnation of Wäldä Maryam Dəngəl (**ወልደ ማርያም ድንግል**)? What was the significance of his translation work, mentioning specific texts like Bärälam wäYəwasəf (**በረላም ወይዋሴፍ**) or Chrysostom's Commentary?
2. Analyze Emperor Gälawdewos's Confession (Ṭomarä Gälawdewos, **ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ**) as a work of patristic apologetics. How did he use Gəʿəz scriptural arguments and appeals to the early Ecumenical Councils (gubaʾeyat, **ጉባኤያት**) to defend both fundamental beliefs (**ጸሎተ ሃይማኖት**) and specific Ethiopian Christian practices like Sänbät (**ሰንበት**) observance?
3. Describe the key literary compositions of Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**).
4. Explain the importance of the 16th-century literary renaissance, including translations of works like Mäṣḥafä Nəsḥa (**መጽሐፈ ንስሐ**) and the composition of original Gəʿəz

defenses like Mäzgäbä Haymanot (**መዝገበ ሃይማኖት**) by figures such as Nəwayä Mäsqäl (**ንዋየ መስቀል**).

5. From a decolonizing perspective, how did the writings of the 16th-century Ethiopian Fathers serve to assert an indigenous Orthodox identity (ʾItyoṗṗəyawi mannənät, **ኢትዮጵያዊ ማንነት**) and resist external religious pressures?
6. How did the need to defend Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) against external challenges in the 16th century, as seen in the writings of these Fathers, inadvertently contribute to the theological self-scrutiny that would later fuel the internal debates of the Gondarine era?

Chapter Seven

7 Christological Debates in Gondarine Perod

Chapter Objectives

- To introduce the concept of "heresy" (mənfəqəna, **ምንፍቅና**) as it manifested within internal Ethiopian Orthodox theological discourse during the Gondarine period, by examining the spiritual lives and intellectual contributions of the Fathers who participated in these debates.
- To detail, drawing from Mebratu Kiros Gebru's *Miaphysite Christology* (2009), the crucial 17th-century Christological debates between Ethiopian Fathers (including the apologetic activity of Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis, **እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ**, as a defender of Täwaḥədo) and Portuguese Jesuit missionaries, showcasing the Ethiopian defense of Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) against external Dyophysite challenges.
- To analyze in depth, drawing significantly from Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009), the origins and complex theological distinctions of the major Christological views often labeled as divergent—Qəbᶜat (**ቅብዐት** – Unction) and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (**ጸጋ/ሦስት ልደት** – Grace/Three Births)—by the dominant Täwaḥədo school, grounding the discussion in the teachings and distinct theological formulations (as their "works") of the Fathers who championed or opposed these views, and using relevant Gəᶜəz (**ግዕዝ**) theological terminology.
- To examine the lives and pivotal roles of other ecclesiastical leaders and scholars, such as Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**), focusing on his biographical contributions, his scholarly lineage, his critical revision of the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) tradition leading to the Yä-Lay Bet and Yä-Tačč Bet distinctions (as detailed in Kəfyaläw Məraḥi's *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə*ʾ, 2011 E.C.), and how his life was impacted by these controversies, while clarifying the traditional understanding of Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis's consistent defense of Täwaḥədo.
- To investigate how these theological divisions, championed by different groups of Ethiopian Fathers through their distinct intellectual contributions and schools of thought,

became deeply politicized, affecting the lives of these patristic figures and contributing to ecclesiastical and national fragmentation during the Zämänä Mäsafənt (**ዘመነ መሳፍንት**).

- To briefly anticipate the conciliar efforts (subsequent "works" of the Church) aimed at resolving these internal disputes and restoring doctrinal unity based on the perceived "faith of the Fathers" (Haymanotä ʾAbäw, **ሃይማኖተ አበው**).
- To reflect on the enduring patristic legacy of this period of intense internal theological inquiry, where the spiritual witness and scholarly output of Ethiopian Fathers reveal both profound intellectual articulation and the challenges of division.

The 16th century, as explored in Chapter Six, witnessed Ethiopian Church Fathers courageously defending the Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) faith against external military and theological onslaughts through their powerful apologetic compositions. This period of intense engagement, particularly the debates with Jesuit missionaries promoting a Chalcedonian Dyophysite Christology, inadvertently sowed the seeds for a new phase of internal theological scrutiny within the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church. The Gondarine period (c. mid-17th – mid-19th century) thus marks one of the most intellectually fervent and theologically complex epochs in the Church's history. Before delving into the specific internal doctrinal disputes that characterized this era, it is crucial to understand the intellectual climate shaped by the preceding "Christological Controversies with Portuguese Missionaries," as meticulously detailed by Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009, pp. 29-35). These debates honed the apologetic skills of Ethiopian Fathers and sharpened their articulation of Täwaḥədo, setting the stage for the internal discussions to come.

7.1 Christological Controversies and Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis (እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ)

The arrival of Jesuit missionaries in the wake of the wars with Ahmad Grañ presented a new theological battlefront. Mebratu (2009, pp. 29-30) highlights that King Gälawdewos, a Father-ruler, was compelled to articulate the Ethiopian faith in his famous *Confessio Fidei Claudii Regis Aethipiae* (Ṭomarä Gälawdewos) in response to the Jesuits' challenges. This foundational text set the stage for more formal debates where key Ethiopian Fathers dedicated their lives and intellectual energy to defending the indigenous faith. Among the most prominent of these was Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis (**እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ**) (fl. mid-17th C.).

7.1.1 The Life and Contribution of Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis

The life of Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis is primarily illuminated by his significant role as a leader and theologian during a critical period of Ethiopian Church history. His rise to the esteemed position of Ǝčč̣äge (**ኣፈጌ**)—the administrative head of all monasteries in Ethiopia and historically the highest-ranking Ethiopian-born church official—testifies to his profound learning, piety, and leadership.

His tenure as Ǝčč̣äge spanned the turbulent reigns of Emperor Susənyos (who attempted to impose Roman Catholicism) and his son, Emperor Fasilädäs (who restored the Ethiopian Orthodox faith). During Susənyos's reign, Beträ Giyorgis's unwavering commitment to the ancestral Täwaḥədo faith led to a precarious existence; he was reportedly appointed and dismissed from the office of Ǝčč̣äge several times due to his staunch opposition to the Catholic conversion (Mebratu, 2009, p. 31, citing Chernetsov in EAE). This demonstrates a life of courage and conviction, willing to face imperial displeasure for the sake of doctrinal integrity.

His most celebrated contribution came to the fore during the reign of Emperor Fasilädäs. Having been instrumental in persuading the new emperor to expel the Jesuits and restore the "Alexandrian faith" (i.e., Ethiopian Orthodoxy), Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis was called upon to be the chief defender of that faith in a final, formal debate against the departing Jesuit Patriarch, Alphonzo Mendez. This debate, detailed by Mebratu (2009, p. 34), showcased the depth of Beträ Giyorgis's theological acumen. He skillfully refuted Mendez's arguments, for instance, by citing Romans 5:10 ("while we were his enemies, we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son") to affirm the suffering of the Son of God, and by using the analogy of light to counter questions about the "face of God," thereby demonstrating God's omnipresence.

This intellectual triumph was not a mere academic exercise; it was a crucial act in reaffirming the Church's theological independence and traditional understanding. The victory was so impactful that it was immortalized in a famous Qəne (**ቅኔ**) (Mebratu, 2009, p. 35):

ረከብናሁ ለበትር ዘያደክማ ለሮሜ

ጽሩበ በንባብ ወቅሩጸ በትርጓሜ

Rekebnahu lebetir zeyadekima leRome

Ṣirube benibab weqiruṣe betirguamē

We have found a rod [Beträ Giyorgis, "Rod of St. George"] that weakens Rome,
Polished by reading and carved by interpretation.

This Qəne encapsulates the essence of Beträ Giyorgis's contribution: profound scriptural and traditional knowledge (nəbab, **ንባብ** - reading/text) combined with sharp interpretive skill (tərgʷame, **ትርጓሜ** - interpretation). His life following this period continued to be influential. As the Ethiopian Church began to grapple with internal theological nuances (the Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga debates), traditional Ethiopian scholarly sources like *Fənotä Liqawənt* (Vol. 1, as excerpted by the module author) argue strongly that Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis continued his advocacy as a defender of the established Täwaḥədo position. Evidence cited includes his praise for the Täwaḥədo advocate Adam Zänfəranz during a later internal debate with Qəbᶜat proponents, and historical accounts of the Qəbᶜat advocate Ǝwər Zäᵓ Iyäsus insulting Beträ Giyorgis after a defeat, precisely because the Ǝčč̣äge had previously bested the Qəbᶜat faction in earlier imperial councils. This traditional perspective underscores Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis's consistent spiritual witness and intellectual activity as a champion of Täwaḥədo.

While some secondary sources (as noted by Mebratu, 2009, p. 31, and critiqued in *Fənotä Liqawənt*) have suggested he later led the Qəbᶜat school, the weight of indigenous tradition appears to affirm his steadfastness in Täwaḥədo. His life and theological endeavors thus represent a crucial patristic contribution to the resilience and theological self-definition of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church.

7.1.2 The First and Second Christological Debates with Portuguese Missionaries

The earlier debates also illustrate the Ethiopian Fathers' commitment to their theological heritage.

- First Debate (Reign of Gälawdewos): Mebratu (2009, pp. 30-32) describes Abba Pauli and Abba Zekri representing the EOTC. The Jesuits argued for two distinct natures and properties in Christ. Abba Zekri, in his refutation, used the analogy of the soul and body in a human being to argue for the indivisible unity of Christ, emphasizing the *communicatio idiomatum*.
- Second Debate (Reign of Zädəngəl): During the reign of King Zädəngəl (1603–1604), Pero Paez argued that Christ, being perfect God and perfect man, possessed two natures. Mebratu (2009, p. 34, citing Jembere) highlights the Ethiopian response: Paez wrongly attributed Christ's human actions (like shedding blood) to His nature (baḥrəy) rather than

His person (ʾakal). The Ethiopian Fathers argued that attributes belong to the person in whom natures are united.

Mebratu (2009, p. 35) aptly concludes this section by stating, "the Roman Catholic challenge was the single most important influence that has so firmly established the monophysite [sic, referring to the external label for Miaphysite] doctrine in Ethiopia." He also observes, however, that "the internal schisms and controversies were direct results of the debates raised by the Catholic missionaries." It is to these internal developments, where the now sharpened Täwaḥədo understanding faced new internal interpretations, that we now turn.

7.2 The Rise of Internal Christological Schools

Following the intense period of defending the faith against external Jesuit pressures, the Ethiopian Church saw the emergence of internal theological schools offering distinct interpretations of Christology. The Qəbᶜat (Unction) school became a significant movement, particularly associated with monks of the order of St. Ewosṭatewos (**ደቂቀ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) and finding strong support in the region of Gojjam (Mebratu, 2009, pp. 36-37).

- Lives of Qəbᶜat Fathers and their Collective Intellectual Activity: The lives of the "Qəbatočč" (**ቅባቶች** – Unctionists) were characterized by their adherence to this school, often marked by strong regional loyalties. Their primary intellectual endeavor was the propagation of their distinct Christological understanding, which they grounded in scriptural passages like Isaiah 61:1, Luke 4:18, Acts 4:27, and Acts 10:38 (Mebratu, 2009, p. 37). The Qəbᶜat school had its own influential proponents whose lives and teachings shaped its doctrines.
- The Teachings of the Qəbᶜat School – Key Theological Tenets: Their central theological teaching revolved around the anointing (qəbᶜat, **ቅብዐት**) of Christ by the Holy Spirit. As Mebratu (2009, p. 37) explains, "the unctionists (the adherents of this sect) contend that in Christ the two natures were fully united by the unction of the Holy Spirit; by unction they mean the grace of the Holy Spirit which the Son received while in the womb." Their distinctive theological formula, a key part of their intellectual output, was: "ʾAb Qäbaᶜi, Wäld Täqäbaᶜi, Mänfäs Qəddus Qəbᶜ" (**አብ ቀባዒ ወልድ ተቀባዒ መንፈስ ቅዱስ ቅብዕ** –

"The Father is the Anointer, the Son is the Anointed, the Holy Spirit is the Ointment/Unction") (Mebratu, 2009, p. 37; Getatchew Haile, EAE "Ethiopian Heresies"). Mebratu (2009, p. 37) further elaborates on their position: "The act of unction belongs to both the Word and flesh, so that by the unction the Word was made perfect man whereas the flesh was made divine." This led to the understanding that Christ was glorified or perfected "by unction" (Bäqəbᶜat Käbbärä, **በቅብዓት ከበረ**). Mebratu (2009, p. 37, fn 140, citing Kidanäwäld Kəfle) mentions three subdivisions within the Qəbᶜat school concerning the effect of the unction: one suggesting the Word lost divine honor restored by unction; another that the flesh received divine honor by unction; and a third that the flesh was exalted by both unction and union.
The Täwaḥədo/Unionist Fathers viewed these teachings as divergent, arguing they could imply an imperfection in Christ's humanity or divinity prior to the anointing, or that Sonship was conferred rather than eternal. Mebratu (2009, p. 37) notes, "Because of this view, the unctionists are allied with Eutychianism which states that the human nature of Christ was absorbed by the divine." The Qəbᶜat school also maintained that Christ has two births: eternal from the Father and temporal from St. Mary (Mebratu, 2009, p. 38).

7.2.1 Christology of Adoption

Another major theological current was the Ṣägga (Grace) school, also widely known as the Śost Lədät (Three Births) school. Mebratu (2009, p. 39) indicates that this school emerged in the mid-17th century "among the monks of the order of Takla Haymanot who had been the adherents of the national tewahedo position," finding strong proponents connected to Däbrä Libanos and prominent in Shäwa.

- Lives of Ṣägga Fathers: The lives of Ṣägga Fathers were dedicated to expounding their understanding of Christ's "births."
- The Teachings of the Ṣägga School – Key Theological Tenets: The central theological position of the Ṣäggočč (**ጸጎች** – Grace adherents) was their doctrine of "Three Births" (Śost Lədät, **ሦስት ልደት**) for Christ. Mebratu (2009, p. 39) outlines these as:
    1. Qədmawi Lədät (**ቀዳማዊ ልደት**): The eternal generation of the Son from the Father.
    2. Daḫrawi Lədät (**ዳሕራዊ ልደት**): The temporal birth of the Son from the Virgin Mary.

3. Yägəbər Lədät (**የግብር ልደት**) or Śaləst Lədät (**ሣልስት ልደት**): A "third birth" by grace (ṣägga, **ጸጋ**) or adoption, effected by the Holy Spirit, typically at Christ's baptism. Mebratu (2009, p. 39) explains, "This teaching is similar to the third century's heresy of adoptionism, the adherents are called adoptionists." This act of the Spirit, they taught, made Christ, in His humanity, the Son of God by grace, thus becoming the first-born (bakʷər, **በኵር**) among many brethren. Their watchword was "Yäsägga Ləj" (**የጸጋ ልጅ** – Son by Grace).

Mebratu (2009, p. 39) clarifies their rationale: "The adoptionists' idea that Christ is Son by grace (by adoption) in his humanity is meant to preclude any idea of the transformation of the body of Christ to be divine. Thus they believed in the co-existence of two distinct natures in Christ. As a result, they were called crypto-Catholics." The Täwaḥədo/Karra Fathers fiercely opposed this teaching, condemning it as a deviation that compromised Christ's unique and natural Sonship, viewing it as adoptionism with Nestorian leanings (Mebratu, 2009, p. 40).

7.2.2 The Täwaḥədo/Karra (ተዋሕዶ/ካራ – Union/Knife) School's Defense

In strong opposition to both the Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga schools, the defenders of what they considered the traditional, unadulterated Täwaḥədo faith—often referred to as the Karra (Knife) school—articulated their position.

- The Doctrinal Stance of the Karra School: Their primary objective was to reject any Christological formulation that compromised the perfect, indivisible union (täwaḥədo) of Christ's divine and human natures (baḥrəyat, **ባሕርያት**) in His one Person (ʾakal, **አካል**). Against the Qəbᶜat school's formula, the Unionists (Täwaḥədo/Karra) argued, as Mebratu (2009, p. 38) states, "the Son Himself is the anointer, the anointed and the ointment (unction)." This is encapsulated in the formula "Wäld Qəbᶜ" (**ወልድ ቅብዕ** – "The Son is the Ointment/Unction"). They maintained that "the union of humanity and divinity is called unction," or "the union of the divinity [with the humanity] in him [Christ] takes the place of the anointment of his humanity" (Mebratu, 2009, p. 38). They accused the Ṣägga school of Nestorianism and the Qəbᶜat school of Eutychianism (Mebratu, 2009, pp. 37, 40). For them, the täwaḥədo itself was the source of Christ's glory and natural Sonship. Mebratu (2009, p. 40) acutely observes, "the purpose of the subtle arguments on unction

was to demonstrate whether one accepts a duality of natures in Christ." The Unionists firmly rejected any such duality.

7.3 Mämhər Esdros (መምህር ኤስድሮስ)

Amidst these swirling doctrinal storms, and central to the intellectual activity of the Gondarine period, Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**) (fl. 18th C.) stands as a colossal patristic figure. His life and scholarly achievements were pivotal not primarily for direct engagement in the Christological factions that divided Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga adherents from the Täwaḥədo school, but for the profound and lasting impact he had on the transmission, critical assessment, and systematic refinement of Ethiopian Orthodox learning. Specifically, his endeavors revolutionized the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) tradition—the indigenous system of commentary—which undergirded all theological discourse and scriptural understanding.

7.3.1 His Life, Scholarly Lineage, and Formation

Born with sight but losing it in infancy, Mämhər Esdros embarked on an extraordinary educational journey that exemplifies the dedication of Ethiopian Fathers to sacred learning. His life was one of relentless study. Kəfyaläw Məraḥi in *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalᵊ* (2011 E.C., pp. 74-76, 233-235) meticulously traces Mämhər Esdros's scholarly lineage and provides context for his monumental contributions. The tradition of interpretation in Ethiopia had ancient roots, evolving from Gəᶜəz-to-Gəᶜəz tərgʷame (interpretation) of texts translated from Greek, Syriac, Coptic, and Arabic, to the burgeoning Amharic Andəmta which flourished especially in the Gondarine period.

Mämhər Esdros emerged as the confluence of two distinct lines of Gondarine scholarly transmission. One line descended from the students of Ǝčča̤ge Beträ Giyorgis, through figures like ᶜAqabe Säᶜat Abba Yohannəs (Abranyos), Zäkərstos, Yəmanä Ab, Ǝčča̤ge Ḥəryaqos, culminating in Ǝčča̤ge Qalä Awadi (fl. c. 1666 E.C. / ~1673/4 G.C.), who became a key teacher of Mämhər Esdros. Ǝčča̤ge Qalä Awadi himself is identified as having laid the foundation for the Andəmta Tərgʷame as it later developed (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 74). A second lineage traced back to teachers named Zäkərənna and Pawli (or Pawlos), through their students down to Aläqa Gʷangul, who also taught Mämhər Esdros (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 234).

Furthermore, the imperial court recognized the need for interpretations accessible to a wider Amharic-speaking populace. During the reign of Emperor Iyasu I Adəyam Sägäd (1682-1706 G.C.), a great council in Gondär resolved that while the base texts (nəbab) would remain in Gəᶜəz, their interpretation (tərgʷame) should be in Amharic. Four Liqawənt were appointed to head the "Four Assemblies" (ʾAratu Gubaʾeyat) of learning and prepare these Andəmta: Ǝčča̱ge Qalä Awadi (for Old Testament), Mämhər Śärwe Krəstos (for New Testament), Mämhər Kəflä Yoḥannəs (for Books of the Fathers/Scholars), and ᶜAqabe Säᶜat Abba Yohannəs (Abranyos) (for Books of the Monks) (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 75).

Mämhər Esdros studied within this highly structured system, learning, for instance, Mäṣaḥəftä Liqawənt from Ǝčča̱ge Henok (a successor or colleague in Qalä Awadi's Gubaʾe) and Mäṣaḥəftä Mänakʷəsat from Mämhər Muse (Ashagre Amite, 2016, pp. 174-175; Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 76 table). This comprehensive education under Gondär's greatest masters earned him the revered title of ʾArat ᶜAyna (**አራት ዐይና** – "Four-Eyed") scholar, signifying his profound mastery of the sacred texts and their interpretations despite his physical blindness.

7.3.2 The Patristic Contribution of Revising and Systematizing the Andəmta

Mämhər Esdros's most significant and enduring contribution was his critical revision, systematization, and profound enrichment of the Andəmta commentaries. As Kəfyaläw Məraḥi recounts, "Though his physical eyes were blind, his spiritual eyes were enlightened; he was a great scholar... a student of Ǝčča̱ge Qalä Awadi, [he] examined around 300 books and started the Andəmta Tərgʷame in a new form (bäʾaddisə məlkəʾ)" (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 74). His deep concern for the purity and accuracy of the interpretive tradition led him to undertake extensive research. This patristic endeavor involved:

- Intensive Manuscript Study: Mämhər Esdros traveled to the ancient and renowned monasteries of Lake Tana, particularly Tana Qirqos and Daga Äsṭifanos. There, he meticulously read and compared over three hundred different ancient manuscripts (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 234). This demonstrates a profound commitment to textual criticism and returning to the sources (ad fontes), a hallmark of true patristic scholarship.
- Improving the Interpretive Method (Səlät): Through this rigorous study, "he improved the method/style of interpretation" (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 234). His efforts focused

on enhancing the accuracy of scriptural cross-references (ṭəqs, **ጥቅስ**), ensuring the conciseness and relevance of illustrative narratives (tarik, **ታሪክ**), and deepening the mystical insights (məsṭir, **ምሥጢር**) of the commentaries.

7.3.3 The Emergence of Yä-Lay Bet and Yä-Tačč Bet

This critical scholarly activity of Mämhər Esdros led to a significant development in the Andəmta tradition: the distinction between two main "houses" or schools of interpretation.

- Yä-Tačč Bet (**የታች ቤት** – "Lower House"): This school, primarily associated with Gondär where Mämhər Esdros taught at the Sədäta Betä Krəstiyan (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 234), largely adopted his revisions and refined interpretive methods. It was characterized by a more concise, critically examined, and systematically presented Andəmta. This is the interpretation he initiated "in a new form."
- Yä-Lay Bet (**የላይ ቤት** – "Upper House"): This school, often associated with Gojjam (particularly Moṭṭa and the disciples of Geta Yonas) and other areas, tended to retain the older, pre-revision Andəmta traditions, which included Gəʿəz-to-Gəʿəz interpretations and possibly more expansive Amharic Andəmta. The story recounted in *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə*ʾ(Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., p. 74) illustrates this divergence: after his deep research, Mämhər Esdros recalled his former students, saying, "There is remaining mystery, come, let us re-examine the books and learn again." Many came and "expanded their interpretation and enriched the mystery (**ምሥጢር ያደላደሉት**)," becoming teachers of the YäTačč Bet. However, a few declined, stating metaphorically, "We were born before you became lean/brought a new interpretation (**ንሕነሰ ፥ ኢተወለድነ ፥ እምዝመ·ት**); we will not re-enter school." These became followers of the YäLay Bet.

Mämhər Esdros's life and scholarly output thus provided a more solid, critically assessed hermeneutical foundation for understanding the Orthodox faith. He was truly a "father of many teachers," and his students, such as Geta Yonas, Geta Gälawdewos, and Sənä Krəstos, continued his scholarly lineage, which, as *Zəkrä Liqawənt* traces, extended to influential scholars of the 19th and 20th centuries, and even to contemporary Liqawənt (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2011 E.C., pp. 234-235).

7.3.4 Mämhər Esdros's Stance in the Debates and His Later Life

While Mämhər Esdros's primary contribution was scholarly and pedagogical, his life was not untouched by the doctrinal controversies. He was a staunch adherent of the Täwaḥədo position. However, as Ashagre Amite (2016, p. 182) notes, due to the politicization of these debates, he faced persecution and was even exiled from Gondär for a period due to the machinations of regional lords who supported the Qəbᶜat school, such as Ras Wäldä Ləᶜul of Gojjam. This demonstrates how the lives of even the most dedicated scholar-Fathers could be profoundly impacted by the intersection of theology and regional power struggles.

7.4 Politicization of Doctrinal Differences during the Zämänä Mäsafənt

The theological divisions of the Gondarine period became deeply entangled with regional politics, especially during the Zämänä Mäsafənt (**ዘመነ መሳፍንት** – Era of the Princes, c. 1769-1855). Regional lords and powerful nobles often championed specific Christological schools, making adherence a matter of political loyalty as much as theological conviction. This politicization profoundly affected the lives and intellectual endeavors of the Fathers.

- Fathers as Victims and Partisans: The lives of many Fathers were shaped by these alliances. As seen with Mämhər Esdros, even those dedicated to scholarship and holding the eventually affirmed Orthodox view could suffer exile if their position conflicted with that of a powerful regional ruler. Conversely, Fathers aligned with regionally dominant schools often found patronage and influence, but this further entrenched the divisions.
- Impact on Ecclesiastical Unity: The association of specific Christological views (now often termed "heresies" or deviations by opponents) with particular regions (e.g., Qəbᶜat with Gojjam, Ṣägga with Shäwa, Karra/Täwaḥədo with Tigray and Gondär) exacerbated political fragmentation and severely hindered ecclesiastical unity (ḥədənätä betä krəstiyan, **ጎድነት ቤተ ክርስቲያን**). The theological contributions of the Fathers became intertwined with, and sometimes tools of, regional power struggles, leading to a period of profound internal strain for the Church.

7.4.1 Anticipating Resolution

The deep divisions fostered during the Gondarine period, fueled by sincere theological inquiry but complicated by political interference, could not endure indefinitely if the Church and the nation were to regain cohesion. The intense theological activity of this era, while divisive, also served to clarify the doctrinal landscape and the precise points of contention. This painstaking, often painful, process of internal debate and articulation ultimately set the stage for later imperial and ecclesiastical endeavors—the councils of the 19th century (Amba Čara and Boru Meda)—aimed at definitively resolving these disputes and establishing a unified doctrinal standard based on the perceived "faith of the Fathers," which will be explored in Chapter Eight.

7.5 The Patristic Legacy of Internal Doctrinal Struggle and the Pursuit of Doctrinal Clarity

The Gondarine period, characterized by these intense internal debates among Ethiopian Fathers over Christological interpretations (some subsequently labeled "heresies" or *mənfəqəna*), was a crucible of theological thought. The lives of these Fathers were deeply impacted by the intellectual and political currents of their time, and their theological contributions—whether expressed in distinct doctrinal formulas, scholarly revisions of tradition like those of Mämhər Esdros, or leadership within specific schools—spurred profound intellectual engagement within Ethiopian Orthodoxy.

This era of intense internal theological inquiry, as detailed by scholars like Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009) and chronicled in traditional works like Kəfyaläw Məraḥi's *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə'* (2011 E.C.), bequeathed a complex but rich patristic legacy, marked by:

- Profound Intellectual Contributions: The necessity to define and defend nuanced Christological positions led to the development and refinement of sophisticated Gəᶜəz theological language and argumentation.
- Heightened Doctrinal Self-Awareness: The controversies, as Mebratu (2009) details, forced the Church, through the endeavors of its Fathers, to scrutinize its Christological heritage with unprecedented rigor. The systematic scholarship of figures like Mämhər

Esdros on the Andəmta tradition also contributed to a deeper and more critically engaged understanding of the scriptural and patristic sources.

- The Enduring Challenge of Unity: The politicization of these differences, profoundly impacting the lives of Fathers and the faithful, left deep scars that would take concerted effort to heal.
- The Imperative of Conciliar Action: The inability to resolve these disputes through ongoing debate alone highlighted the eventual need for definitive conciliar pronouncements to establish a common understanding based on the "faith of the Fathers" (Haymanotä ʾAbäw, **ሃይማኖተ አበው**).

The Gondarine Fathers, through their spiritual witness and diverse scholarly outputs—whether polemical, pedagogical, or pastoral—contributed significantly to the ongoing stream of Ethiopian patristic thought. Their struggles, explorations, and the very controversies they engaged in, laid a complex but indispensable foundation for the subsequent consolidation of Täwaḥədo Christology in the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church.

Review Questions for Chapter Seven

1. Based on Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009, pp. 29-35) and traditional sources like *Fənotä Liqawənt*, describe the life and contribution of Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis in defending Täwaḥədo against the Jesuit missionary Alphonzo Mendez. What does the Qəne composed about him signify regarding his patristic impact, and how do traditional sources clarify his stance during later internal debates?
2. Drawing from Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009, pp. 36-39), detail the core theological tenets of the Qəbʿat (**ቅብዐት**) school. What was their key formula regarding the Trinity and anointing, what were the subdivisions within their thought, and why were they associated with Eutychianism by their opponents?
3. According to Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009, pp. 39-40), what were the main teachings of the Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (**ጸጋ/ሦስት ልደት**) school? Explain their concept of the "Three Births" (Śost Lədät, **ሦስት ልደት**) including yägəbər lədät (**የግብር ልደት**), and why were they termed "crypto-Catholics" or adoptionists?
4. Explain the Täwaḥədo/Karra (**ተዋሕዶ/ካራ**) school's response to the Qəbʿat and Ṣägga schools, as understood from Mebratu Kiros Gebru's (2009, pp. 38, 40-41) presentation of

the Unionist position. How did they understand "unction" in relation to "union," and what were their primary objections to the other schools?

5. Describe the life and patristic contribution of Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**) to the Andəmta (**አንድምታ**) tradition, drawing from Kəfyaläw Məraḥi's *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə*ʾ (2011 E.C.). Include his scholarly lineage (e.g., his teachers Ǝčč̣äge Qalä Awadi and Aläqa Gʷangul), his research methodology (e.g., at Tana Qirqos and Daga Äsṭifanos), and how his scholarly activity led to the Yä-Lay Bet (**የላይ ቤት**) and Yä-Tačč Bet (**የታች ቤት**) distinctions.
6. Drawing from Kəfyaläw Məraḥi's *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə*ʾ (2011 E.C.), explain the imperial decision under Emperor Iyasu I regarding the use of Amharic for Andəmta and the appointment of four Liqawənt to head the "Four Assemblies" of learning. How did this context shape the environment for Mämhər Esdros's work?
7. In what ways did the theological divisions of the Gondarine period become politicized during the Zämänä Mäsafənt (**ዘመነ መሳፍንት**)? How did this affect ecclesiastical unity and the lives of Fathers like Mämhər Esdros?
8. Reflecting on the spiritual journeys and scholarly output of the Gondarine Fathers, what is the overall patristic legacy of this period of intense internal theological debate? How did it contribute to the development of Ethiopian Orthodox theological thought, despite the divisions it created?

Chapter Eight

8 Fathers at the Beginning of Modernity

Chapter Objectives

- To articulate the patristic underpinnings of the quest for ecclesiastical unity and national self-definition in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, focusing on how the lives and contributions of key Fathers were informed by the historical understanding of Miaphysite Christology as solidified after the Gondarine controversies.
- To analyze how the imperial endeavors and interventions of Emperor Tewodros II (**አፄ ቴዎድሮስ ፪**), Emperor Yohannes IV (**አፄ ዮሐንስ ፬**), and Emperor Menelik II (**አፄ ምኒልክ ፪**) engaged with and sought to define or utilize patristic doctrine (təmhərtä ʾabäw, **ትምህርተ አበው**), particularly the Alexandrian-Cyrillian heritage as understood and defended by the Täwaḥədo/Karra school, for national cohesion.
- To further detail the context, proceedings, and definitive decisions of the Councils of Amba Čara (**አምባ ጭራ**) and Boru Meda (**ጉባኤ ቦሩ ሜዳ**) (1878) as landmark patristic achievements in standardizing Täwaḥədo (**ተዋሕዶ**) Christology and condemning what were then considered resolved theological deviations (mənfəqəna, **ምንፍቅና**) like Qəbᶜat (**ቅብዐት**) and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (**ጸጋ/ሦስት ልደት**).
- To explore the patristic dimensions of Emperor Menelik II's reign, including the theological interpretation of the Battle of Adwa (**ጦርነት ዓድዋ**) as reflected in the understanding of the Fathers and the Church.
- To describe the methods of transmitting the patristic heritage (rəstä ʾabäw, **ርስተ አበው**) during this transitional period, highlighting the lives and scholarly contributions of influential liqawənt (**ሊቃውንት**) such as Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) and Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**) as key patristic figures in this process.
- To reflect on the complex legacy of this period, marked by the aftermath of intense internal debate, the assertion of a unified doctrinal stance through the conciliar and

imperial actions, and the Church's engagement with emerging modernity, all viewed through the spiritual witness and intellectual output of its leading Fathers.

The period stretching from the mid-19th century through the early decades of the 20th century was one of profound transformation for Ethiopia. Visionary emperors rose, their lives and reigns dedicated to ending the fragmentation of the Zämänä Mäsafənt (**ዘመነ መሳፍንት** – Era of the Princes) and forging a unified, modernizing nation. Central to this imperial project was a deep-seated "patristic imperative": an understanding that true national cohesion was inextricably bound to a unified Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, itself grounded in a clearly defined "faith of the Fathers" (haymanotä ʾabäw, **ሃይማኖተ አበው**). This faith, as definitively established by conciliar decisions after the tumultuous Gondarine controversies (discussed in Chapter Seven), was the Miaphysite Christology of the Täwaḥədo/Karra (**ተዋሕዶ/ካራ**) school. The previously divisive Christological interpretations of Qəbᶜat (**ቅብዐት**) and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (**ጸጋ/ሦስት ልደት**) were now largely considered resolved theological deviations (mənfəqəna, **ምንፍቅና**). This chapter examines how the lives and activities of Emperors Tewodros II, Yohannes IV, and Menelik II, alongside those of influential Church Fathers like Mämhər Akalä Wäld and Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle, engaged with this patristic imperative, enforcing doctrinal standardization, fostering theological interpretations of national events, and ensuring the transmission of the sacred heritage.

8.1 Imperial Patristic Agendas

The emperors of this era viewed theological unity not merely as an ecclesiastical concern but as a fundamental prerequisite for political stability and national strength. Their interventions in church doctrine, constituting significant aspects of their reigns, were extensions of their state-building projects.

8.1.1 Council at Amba Čara (**አምባ ጭራ**) (1854)

The life of Emperor Tewodros II (r. 1855-1868) was marked by an almost messianic zeal to restore Ethiopia. One of his earliest and most significant initiatives, even before his formal coronation, was convening the Council of Amba Čara in 1854.

- Life and Purpose: Tewodros, supported by the influential Coptic Metropolitan Abunä Sälama III (**አቡነ ሰላማ ፫**)—a Father whose own activity was dedicated to promoting the Täwaḥədo/Karra position—sought to decisively end the Christological disputes.
- Decisions as a Patristic Statement: The Council of Amba Čara decreed that the Täwaḥədo/Karra understanding of Christ's nature—affirming the one, indivisible, united divine-human nature of Christ without confusion, mixture, division, or separation—was the sole orthodox doctrine (Rətuᶜa Haymanot, **ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**). The teachings of the Qəbᶜat (Unction) and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät (Grace/Three Births) schools were officially proscribed by imperial fiat (Crummey, 1972, pp. 81-82). This conciliar decision was a clear assertion of the historical Miaphysite understanding, emphasizing continuity with the Alexandrian patristic heritage.

8.1.2 Council of Boru Meda (**ጉባኤ ቦሩ ሜዳ**) (1878)

The life of Emperor Yohannes IV (r. 1872-1889) was characterized by profound personal piety and an unwavering commitment to the Täwaḥədo/Karra faith. His reign culminated in the landmark Council of Boru Meda in 1878, a pivotal event for doctrinal standardization.

- Context and Proceedings: The council brought together liqawənt (**ሊቃውንት** – learned scholars) from all contending Christological schools. The Emperor, a theologian in his own right, presided, with the Coptic Metropolitan Abunä Atnatewos (**አቡነ አትናቴዎስ**) lending Alexandrian sanction (Getatchew Haile, n.d.-a, CE:987a). The debates, themselves significant intellectual endeavors, drew heavily on Holy Scripture (Mäṣḥaf Qəddus, **መጽሐፍ ቅዱስ**) and the Haymanotä Abäw (**ሃይማኖተ አበው** – Faith of the Fathers).

8.1.3 The Contribution of Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**)

A pivotal Father whose life and influence shaped the outcome of Boru Meda was Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) (ca. mid-19th to early 20th C.). A scholar of immense repute (Amsalu Aklilu, EAE "Akalä Wäld"), his role at Boru Meda involved persuasively arguing to Emperor Yohannes that adherence to Orthodoxy should be achieved through teaching (təmhərt, **ትምህርት**) and conviction. Subsequently, as "the apostle of Wällo," his pastoral activity was

instrumental in the peaceful persuasion and conversion of many regional leaders (Caulk, 1972, p. 35). His life exemplifies the patristic ideal of combining profound scholarship with effective pastoral engagement. The Amharic saying, "mämar éndä Akaléyye mäwagat éndä Gäbréyye" (**መማር እንደ አካሌዬ መዋጋት እንደ ገብርዬ** – "Learning [should be] like Akaleyye / Fighting [should be] like Gabreyye"), attests to his renowned scholarly impact.

The Council of Boru Meda's primary achievement was to definitively affirm the Karra/Täwaḥədo doctrine as the sole Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**) (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 33). It explicitly condemned the Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga/Śost Lədät doctrines as mənfəqəna (**ምንፍቅና**) (Getatchew Haile, CE:987a). This conciliar decision aimed to eradicate any Christological formulations that could imply a division in Christ, thereby reinforcing Miaphysite Christology.

8.2 Emperor Menelik II (**አፄ ምኒልክ ፪**)

The life and reign of Emperor Menelik II (r. 1889-1913) saw the further consolidation of the Ethiopian empire and the iconic victory at Adwa. These events were interpreted through a patristic lens by the Church and its leading figures.

- The Battle of Adwa (**ጦርነት ዓድዋ**) (1896) – A Theological Interpretation of Divine Intervention: The victory at Adwa was overwhelmingly attributed to divine providence (fəqadä ʾƎgziʾabḥer, **ፈቃደ እግዚአብሔር**) and the intercession of St. George (Qəddus Giyorgis, **ቅዱስ ጊዮርጊስ**). The war was perceived as a sacred defense of Ethiopia's ancient Christian identity, a theological event in which God protected His faithful nation.
- Early Modernization and the Enduring Importance of Traditional Learning: While Emperor Menelik II initiated early modernization, the traditional Qes Təmhərt Bet (**ቀስ ትምህርት ቤት**) system—comprising nəbab bet (**ንባብ ቤት**), qəddase bet (**ቅዳሴ ቤት**), zema bet (**ዜማ ቤት**), qəne bet (**ቅኔ ቤት**), and mäṣḥaf bet (**መጽሐፍ ቤት**)—continued its vital function of producing learned Fathers and transmitting the sacred heritage.

8.3 Transmitting the Patristic Heritage

Despite profound changes, the traditional transmission of the patristic heritage (rəstä ʾabäw, **ርስተ አበው**) remained resilient through the dedicated lives and scholarly endeavors of the liqawənt (**ሊቃውንት**).

8.3.1 Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**)

A monumental Father who bridged traditional scholarship with modern dissemination was Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**) (ca. 1862 – July 6, 1944 AD, as per DACB). Born in Wagda, Shawa, his life was dedicated to learning. Educated first at home and then in a church school, he went to Jerusalem at age twenty to study Hebrew, Arabic, and Syriac. After many years, he was summoned in 1919 by Ras Täfäri Mäkonnən to undertake a commentary on Ezekiel (Amsalu Akilu, DACB, "Kefle, Kidana-Wald"). This background shaped his future scholarly contributions.

Aläqa Kidanäwäld embarked on immense scholarly projects. His *Mäṣḥafä Säwasəw wägəss wämäzgäbä Qalat Ḥaddis (**መጽሐፈ ሰዋስው ወግስ ወመዝገበ ቃላት ሐዲስ**)*: His monumental Gəᶜəz-Amharic dictionary (KWKDic), published posthumously (1956 G.C.) by his student Dästa Täklä-Wald, is an indispensable tool for Gəᶜəz studies (Heruy Walda Selasse, *Yaheywat Tarik*; Kidana Wäld Kəfle, *Mäṣḥafä Säwasəw*).

His literary output included his Commentary on the Book of Ezekiel (published 1924). Among his unpublished works were a Hebrew-Gəᶜəz dictionary and a versified Amharic translation of the *Liber Patrum* (Amsalu Akilu, DACB). During the Italian occupation (1936-41), he was imprisoned for denouncing the regime and lost his sight, yet he determined to write an Ethiopian onomastic and topological dictionary. He died on July 6, 1944, and was buried at Däbrä Libanos. Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle's life and vast scholarly contributions represent a profound dedication to the preservation and transmission of the Ethiopian patristic heritage (təwəfitä haymanot, **ትውፊተ ሃይማኖት**).

8.4 A Patristic Legacy of Asserted Unity through Imperial and Ecclesiastical Endeavors

The late 19th and early 20th centuries were profoundly significant for Ethiopian Patrology. The imperial actions of rulers, particularly through the Council of Boru Meda, sought to establish doctrinal unity based on a specific understanding of the "faith of the Fathers." Simultaneously, the Church's ancient systems of learning, embodied in the lives and dedicated scholarly efforts of great liqawənt like Mämhər Akalä Wäld and Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle, continued to produce scholars of immense caliber. Their collective contributions—conciliar, pastoral, and scholarly—

ensured the preservation and deeper understanding of the patristic heritage, preparing the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church for the challenges and opportunities of the modern world, including the momentous journey towards autocephaly. This period reflects a legacy where the spiritual witness and intellectual output of Fathers, both imperial and ecclesiastical, converged to assert a unified doctrinal identity.

Review Questions for Chapter Eight

1. Explain the "patristic imperative" behind the drive for doctrinal unity by emperors like Tewodros II and Yohannes IV in the late 19th century. How did this reflect the historical Ethiopian understanding of Miaphysite Christology?
2. Discuss Emperor Tewodros II's patristic agenda. How did the Council of Amba Čara (**አምባ ጭራ**) and his church reforms reflect this agenda?
3. Detail the context and doctrinal decisions of the Council of Boru Meda (**ጉባኤ ቦሩ ሜዳ**) (1878). How did Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) contribute to the implementation of its vision for Täwaḥədo?
4. Analyze the significance of the Battle of Adwa (**ጦርነት ዓድዋ**) from an Ethiopian Orthodox patristic perspective.
5. Describe the state of traditional patristic learning (təwəfitawi təmhərt, **ትውፊታዊ ትምህርት**) in the early 20th century, highlighting the life and monumental scholarly contribution of Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**), including his *Mäṣḥafä Säwasəw wägəss wämäzgäbä Qalat Ḥaddis*.

Chapter Nine

9 Engaging "Heresies" and the Patristic Definition of Orthodoxy in Ethiopia

Chapter Objectives

- To provide a focused examination of significant internal theological controversies and teachings deemed "heretical" or deviant within the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, as confronted and addressed through the spiritual lives and intellectual contributions of key Ethiopian Fathers, drawing from sources like Getatchew Haile (CE:984a-987b), Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C.), and Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009).
- To analyze the historical awareness and engagement of the Ethiopian Church with early Christian deviations such as Arianism, and the intellectual activity of Fathers like Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča in refuting them.
- To explore in detail the Estifanosites (Stephanites) movement, their core tenets regarding veneration and imperial authority, and the Church's response as articulated by its patristic figures.
- To examine the long-standing Sabbath Controversy involving the Ewostatewosites, detailing the arguments of proponents like Abba Ewosṭatewos and the eventual conciliar resolution efforts by Fathers like Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob.
- To discuss other theological challenges of the 14th-15th centuries, including those associated with the Zamika'elites on Trinitarian iconography and Marian devotion, and views of figures like Gämalyal and Bitu, and the patristic responses to them.
- To contextualize the later Gondarine Christological Controversies (Qəbᶜat, Ṣägga, and Täwaḥədo/Karra) as a significant period of internal theological debate, building upon the detailed discussion in Chapter Seven, and focusing on the *methods* of defining orthodoxy.
- To reflect on how Ethiopian Fathers defined and defended Rətuᶜa Haymanot (**ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት** – Orthodox Faith) in the face of these internal divergences, thereby shaping the doctrinal identity of the Ethiopian Church.
- To understand these internal "heresies" and debates not merely as deviations, but as stimuli for profound patristic reflection, theological articulation, and the clarification of

Orthodox doctrine through the spiritual witness and scholarly endeavors of the Ethiopian Fathers.

9.1 Ethiopia and the Landscape of Theological Controversy

The Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, while cherishing its unique spiritual and cultural heritage, has never existed in complete theological isolation. From its earliest centuries, it was connected to the wider Christian world and, consequently, was aware of and engaged with major theological currents and controversies that shaped early Christian doctrine. Getatchew Haile (CE:984a) highlights that a letter from the Arian Emperor Constantius II (337-361) to the rulers of Ethiopia, demanding that Abba Sälama I (St. Frumentius) be sent to Egypt for instruction in the Arian faith by the Arian Patriarch Gregory, demonstrates not only early lines of communication but also Ethiopia's early confrontation with significant theological challenges to Nicene Orthodoxy. This imperial pressure, aimed at supplanting the faith championed by St. Athanasius (whom Constantius suspected of hiding in Ethiopia), underscores Ethiopia's early alignment with Alexandrian Orthodoxy.

While historical records for some periods, such as the Zagwe dynasty (1137-1270), are "too sketchy to include the controversies, since the parties involved destroyed each other's evidence" (Getatchew Haile, CE:984a), the intellectual output of later Ethiopian Fathers reveals a continuous and vigorous engagement with defining and defending Orthodox belief against both external and internal challenges. The 15th-century Father, Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča, stands as a monumental example. In his comprehensive composition, the Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir (**መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር** – Book of Mystery), he systematically refuted ancient theological positions deemed erroneous, such as those of Origen, Arius, Eutyches, and Nestorius, alongside local theological deviations (like those of Bitu) and the tenets of Islam (Getatchew Haile, CE:984a). This demonstrates that these challenges, whether originating from the broader Christian oikoumene or arising indigenously, had significant relevance within the Ethiopian intellectual and spiritual milieu and necessitated a robust patristic response. Beyond formal Christological or Trinitarian disputes, Ethiopian Fathers also confronted and sought to correct syncretic or errant practices among Christians, such as "celebrating certain religious holy days in the form of orgy, taking advice from sorcerers, or praying with magic words" (Getatchew Haile, CE:984a). This

chapter, however, will focus on internal controversies of significant Christological or theological import that elicited substantial patristic responses, shaping the doctrinal landscape of Ethiopian Orthodoxy by examining *how* orthodoxy was defined and defended.

9.1.1 The Estifanosites (Stephanites)

One of the earliest and most significant recorded internal challenges to the established Church's practices and authority was the movement initiated by Abba Estifanos in the 15th century, often referred to as the Estifanosites or Stephanites (Däqiqä ʾƎsṭifanos, **ደቂቀ እስጢፋኖስ**).

- Antecedents and the Ministry of Abba Estifanos: Getatchew Haile (CE:984b) notes that objections to the veneration of icons and the Cross had surfaced earlier, during the reign of Emperor Yagbe'a Seyon (1285-1294), when some clergy controversially dismissed the icon of the Madonna and Child as "mere slate" and the cross as "a mere piece of wood." In the 15th century, Abba Estifanos (Stephen), a monk from the Monastery of Qwayyäsa in Tigray, revived and intensified these concerns. His activity initially focused on criticizing lax ascetic rules in established monasteries, and his decision to found his own monastery based on strict asceticism attracted many followers, posing a challenge to the existing monastic order (Getatchew Haile, CE:984b).
- Core Tenets and Conflict with Imperial and Ecclesiastical Norms: The most distinctive and controversial teaching of the Estifanosites was their insistence that Christians should prostrate themselves (səgdät, **ስግደት**) only before God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit (Getatchew Haile, CE:984b; Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., p. 13). This stance directly conflicted with the increasing imperial demand for prostration before the monarch (Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob) and the growing liturgical emphasis on venerating the Virgin Mary (through her icon) and the Cross. Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob was a fervent promoter of Marian devotion, popularizing translated miracles of Mary and instituting thirty-three Marian holidays based on the Mäṣḥafä Sərʿat (**መጽሐፈ ሥርዓት** – Book of Order) from Muʿallaqa (Getatchew Haile, CE:985a). The Estifanosites, while honoring Mary as the Mother of God (Wälədättä ʾAmlak, **ወላዲተ አምላክ**), considered the level of reverence and prostration demanded by the king for icons, the Cross, and himself to be excessive and an infringement upon the unique worship due to God alone (Getatchew Haile, CE:985a). Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C., p. 14) elaborates that the core of the

dispute lay in the interpretation of the Gəʿəz word *sägädä*. While the Estifanosites reserved it for divine worship, the established Church understood that *səgdät* could also encompass acts of veneration (ʾakbərot səgdät, **አክብሮት ስግደት**) for saints, holy objects, and respected persons. When questioned about not prostrating to Mary, they reportedly answered, "When we prostrate to her Son, we find her there," and "Before this, we have not found [it written] 'I prostrate to Mary,' but only 'I prostrate to the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit'" (Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., p. 15, citing Gädlä ʾAbäw wäʾAḫaw).

- Persecution and Legacy: Due to their unyielding stance, particularly their refusal to prostrate before the Emperor, the Estifanosites "suffered severe persecution, including mass arrest, execution, amputation (especially of hands and tongues), and isolation" (Getatchew Haile, CE:985a). Despite this, Getatchew Haile notes that Metropolitans Mika'el III and Gabre'el showed some sympathy towards them. The Estifanosites' center, the Monastery of Däbrä Garzen in Tigray, eventually came under the authority of the main Church by the mid-16th century, but their movement left an indelible mark, radically questioning the limits of veneration and the relationship between spiritual and temporal authority.

9.1.2 The Ewostatewosites (Followers of Abba Ewosṭatewos)

The debate over the observance of the Sabbath was one of the most significant and enduring internal theological struggles within the Ethiopian Church, with profound patristic implications for defining orthodoxy and Church unity.

- Traditional Observance and the Emergence of Conflict: Getatchew Haile (CE:985a) posits that the Ethiopian Church "probably since its beginning... has observed Saturday as the first Sabbath and Sunday as the Christian Sabbath." This practice was rooted in the understanding of the Ten Commandments and supported by the Synodicon (Sənodos, **ሲኖዶስ**), which attributes the directive to observe both days to the Apostles Peter and Paul. However, a major controversy arose during the reign of Emperor ʿAmda Seyon (1314-1344) when the Coptic Church in Egypt, concerned about perceived "Jewish customs" among Ethiopian Christians, decreed the abolition of Saturday observance (Getatchew Haile, CE:985a).

- The Life and Advocacy of Abba Ewosṭatewos: As detailed in Chapter Four, the highly revered monk Abba Ewosṭatewos (**አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ**) became the leading champion for the continued observance of both Sabbaths. His unwavering commitment to this teaching, which he believed was scripturally and apostolically mandated, brought him into conflict with both the Coptic Abun in Ethiopia and Emperor ʿAmda Seyon. This ultimately led to his self-exile, first to Egypt and then to Armenia (Getatchew Haile, CE:985b; Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., p. 7). His disciples, forming the Betä Ewosṭatewos (**ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ** – House of Ewosṭatewos), steadfastly continued his teachings, particularly in northern Ethiopia (Tigray and Eritrea), creating a significant division within the Church that lasted for over a century.
- The Patristic Resolution by Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob and the Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq: The schism over Sabbath observance was a major concern for Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob. His own extensive theological composition, the Mäṣḥafä Bərhan (***መጽሐፈ ብርሃን*** – Book of Light), strongly advocated for the observance of both Sabbaths (Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., p. 10). To formally resolve the issue and unify the Church, he convened the Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (**ጉባኤ ደብረ ምጥማቅ**) around 1450 CE. Getatchew Haile (CE:985b) recounts that at this council, the Emperor questioned the Metropolitans Mika'el and Gabre'el regarding the scriptural grounds for abolishing the first Sabbath. Finding no such justification in the Scriptures, the Octateuch, the Prophets, the Gospels, or the writings of the apostles, and recalling the Synodicon's directive from Peter and Paul, the Metropolitans reversed the earlier decrees of their predecessors, Abba Sälama II ("the Translator") and Abunä Bartalomewos. This conciliar decision officially affirmed the observance of both Sabbaths in the Ethiopian Church, which, as Getatchew Haile (CE:985b) notes, "starts at sunset on Friday and ends at sunset on Sunday." This resolution was a major achievement of patristic discernment and conciliar authority in Ethiopian Church history.

9.1.3 The Zamika'elites and Other 15th-Century Theological Debates

The vibrant intellectual life of the 15th century, particularly during the reign of Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob, saw the emergence of other theological debates and figures whose teachings were

challenged by the established Church and its leading Fathers like Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča.

- The Zamika'elites on Trinitarian Iconography and Marian Devotion: According to Getatchew Haile (CE:985b-986a), the Zamika'elites, followers of a monastic leader named Zamika'el (and Fre Makhebar), contested the prevailing Church teaching on the Trinity and Marian devotion.
    - Trinitarian Representation: Since the time of Emperor Dawit I, the Church had taught that each Person of the Trinity has an image resembling man, based on Genesis 1:27. Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob used the analogy of three suns with united light (three Persons, one divinity). The Zamika'elites proposed instead the analogy of one sun with a disk (Father), light (Son), and heat (Holy Spirit). They also rejected the teaching that the Father and Holy Spirit would appear with the Son at His Second Coming.
    - Marian Devotion and Canon: They opposed Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob's zealous promotion of translated and newly composed miracles of the Virgin Mary and the dedication of numerous holidays to her. They also disagreed with the constitution of the canonical books of the Church (Getatchew Haile, CE:986a). Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C., p. 11) notes that a figure named ZäMikael (distinct from, or perhaps the same as, the leader of the Zamika'elites) held views that honoring Mary's feasts did not grant forgiveness for grave sins and, like Gämalyal, interpreted Abraham's three visitors as angels and God. Gämalyal, a visually impaired scholar of Zärʾa Yaʿəqob's time, also taught that God has no human-like form, rejected the Täʾammərä Maryam (**ተአምረ ማርያም**), and, like the Stephanites, argued against prostration to the Cross and Mary (Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., pp. 10-11). Abba Giyorgis refuted Gämalyal in his writings.
- Bitu's Christological and Eschatological Divergences: During Emperor Dawit I's reign, a scholar named Bitu propagated teachings deemed unorthodox, particularly concerning Christology and eschatology. Getatchew Haile (CE:984a) mentions Bitu as a "local theologian" refuted in Abba Giyorgis's Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir. Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C., p. 12), drawing from Gädlä Abba Giyorgis and Gädlä Abba Eliyas, details that Bitu taught the Son would come alone at the Second Coming (not with the Father and Holy Spirit)

and held a divisive Christology, suggesting Christ had two natures, possessing knowledge by His divinity but ignorance in His flesh (like humans), and that it was the flesh, separated from the Godhead, that died. Abba Giyorgis engaged Bitu in debate, which led to Abba Giyorgis's temporary exile due to Bitu's machinations.

- Other Challenges: Getatchew Haile (CE:986a) briefly mentions a controversy during Emperor Gälawdewos's reign (1540-1559) regarding the preexistence of souls, possibly an Origenist influence, though it did not have a lasting impact. Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C., p. 17) also refers to challenges from Giyorgis Romawi (George the Roman) who denied angelic intercession and the veneration of icons and the Ark of St. Mary, and from the Kahənatä Agamən̄ (Priests of Agamən̄) who opposed Saturday Sabbath observance based on their interpretation of canonical texts. The comprehensive compositions of Abba Giyorgis, particularly his Fəkkare Haymanot (**ፍካሬ ሃይማኖት**), served as direct patristic responses to many of these divergent teachings (Dn. Daniel Kibret, 2008 E.C., p. 18).

9.1.4 The Gondarine Period Christological Controversies (Revisited Thematically)

The aftermath of the Jesuit presence in the 17th century ushered in another major period of internal theological controversy, distinct from the earlier challenges but equally formative for the Church's doctrinal self-understanding. As Getatchew Haile (CE:986a-b) and Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009, pp. 36-41) explain, questions surrounding the theological meaning of Christ's Unction (qəbᶜat, **ቅብዐት**) and His status as First-born (bäkʷər, **በኵር**) led to the division of the Church's scholars and Fathers into three main schools of thought. These controversies, involving the Täwaḥədo (Unionists, later Karrocc), the Qəbatočč (Unctionists), and the Ṣäggočč (Adoptionists/Ya-Sägga Lejocc), were discussed in detail regarding their specific tenets in Chapter Seven.

Here, the focus is on *how* the engagement with these internal schools itself constituted a patristic "work" of defining Orthodoxy. The Täwaḥədo/Karra school, by vigorously opposing the Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga views—accusing the former of Eutychian tendencies and the latter of Nestorian/Adoptionist errors—was actively involved in delineating the boundaries of acceptable Miaphysite Christology. The debates, though highly politicized during the Zämänä Mäsafənt, forced a deeper articulation of traditional doctrine. The eventual resolution at the Council of Boru Meda in 1878 under Emperor Yohannes IV, which affirmed the Täwaḥədo/Karra position

as the official doctrine, represented a culmination of this long process of internal theological clarification and defense by leading patristic figures of that school.

9.2 The Patristic "Work" of Defining Orthodoxy

The history of theological controversies within the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church is not merely a chronicle of doctrinal deviations but a testament to the vibrant intellectual life of the Church and the profound engagement of its Fathers. From addressing early challenges like Arianism to navigating complex internal debates on the Sabbath, the nature and scope of veneration, Trinitarian expression, and the intricate details of Christ's natures and unction, Ethiopian Fathers consistently undertook the patristic task of discerning truth, defining boundaries, and defending the Rətuᶜa Haymanot.

The contributions of figures like Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča, Emperor Zärᵊa Yaᶜəqob, Abba Ewosṭatewos, Ǝččäge Beträ Giyorgis, and the many scholars involved in the Gondarine debates, demonstrate a deep commitment to scriptural fidelity, apostolic tradition, and rigorous theological reasoning. These controversies, while at times causing painful divisions, also spurred the production of profound theological literature, refined doctrinal understanding, and ultimately contributed to the consolidation of a distinct and resilient Ethiopian Orthodox identity. The engagement with perceived theological divergences thus became an indispensable catalyst for patristic articulation and the ongoing clarification of the Church's sacred teachings for future generations, ensuring the transmission of a faith robustly tested and thoughtfully defended.

Review Questions for Chapter Nine

1. How does Emperor Constantius II's letter regarding Abba Sälama I (St. Frumentius) illustrate Ethiopia's early connection to broader Christian world theological controversies like Arianism, according to Getatchew Haile (CE:984a)?
2. Describe the core tenets of the Estifanosites (Stephanites) regarding veneration and imperial authority, as outlined by Getatchew Haile (CE:984b-985a) and Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C.). How did Emperor Zärᵊa Yaᶜəqob's theological compositions respond to this movement?
3. Explain the origins and development of the Sabbath Controversy in Ethiopia. What was the contribution of Abba Ewosṭatewos, and how did Emperor Zärᵊa Yaᶜəqob and the

Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq address this issue, based on Getatchew Haile (CE:985a-b) and Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C.)?

4. According to Getatchew Haile (CE:985b-986a), what were the main theological objections of the Zamika'elites to the teachings promoted by Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob concerning Trinitarian iconography and Marian devotion?
5. Identify two theological challenges (e.g., teachings of Bitu, Gämalyal, Giyorgis Romawi) that Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča addressed in his patristic compositions, as highlighted by Getatchew Haile (CE:984a) and Dn. Daniel Kibret (2008 E.C.).
6. Briefly summarize the main Christological distinctions between the Täwaḥədo (Unionist/Karra), Qəbatočč (Unctionist), and Ṣäggočč (Adoptionist) schools during the Gondarine controversies, as detailed by Getatchew Haile (CE:986b-987a) and Mebratu Kiros Gebru (2009). How did the Council of Boru Meda (1878) attempt to resolve these debates from the perspective of defining Orthodoxy?
7. How did the Ethiopian Fathers' engagement with these various internal theological challenges and perceived "heresies" contribute to the clarification and articulation of Rətuᶜa Haymanot (Orthodox Faith) and the development of Ethiopian patristic literature?

Chapter Ten

10 Autocephaly and the Living Patristic Tradition in Contemporary Ethiopia

Chapter Objectives

- To explore Emperor Haile Selassie I's (**ቀዳማዊ ኃይለ ሥላሴ**) continuing patristic vision and contributions for the Church and nation in the mid-20th century, including his efforts in educational reform, the publication of patristic texts, and fostering ecumenical dialogue.
- To analyze the Italian Occupation (1936-1941) as a severe test of the Church's patristic resilience (ṣənat, **ጽናት**) and the martyrdom (səmaᶜətännät, **ሰማዕትነት**) of its Fathers like Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**) as profound acts of witness.
- To detail the theological, canonical, and national arguments underpinning the long journey to autocephaly (rasəwan yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan, **ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን**), emphasizing Emperor Haile Selassie I's diplomatic activity and culminating in the historic consecration of the first Ethiopian Patriarch, Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**), whose life and leadership became foundational for the autocephalous Church.
- To examine the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church's engagement with the wider Oriental Orthodox Communion, particularly the significance of the 1965 Addis Ababa Conference as a collective patristic endeavor, and its early involvement in the modern ecumenical movement (ḥəbrätä ʾabəyatä krəstiyanat, **ሕብረተ ዐብያተ ክርስቲያናት**).
- To discuss the development of modern theological scholarship alongside traditional learning, highlighting the lives and significant contributions of influential 20th-century Fathers like Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**), Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**) (author of *Kʷäkʷəḥa Haymanot*, **ኰኵሐ ሃይማኖት** and *Mədlotä Amin*, **መድሎተ አሚን**), and Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**) (author of *Yäʾ Ityoppəya ʾƎmmənät BäSostu Həggəgat*), and the role of institutions like the Holy Trinity Theological College.
- To analyze how the EOTC continues to engage its patristic heritage (rəstä ʾabäw, **ርስተ አበው**) through the spiritual witness and scholarly endeavors of its contemporary Fathers

in responding to modern challenges such as the 1974 Revolution (ʾabyot, **አብዮት**) and the diaspora (sədtät, **ስደት**).

- To affirm the enduring vitality (ḥəyawənnät, **ሕያውነት**) and contemporary relevance of the Ethiopian patristic heritage, as embodied in the ongoing spiritual lives and intellectual contributions of its faithful leaders and scholars.

The reign of Emperor Haile Selassie I (**ቀዳማዊ ኃይለ ሥላሴ**), spanning from his regency in the early 20th century to his deposition in 1974, ushered in an era of truly profound transformation for both the Ethiopian nation and its ancient Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church. This period witnessed the culmination of centuries-old aspirations for ecclesiastical independence (autocephaly) through the dedicated efforts of its leaders; a renewed and systematic engagement with the Church's rich patristic heritage through modern means of education and publication championed by its leading figures; and an unprecedented projection of Ethiopian Orthodoxy onto the global stage. However, it was also an era marked by severe trials, most notably the brutal Italian Fascist Occupation, which tested the Church's resilience and the steadfastness of its Fathers to the very core.

Throughout these tumultuous decades, a distinct "patristic vision" often guided imperial policy and ecclesiastical endeavors. This vision sought to strengthen the Church as the bedrock of national identity and the faithful guardian of Ethiopia's unique Christian tradition, while simultaneously navigating the complexities of the modern world and asserting Ethiopia's ancient Christian voice in global ecumenical conversations. This chapter explores these critical developments, focusing on the theological and canonical journey to autocephaly as a defining patristic milestone, the Church's evolving role under its indigenous Patriarchs, the contributions of key 20th-century Fathers in preserving and articulating the faith through their spiritual lives and scholarly output, and the ongoing engagement with its patristic legacy in contemporary times.

10.1 Emperor Haile Selassie I's Patristic Vision and Contributions for Church and Nation

Emperor Haile Selassie I, even from his early years as Ras Täfäri Mäkonnən, possessed a deep understanding of the EOTC's historical significance and its foundational role in Ethiopian identity. His vision for a modern Ethiopia was inextricably linked to the strengthening of its

ancient Church, emphasizing its apostolic foundations (hawaryawi masarat, **ሐዋርያዊ መሠረት**) and unbroken tradition (təwəfit, **ትውፊት**).

- Educational Reform and Publication of Patristic Texts as Imperial Initiatives: The Emperor recognized the vital importance of education for both clergy and laity to ensure the robust transmission of the patristic heritage. His initiatives in this area included instrumental support for the establishment of the Theological College of the Holy Trinity (**ቅድስት ሥላሴ መንፈሳዊ ኮሌጅ**) in Addis Ababa (officially inaugurated 1960, though teaching began earlier). This institution was intended to provide advanced theological training, combining traditional Ethiopian Orthodox learning with modern pedagogical methods, thereby equipping a new generation of patristic scholars.
  Under his patronage, significant publication projects were undertaken to make sacred knowledge (qəddus ʾəwqät, **ቅዱስ ዕውቀት**) more accessible. The most notable among these was the first complete Amharic Bible translation printed in Ethiopia, the Haile Selassie I Bible (published in 1962 G.C./1955 E.C.). Numerous liturgical books (mäṣaḥəftä qəddase, **መጻሕፍተ ቅዳሴ**), commentaries, and other traditional religious texts were also printed, a crucial step in preserving and disseminating the literary heritage of the Ethiopian Fathers.
- Ecumenical Vision and Assertion of Patristic Identity: The 1955 Revised Constitution of Ethiopia defined the Emperor's role as "Defender of the Faith" (ṭäbbaqi haymanot, **ጠባቂ ሃይማኖት**) (Macar, in Chaillot, 2016, p. 170). Emperor Haile Selassie I saw the EOTC not as an isolated entity but as a venerable member of the universal Church. His work in fostering ecumenical dialogue, particularly in convening the 1965 Addis Ababa Conference of Oriental Orthodox Heads, and his support for Ethiopian participation in the wider ecumenical movement (e.g., the World Council of Churches), reflected a deep confidence in Ethiopia's own patristic tradition and its capacity to contribute to global Christian understanding (Macar, in Chaillot, 2016, pp. 170-171).

10.1.1 Martyrdom as Patristic Witness and the Church's Resilience (Ṣənat, **ጽናት**)

The Italian Fascist occupation of Ethiopia (1936-1941) posed one of the gravest threats to the Church's existence and integrity in its long history. The Italian administration actively sought to undermine the EOTC's authority and sever its ancient canonical ties with the Coptic Patriarchate

of Alexandria. This included the uncanonical appointment of Abba Abraham as "Archbishop" after exiling the legitimate Coptic Metropolitan, Abunä Qerillos (**አቡነ ቄርሎስ**), a direct assault on apostolic succession (Ademe & Ali, 2023).

- Martyrdom as the Ultimate Patristic Testimony: In this dark period, the martyrdom (səmaᶜətännät, **ሰማዕትነት**) of key Ethiopian Church Fathers became powerful symbols of resistance and unwavering faith. Their ultimate sacrifice was a profound act of witness (səmaᶜət, **ምስክርነት**) to the truth of the Gospel and the inviolability of their Church.
    - Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**) of Wollo: The life of this courageous bishop culminated in the ultimate act of martyrdom. He publicly condemned the Italian invasion and the atrocities committed, and famously excommunicated (wəgəzät, **ውግዘት**) all Ethiopians who collaborated with the Fascist regime. Given the choice to retract his condemnation or face death, Abunä Peṭros chose martyrdom, upholding the truth (ʾəwənät, **እውነት**) of his apostolic office. He was publicly executed in Addis Ababa in July 1936, and his martyrdom became an enduring symbol of Ethiopian patriotism and Orthodox fidelity, a spiritual legacy that continues to inspire.
    - Abunä Mikael (**አቡነ ሚካኤል**) of Gojjam: The life of this bishop also ended in martyrdom for his staunch resistance to the Italian occupation and his refusal to submit to the uncanonical church structure imposed by the occupiers. His death was another powerful testimony that fueled the spirit of resistance.
- The Church's Broader Resilience: Beyond these prominent martyrdoms, countless clergy, monks, and nuns performed acts of courage by supporting the patriotic resistance movement (ʾarbäñña-nnät, **አርበኝነት**), often at great personal risk. Monasteries served as refuges and centers of patriotic activity. The Church's ability to withstand this intense persecution and emerge with its core identity intact was a testament to its deep patristic roots and the resilience (ṣənat) instilled by centuries of faith.

10.1.2 The Long Journey to Autocephaly

The trauma of the Italian Occupation starkly highlighted the vulnerabilities inherent in the EOTC's centuries-old dependence on the See of Alexandria for the consecration of its Metropolitan. This experience, coupled with a growing sense of national and ecclesiastical

maturity, reinvigorated the long-held aspiration for autocephaly (rasəwan yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan, **ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን** – "a Church that governs herself").

- Patristic Arguments and Imperial Diplomatic Efforts: The arguments for autocephaly were deeply patristic. Ethiopian leaders and scholars emphasized the Church's apostolic origins (tracing back to the Ethiopian Eunuch), its nearly two millennia of continuous Christian life, its rich indigenous literary and theological tradition (the contributions of its own Fathers), its vast size and pastoral needs, canonical precedents for autocephaly in other ancient churches, and the dignity of the Ethiopian nation. Emperor Haile Selassie I made the achievement of autocephaly a cornerstone of his imperial policy, tirelessly championing the cause through decades of complex diplomatic activity with the Coptic Patriarchate and the Egyptian government (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 35; Macar, in Chaillot, 2016, p. 169).
- Culmination in the First Ethiopian Patriarchate: The journey reached its historic culmination in 1959 with the consecration of Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**) as the first Patriarch of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, by the Coptic Patriarch Cyril VI (Ademe & Ali, 2023, p. 2). The life of Abunä Basilios, who had previously served as superior (mämgəb, **መምጎብ**) of the Ethiopian monastery in Jerusalem and later as Archbishop, was now dedicated to the foundational leadership of the newly autocephalous Church. This achievement was a profound patristic milestone, signifying the full maturity and canonical independence of one of the world's oldest Christian traditions. It allowed the EOTC to appoint its own bishops and Patriarch, fully governing its internal affairs according to its ancient faith and order.

10.1.3 Patristic Engagement in a Global Context

The achievement of autocephaly empowered the EOTC to engage more fully and confidently with the wider Christian world, bringing its unique patristic voice to global conversations.

- Strengthening Oriental Orthodox Unity – The 1965 Addis Ababa Conference: A landmark achievement of this new era was the Addis Ababa Conference of the Heads of Oriental Orthodox Churches in January 1965. Convened under the patronage of Emperor Haile Selassie I and the leadership of Patriarch Abunä Basilios, it was the first such gathering in over fifteen centuries (Sergew & Taddese, 1970, p. 36). Its primary outcome

was to reaffirm the shared apostolic faith (hawaryawi haymanot, **ሐዋርያዊ ሃይማኖት**) and common patristic heritage uniting the Oriental Orthodox Churches (Coptic, Syrian, Armenian, Indian, and Ethiopian), based on their acceptance of the first three Ecumenical Councils and their shared understanding of the Christology of St. Cyril of Alexandria (Qerəllos, **ቄርሎስ**). Ethiopian Fathers played a pivotal role in this collective patristic endeavor of fostering unity and mutual understanding.

- Ethiopian Fathers and the Pursuit of Reconciliation: Ethiopian Fathers, alongside their counterparts from other Oriental Orthodox Churches, actively participated in theological dialogues aimed at healing the ancient schism with the Eastern (Chalcedonian) Orthodox Churches. This effort of reconciliation centered on re-examining the Council of Chalcedon (451 AD) through the lens of the shared patristic tradition of the early centuries, with the Christology of St. Cyril often serving as a crucial bridge.
  Fathers like Patriarch Abunä Theophilos (**አቡነ ቴዎፍሎስ**) (Second Patriarch, 1971-1976, martyred 1979), known for his ecumenical vision and scholarly depth, guided the EOTC's engagement in these dialogues. These efforts led to Agreed Statements (e.g., Second Chambésy Statement, 1990), which affirmed that both Orthodox families maintained the same apostolic Christological faith despite historical terminological differences. This was a testament to the patristic methodology of returning to the sources (ad fontes) and seeking unity in essentials.

10.2 The Lives and Contributions of 20th-Century Fathers

Throughout the 20th century, even amidst profound social and political changes, the EOTC's ancient tradition of scholarship continued through the dedicated lives and intellectual achievements of its learned Fathers (liqawənt, **ሊቃውንት**). They ensured the transmission of the patristic heritage while also engaging with modern forms of education and dissemination.

10.2.1 Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**)

(ca. 1868 – 1967 G.C.) The life of this towering traditional scholar, born near the end of Emperor Tewodros II's reign, spanned multiple imperial eras. His educational journey, as detailed in *Zəkrä Liqawənt Kalə*ʾ(Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2004 E.C., pp. 57-59), was extensive. He began with Nəbab

Bet and Məᶜraf in his native Shäwa, received deaconate orders from Abunä Peṭros, and then delved deeply into Ṣäwatəwä Zema. His quest for knowledge led him to study Qəne under renowned masters like Mərgeta Qäṣäla, "Ṣäḥay Fänta" in Wadla, Mämhər Wäsäne Kəfläy in Amhara Sayənt, and Mämhər Täṭämqä in Gojjam, mastering diverse Qəne styles. His advanced textual interpretation (Tərgʷame) included studying Old Testament texts, Monastic Writings (Mäṣaḥəftä Mänäkʷəsat), New Testament books, and Haymanotä Abäw under masters like Aläqa Wäldä Mädḫən of Asäbot and Mämhər Wälättä Maryam of Däbrä Bəgəᶜ. He also studied the interpretations of Qerəllos and Yoḥannəs Afäwärq. Aläqa Lämma's activity also involved administrative roles, serving as head of Däbrä Sälam Qäčäne Mädhane Aläm in Addis Ababa and Adere Ṭiqo Śəllase in Harar. His profound learning and ability to provide insightful historical and theological analyses made him a living repository of tradition. His memoirs, *Mäshafä Təzzəta zäʾAläqa Lämma (መጽሐፈ ትዝታ ዘአለቃ ለማ – The Book of Aläqa Lämma's Reminiscences)*, are a significant literary contribution preserving invaluable traditional knowledge. His long life allowed him to witness and interpret nearly a century of Ethiopian history through a patristic lens.

10.2.2 Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ)

(1885 E.C. [ca. 1893 G.C.] – 2000 E.C. [ca. 2007/08 G.C.]): The life of this "Four-Eyed" (ʾArat ᶜAyna, **አራት ዐይና**) scholar, born in Dima Giyorgis, Gojjam, was one of profound learning and teaching, as detailed in *Fəre Liqawənt* (Mahibere Kidusan, 2010 E.C., pp. 62-65). His early education in Dima included Fidel, Dawit, Ṣomä Dəggʷa, Məᶜraf, Dəggʷa, Zəmmare, Mäwasəʾət, and Qəne. His journey for advanced learning took him to Dessie to study Ḥaddisat and Mäṣaḥəftä Liqawənt under the great Mämhər Akalä Wäld of Boru Meda. He later studied Bluyat in Gojjam under Aläqa Gäbrä Elyas and Qəne under Mäʾəläkä Sälam Gäbrä Maryam Dənbəṣa, before returning to Dima to teach Qəne.

His literary compositions are seminal for modern Ethiopian Patrology:

- *Kʷäkʷəḥa Haymanot (ኰኵሐ ሃይማኖት – The Rock of Faith):* This comprehensive exposition of EOTC doctrines is perhaps his most famous work. Written to refute teachings perceived as divergent, it articulates Trinitarian theology, Täwaḥədo Christology, and Mariology with extensive scriptural proofs

(ṭəqsä mäṣḥaf, **ጥቅሰ መጽሐፍ**) and deep Andəmta grounding, serving as a modern compendium of patristic thought.

- *Mədlotä Amin (**መድሎተ አሚን** – Balance of Faith):* This text was specifically written to refute Dyophysite Christology, particularly targeting internal views influenced by or similar to the Qəbᶜat and Ṣägga understandings that were perceived as remnants or re-emergences of Catholic-influenced Christologies (Melkamu Beyene, 2017, analyzing Admasu Jembere's intent).
- Other Contributions: Melake Birhan Admasu was known for his powerful preaching, his advocacy for an Ethiopian Patriarchate, and his efforts to preserve the writings of other scholars, notably through his book *Zəkrä Liqawənt (**ዝክረ ሊቃውንት** – Memorial of the Scholars).* His life was a testament to deep scholarship, traditional sanctity, and unwavering defense of the Orthodox faith, effectively making him a contemporary Father continuing the patristic tradition. He also compiled *Yäbägäna Mäzmur* and saw his draft of *Mäṣḥafä Gəṣṣawe* eventually published under imperial patronage. He held titles such as Məgabe Məsṭir, Liqä Ṭäbbəbt, and finally Melake Birhan.

10.2.3 Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**)

(d. Nəḥase 14, 1999 E.C. [ca. Aug 20/21, 2007 G.C.]): The life of Aläqa Ayalew, born in Dima Giyorgis, Gojjam, was one of extraordinary scholarly achievement despite losing his sight at age four (Kəfyaläw Məraḥi, 2004 E.C., pp. 195-199). His scholarly journey began with traditional church education in 1926 E.C., mastering Ṣäwatəwä Zema, Gəᶜəz language, and initial New Testament interpretation. His extensive studies included interpretation of Psalms, Prophets, and Solomonic books under Abba Akalu; Wəddase Maryam and Qəddase Maryam under Mämhər Adəgu ZäWəᶜəde Maryam. Under Patriarch Abunä Basəlyos's auspices at Holy Trinity, he studied further biblical books with interpretation. His studies extended to Daniel, Old Testament books, Enoch, Gospels, Mäṣḥafä Kidan, and prophetic teachings under various masters like Məgabe Məsṭir Gera Wärq and Mämhər Gäbrä Maryam. Crucially, he also embraced modern learning by studying Braille at the Swedish Evangelical Mission School.

Aläqa Ayalew's contributions included teaching Qəne at Däbrä Amin Täklä Haymanot, where he later became Liqä Ṭäbbəbt and then Aläqa. He was a prominent and eloquent defender of the

Täwaḥədo faith, serving for many years as the head of the EOTC Liqawənt Council, responsible for Church culture and history. His work, *Yäʾ Ityoppəya ʾƎmmənät BäSostu Həggəgat (የኢትዮጵያ እምነት በሦስቱ ሕግጋት – The Faith of Ethiopia in the Three Laws/Dispensations)*, published in 1953 E.C., stands as a significant articulation of Ethiopian Orthodox doctrine. His life was dedicated to protecting and expounding the faith, order, and tradition of the Church for nearly half a century. He was remembered by contemporaries like Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere as an irreplaceable scholar.

These Fathers, and institutions like the Holy Trinity Theological College, represent the dual endeavor of preserving ancient traditional scholarship while also engaging with modern methods of theological education and dissemination.

10.3 Contemporary Challenges and the Ongoing Patristic Engagement

The Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church continues to draw life and guidance from the spiritual witness and intellectual legacies of its historical and contemporary Fathers. The 1974 Ethiopian Revolution (ʾabyot, **አብዮት**) and the subsequent Marxist Derg regime brought immense challenges, including persecution, confiscation of property, and attempts to undermine the Church's influence (Larebo, 1984). Yet, the Church demonstrated remarkable resilience, a testament to its deep patristic foundations. The succession of Patriarchs since autocephaly—Abunä Basilios, Abunä Theophilos, Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), Abunä Mərqorewos (**አቡነ መርቆሬዎስ**), Abunä Pawlos (**አቡነ ጳውሎስ**), and Abunä Mathias (**አቡነ ማትያስ**)—has seen each Father's life dedicated to the task of shepherding the Church through unique and often severe trials.

Contemporary challenges persist, including internal divisions that sometimes mirror old theological fault lines or new political pressures (Ademe & Ali, 2023), navigating a rapidly changing and increasingly pluralistic Ethiopian society (Feyissa, 2025), and addressing the pastoral and cultural needs of a vast and growing global diaspora (sədtät, **ስደት**) (Abba Thaddaeus, 2020; Fikre Mariam Workneh, 2019). The task of Ethiopian Patrology today involves applying the wisdom of past Fathers to these contemporary issues. This includes:

- Striving for internal reconciliation (ʾərq, **ዕርቅ**) and institutional reform based on canonical and patristic principles.

- Developing a patristically-grounded theology of coexistence and engagement with a multi-religious and secularizing world.
- Strengthening indigenous scholarship and education, including the critical edition and translation of the Gəᶜəz compositions of the Fathers, and supporting traditional Qes Təmhərt Betoch.
- Addressing diasporic challenges through sensitive inculturation, maintaining doctrinal integrity while overcoming cultural and linguistic barriers.

The Ethiopian patristic heritage, embodied in the spiritual lives and intellectual contributions of its holy Fathers, remains an inexhaustible source of spiritual nourishment (mänfäsawi məgəb, **መንፈሳዊ ምግብ**), doctrinal clarity, and moral guidance. It is a living tradition that continues to demonstrate the unceasing activity of the Holy Spirit within the Church, offering profound insights not only for the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church but for the universal Christian family.

Review Questions for Chapter Ten

1. Describe Emperor Haile Selassie I's "patristic vision" for the EOTC. How were his initiatives in educational reform (e.g., establishing the Holy Trinity Theological College) and the publication of texts (e.g., the Amharic Bible) part of this vision?
2. How did the Italian Occupation (1936-1941) test the EOTC's "patristic resilience" (ṣənat, **ጽናት**)? Discuss the martyrdom (səmaᶜətännät, **ሰማዕትነት**) of Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**) as a profound act of witness.
3. Outline the key patristic, canonical, and national arguments that underpinned the long journey to autocephaly. What was Emperor Haile Selassie I's diplomatic role in this process, and why is the consecration of Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**) considered a "patristic milestone"?
4. Discuss the significance of the 1965 Addis Ababa Conference of Oriental Orthodox Heads as a collective patristic endeavor. How did it reflect the EOTC's engagement with the wider Oriental Orthodox Communion following autocephaly?
5. Describe the life and scholarly contributions of Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**). How does his educational journey and literary output (e.g., *Mäshafä Təzzəta*) represent the transmission of the patristic heritage in the 20th century?

6. Detail the life and major literary contributions of Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere. How do his compositions like *Kʷäkʷəḥa Haymanot* and *Mədlotä Amin* serve as modern contributions to Ethiopian Patrology?
7. Describe the life and scholarly achievements of Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru, including his educational path, his work *Yäʾ Ityoppəya ʾƎmmənät BäSostu Həggəgat*, and his role in the Liqawənt Council.
8. Identify two major challenges confronting the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church today (e.g., internal divisions, diaspora needs, political pressures).
9. How does the ongoing activity of contemporary EOTC Fathers (Patriarchs, bishops, scholars) demonstrate the "living tradition" (ḥəyaw təwəfit) of Ethiopian Patrology in the 21st century?

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General Conclusion

A Living Patristic Heritage for a Global Church

Our journey through the vast and luminous landscape of Ethiopian Patrology, as presented in this module, has now drawn to its formal close. Yet, in the truest sense, it marks not an end, but an invigorating commencement—an earnest invitation to continued exploration, deeper engagement, and sustained reflection on a spiritual and intellectual tradition of immense global significance. Over the preceding ten chapters, we have endeavored to trace the remarkable trajectory of Christian thought and spiritual life as it has been articulated, defended, transmitted, and profoundly lived out by the holy Fathers (*Qəddusan ʾAbatočč*, **ቅዱሳን አባቶች**) of the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church (*ʾItyoṗṗəya Ortodoks Täwaḥədo Betä Krəstiyan*, **የኢትዮጵያ ኦርቶዶክስ ተዋሕዶ ቤተ ክርስቲያን**) across nearly two millennia. This exploration has sought to move beyond a mere survey, aiming instead for a meaningful encounter with a "living tradition" (*ḥəyaw təwəfit*, **ሕያው ትውፊት**), one that continues to be shaped by the enduring legacy of their "lives" (*ḥəywät*, **ሕይወት**) and "works" (*śəraḥočč*, **ሥራዎች**).

From the fertile soil of Aksum, where the apostolic seeds of faith were nurtured by the episcopal and translational "works" of Abba Sälama (**አባ ሰላማ**) and the monastic and doctrinal "works" of the Nine Saints (*Täsᶜatu Qəddusan*, **ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን**), we witnessed the blossoming of a profoundly indigenous Christian expression. The sublime liturgical theology of Saint Yared (*Qəddus Yared*, **ቅዱስ ያሬድ**), whose *Zema* (**ዜማ**) remains the sacred heartbeat of Ethiopian worship, and the monumental faith expressed in the rock-hewn patristic statements of the Zagwe era, particularly by St. Lalibäla (**ቅዱስ ላሊበላ**), stand as powerful early testaments to this indigenous genius.

Our path then led us through the "Golden Age" of medieval Ethiopian Patrology, encountering the great monastic theologians such as Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (**አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ**) and Abunä Täklä Haymanot (**አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት**), whose "works" founded enduring spiritual and intellectual centers. We explored the unparalleled systematizing intellect of Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (**አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘጋሥጫ**) and the unique "works" of the theologian-emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (**አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ**). Their extensive *Gəᶜəz* (**ግዕዝ**) writings, deeply informed by the unique hermeneutical lens of the *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**) tradition, solidified the doctrinal foundations of

Ethiopian Orthodoxy, particularly its unwavering commitment to *Täwaḥədo* (**ተዋሕዶ**) Christology and its profound Marian devotion.

The resilience of these Fathers was starkly tested during the existential crises of the 16th century. From that crucible emerged the powerful apologetic "works" of Ǝcc̣äge Ǝnbaqom (**እጨጌ ዕንባቆም**), the confessional "work" of Emperor Gälawdewos (**አፄ ገላውዴዎስ**), and the historical-theological reflections of Abba Baḥrəy (**አባ ባሕርይ**), each defending the ancestral faith (*Rətuᶜa Haymanot*, **ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**) with courage and intellectual rigor against external threats. The subsequent Gondarine period, though characterized by intense internal Christological debates (*kərkər haymanot*, **ክርክር ሃይማኖት**) around *Qəbᶜat* (**ቅብዐት**) and *Ṣägga* (**ጸጋ**) doctrines, also witnessed the remarkable scholarly "work" of Fathers like Mämhər Esdros (**መምህር ኤስድሮስ**) in refining the *Andəmta* tradition, and the steadfast apologetic "work" of figures like Ǝcc̣äge Beträ Giyorgis (**እጨጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ**) against earlier Jesuit challenges, all attesting to the continuous intellectual vitality of the Church. Our thematic exploration of various internal theological challenges, including the movements of the Estifanosites and Ewostatewosites, further revealed how Ethiopian Fathers defined and defended Orthodoxy against "heresies" (*mənfəqəna*, **ምንፍቅና**), thereby shaping and clarifying the Church's doctrinal boundaries through their discerning "works."

The imperial drive for unification in the 19th century, culminating in the conciliar "work" of Boru Meda (**ጉባኤ ቦሩ ሜዳ**), sought to standardize patristic doctrine as a cornerstone of national identity. This endeavor was carried forward by the scholarly "works" of Fathers like Mämhər Akalä Wäld (**መምህር አካለ ወልድ**) and Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (**አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ**). The 20th century brought both immense trials, such as the Italian Occupation and the martyrdom (*səmaᶜətənnät*, **ሰማዕትነት**) of Fathers like Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**), and profound triumphs, most notably the achievement of autocephaly (*rasəwan yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan*, **ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን**). This era was also graced by the "lives and works" of towering traditional scholars like Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**), Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**), and Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**), who ensured the transmission of the patristic heritage (*rəstä ʾabäw*, **ርስተ አበው**) while engaging with the modern world and its challenges, including the Revolution (*ʾabyot*, **አብዮት**) and the realities of the diaspora (*sədtät*, **ስደት**).

What, then, are the enduring insights gleaned from this journey into Ethiopian Patrology? Firstly, it offers an indispensable corrective to Eurocentric narratives of Christian history. The "lives and works" of the Ethiopian Fathers reveal an ancient, vibrant, and intellectually sophisticated African Christian tradition that developed with remarkable continuity, indigenous creativity, and profound theological depth, long before and often independent of Western Christian historical trajectories.

Secondly, the consistent emphasis on a "living tradition" (*ḥəyaw təwəfit*, **ሕያው ትውፊት**) within Ethiopian Orthodoxy means that the wisdom of the Fathers is not confined to dusty archives but remains a vital and dynamic source of spiritual nourishment (*mänfäsawi məgəb*, **መንፈሳዊ ምግብ**), doctrinal guidance, and moral orientation for the Church and its faithful in the contemporary world. The complex challenges facing the EOTC today—from maintaining internal unity (*ḥədənät*, **ኀድነት**) and navigating a rapidly globalizing and pluralistic society, to addressing the pastoral needs of a burgeoning diaspora and engaging with complex socio-political realities—all demand a renewed, critical, and creative engagement with this rich patristic wellspring.

Thirdly, the decolonizing lens through which this module has approached Ethiopian Patrology encourages us to continue valuing, uplifting, and rigorously studying indigenous Ethiopian knowledge systems (*ṭəbäb*, **ጥበብ**), theological expressions, hermeneutical approaches like the *Andəmta*, and the *Gəʿəz* literary heritage. Recognizing their intrinsic worth and their unique contribution to the universal Church is essential for a truly global and inclusive understanding of Christian history and thought.

The study of Ethiopian Patrology is, by its very nature, an ongoing endeavor. Countless manuscripts (*bərannawočč*, **ብራናዎች**) housed in monasteries and libraries worldwide still await critical edition, translation, and deep theological analysis. The spiritual insights and theological formulations of the Ethiopian Fathers continue to invite and reward scholarly exploration, offering fresh perspectives on perennial questions of faith.

It is our earnest hope that this module has not only illuminated the historical path and theological contributions of the Ethiopian Fathers but has also ignited a lasting desire for ongoing study, critical engagement, and profound appreciation of their enduring legacy. The unfolding tapestry of Ethiopian patristic wisdom, meticulously woven with threads of unwavering faith, profound scholarship, courageous witness, and an abiding love for Christ and His Church, remains a

vibrant and essential heritage. It is a heritage not just for the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church, but for all who seek to understand the richness, diversity, and resilience of the Christian tradition in its global expressions. May the spirit (*mänfäs*, **መንፈስ**) and wisdom (*ṭəbäb*, **ጥበብ**) of these holy Fathers continue to inspire and guide all who engage with their sacred story, fostering a deeper understanding and a more inclusive vision of the Christian past, present, and future.

Mämhər Behailu Bekele

Glossary of Gəʿəz and Key Theological Terms

A

- *ʾAbat / ʾAbatočč* (**አባት / አባቶች**): Father / Fathers. A title of respect for monks, clergy, and especially for those recognized for their sanctity and significant contributions to the Church's faith and life; the Church Fathers.
- *ʾAbəyatä Krəstiyanat* (**አብያተ ክርስቲያናት**): Churches (plural of *Betä Krəstiyan*).
- *ʾAbəyatä Təmhərt* (**አብያተ ትምህርት**): Houses of learning; traditional church schools.
- *ʾAbṭəlis* (**አብጥሊስ**): (Gr. *Apostolos*) Canons of the Apostles; a collection of ancient ecclesiastical regulations.
- *Abun* (**አቡን**): "Our Father"; title for the Metropolitan Bishop, historically appointed from Alexandria, and later for Ethiopian bishops and the Patriarch.
- *Abušakər / Abušaḫər* (**አቡሻክር / አቡሻሕር**): A work of chronography, a type of historical and calendrical computation.
- *ʾAbyot* (**አብዮት**): Revolution, specifically referring to the 1974 Ethiopian Revolution.
- *ʾAkal / ʾAkalat* (**አካል / አካላት**): Person, hypostasis / Persons, hypostases. A key term in Trinitarian and Christological theology.
- *Äläqa* (**አለቃ**): Chief, head, master; a title for a highly learned traditional scholar.
- *Almaqah* (**አልማቃሕ**): A pre-Christian South Arabian moon god worshipped in ancient Ethiopia.
- *ʾAmlak* (**አምላክ**): God.
- *ʾAmləko* (**አምልኮ**): Worship, adoration, divine service; specifically the worship due to God alone.
- *Andəmta* (**አንድምታ**): "One says"; the traditional Ethiopian system of biblical and textual commentary, primarily in Amharic, explaining Gəʿəz texts.
- *Anqäṣä Bərhan* (**አንቀጸ ብርሃን**): "Gate of Light"; a famous Marian hymn attributed to St. Yared.
- *Anqäṣä Amin* (**አንቀጸ አሚን**): "Gate of Faith"; title of Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom's major apologetic work.
- **Apostolic Succession** : The unbroken line of bishops, and thus faith and practice, believed to extend back to the Apostles.

- *ʾAqqwqwam* (አቋቋም): Sacred dance and liturgical performance, often accompanying Zema.
- *ʾAqabe Säʿat* (ዐቃቤ ሰዓት): "Keeper of the Hour/Time"; a high-ranking monastic official, often abbot of Däbrä Hayq, who served as head of the imperial clergy and a key spiritual advisor.
- *ʾArat ʿAyna* (አራት ዐይና): "Four-Eyed"; a title for a scholar of the highest learning, proficient in all major branches of traditional Ethiopian education.
- *Araray* (አራራይ): One of the three main melodic modes of St. Yared, characterized by its festive and ornamented nature.
- *Arke* (አርኬ): A specific type of hymn or poetic style, often attributed to Arkä Śəllus.
- *Arganonä Maryam* (አርጋኖነ ማርያም): "Harp/Organ of Mary"; a major Marian devotional work by Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.
- *Aryam* (አርያም): "Exalted/Heavenly"; a specific hymn and melodic pattern attributed to St. Yared, often associated with heavenly praise.
- *ʾAśratä Maryam* (ዓሥራተ ማርያም): "Tithe of Mary"; the tradition that Ethiopia is a special portion or tithe dedicated to the Virgin Mary.
- *ʾAṣe* (አፄ): Emperor.
- Autocephaly (ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን): "A Church that Governs Herself"; ecclesiastical self-governance, independence from another see.

B

- *Baḥrəy / Baḥrəyat* (ባሕርይ / ባሕርያት): Nature, essence, substance / Natures, essences. A key term in Christological discussions.
- *Bäkʷər* (በኵር): First-born.
- *Bəranna / Bərannawočč* (ብራና / ብራናዎች): Parchment / Parchments; the primary material for Ethiopian manuscripts.
- *Betä Ewosṭatewos* (ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ): "House of Ewosṭatewos"; the monastic confederation following Abba Ewosṭatewos, particularly regarding Sabbath observance.

D

- *Dagəmä Məṣʾat* (ዳግመ ምጽአት): Second Coming (of Christ).
- *Däğğ* (ደጅ): Royal court, palace gate.

- *Dəggʷa* (**ድጓ**): The great antiphonary of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, containing hymns for the entire liturgical year, primarily attributed to St. Yared.
- *Dərsan / Dərsanat* (**ድርሳን** / **ድርሳናት**): Homily, discourse, treatise / Homilies.
- *Dədsqəlya* (**ዲድስቅልያ**): (*Didascalia Apostolorum*) An early Christian church order.

Ǝ

- *Ǝčč̣äge* (**እጨጌ**): The administrative head of all monasteries in Ethiopia, historically the highest-ranking Ethiopian-born church official.
- *ʾƎgziʾabəḥer Nägśä* (**እግዚአብሔር ነግሠ**): "God has Reigned" or "The Lord Reigns"; title of a significant collection of hymns.
- *ʾƎnbäräm Kahən* (**እንበረም ካህን**): Enbaräm the Priest; a figure mentioned in some indigenous traditions related to St. Frumentius.
- *ʾƏrq* (**ዕርቅ**): Reconciliation.
- *ʾƎsṭifanosites* (**ደቂቀ እስጢፋኖስ** - *Däqiqä ʾƎsṭifanos*): Stephanites; followers of Abba Estifanos.
- *Ewostatewosites* (**ቤተ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ** - *Betä Ewosṭatewos*): Followers of Abba Ewosṭatewos.
- *ʾƎzəl* (**ዕዝል**): One of the three main melodic modes of St. Yared, characterized by its flowing and often plaintive nature.

F

- *Fəqadä ʾƎgziʾabḥer* (**ፈቃደ እግዚአብሔር**): The will of God, divine providence.
- *Fidel* (**ፊደል**): The Gəʿəz syllabary/alphabet.
- *Filkəsyus* (**ፊልክስዩስ**): Philoxenus; a collection of ascetic writings translated into Gəʿəz.
- *Fəkkare Haymanot* (**ፍካሬ ሃይማኖት**): "Exposition of Faith"; a theological treatise, notably by Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.

G

- *Gädl / Gädlät* (**ገድል** / **ገድላት**): Hagiography, "Acts" or "Struggles" of a saint / Hagiographies.
- *Gəʿəz* (**ግዕዝ**): The classical Semitic language of Ethiopia, the liturgical and scholarly language of the EOTC. Also one of St. Yared's melodic modes.
- *Gəbər* (**ግብር**): Work, deed, action.

- *Gəbrä Ḥəmamat* (ግብረ ሕማማት): "Rite of Passion Week"; the lectionary and collection of services for Holy Week.
- *Gihon* (ግዮን): Ghion; one of the four rivers of Paradise (Genesis 2), traditionally identified by Ethiopians with the Abbay (Blue Nile).
- *Gəzrät* (ግዝረት): Circumcision.
- *Guba'e / Guba'eyat* (ጉባኤ / ጉባዔያት): Council, assembly / Councils (often referring to Ecumenical Councils).

Ḥ

- *Ḥaddisat* (ሐዲሳት): New Testament books.
- *Ḥarägä Liqawənt* (ሐረገ ሊቃውንት): Lineage/Genealogy of Scholars.
- *Ḥawaryawi Haymanot* (ሐዋርያዊ ሃይማኖት): Apostolic faith.
- *Ḥawaryawi Masarat* (ሐዋርያዊ መሠረት): Apostolic foundations.
- *Haymanotä 'Abäw* (ሃይማኖተ አበው): "Faith of the Fathers"; a vital compendium of patristic writings.
- *Ḥəyaw Təwəfit* (ሕያው ትውፊት): Living tradition.
- *Ḥoḫətä Bərhan* (ኖኅተ ብርሃን): "Portal of Light"; a Marian hymn by Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.

K

- *Karra* (ካራ): "Knife" or "precise/unadulterated"; a term for the strictest Täwaḥədo interpretation, particularly associated with Tigrayan scholarship and Emperor Yohannes IV.
- *Kəbrä Nägäśt* (ክብረ ነገሥት): "The Glory of Kings"; Ethiopia's national epic.
- *Kidan* (ኪዳን): Covenant.
- *Kuš* (ኩሽ): Kush; the biblical name consistently identified with Ethiopia in EOTC tradition.
- *Kʷäkʷəḫa Haymanot* (ኰኵሐ ሃይማኖት): "The Rock of Faith"; title of a major doctrinal work by Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere.

L

- *Liq / Liqawənt* (ሊቅ / ሊቃውንት): Great scholar, Doctor (of the Church) / Scholars.

M

- *Maḥəletä Ṣəge* (ማሕሌተ ጽጌ): "Canticle of the Flower/Rose"; a major cycle of Marian hymns.
- *Mälkəʾ* (መልክዕ): "Image," "Portrait," "Form"; a genre of Ethiopian poetry.
- *Mämhər* (መምህር): Teacher, doctor (of the Church).
- *Mänfäsawi Məgəb* (መንፈሳዊ ምግብ): Spiritual nourishment.
- *Mənfəqəna* (ምንፍቅና): Heresy.
- *Mäṣḥafä Bərhan* (መጽሐፈ ብርሃን): "Book of Light"; a major theological work by Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob.
- *Mäṣḥafä Milad* (መጽሐፈ ሚላድ): "Book of Nativity"; a work by Emperor Zärʾa Yaʿəqob.
- *Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir* (መጽሐፈ ምሥጢር): "Book of Mystery"; a major theological work by Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.
- *Mäṣḥafä Säʿatat* (መጽሐፈ ሰዓታት): "Book of Hours"; a liturgical work often associated with Abba Giyorgis.
- *Mäsqäl* (መስቀል): Cross.
- *Mäwasəʾət* (መዋስዕት): One of St. Yared's five books of chant, for funeral services.
- *Məʿraf* (ምዕራፍ): One of St. Yared's five books of chant, for daily prayer and major feasts; also means chapter.
- *Mədlotä Amin* (መድሎተ አሚን): "Balance of Faith"; a theological work by Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere.
- *Məkəra* (መከራ): Trial, tribulation, suffering.
- *Məlkkət / Məlkkətočč* (ምልክት / ምልክቶች): Sign(s); referring to St. Yared's musical notation signs.
- Miaphysite Christology: The Christological teaching, upheld by the EOTC and other Oriental Orthodox Churches, affirming one united divine-human nature (*mia physis*) of the Incarnate Word, Jesus Christ, without confusion, mixture, division, or separation. (See *Täwaḥədo*).
- *Məśṭir* (ምሥጢር): Mystery, sacrament.

N

- *Nəbab* (ንባብ): Reading; the base Gəʿəz text in Andəmta; also the first stage of traditional education (reading school).

- *Näqəᶜ Mäṣaḥəft* (**ነቅዐ መጻሕፍት**): "Source of Books"; title of a work by Dr. Amsalu Tefera.

Q

- *Qal* (**ቃል**): Word; referring to the Logos, the Second Person of the Trinity.
- *Qəbᶜat* (**ቅብዐት**): Unction, anointing; a key term in the Gondarine Christological debates, referring to a school of thought.
- *Qəddase* (**ቅዳሴ**): Divine Liturgy, Eucharist, Anaphora.
- *Qəddus / Qəddusan* (**ቅዱስ** / **ቅዱሳን**): Saint, holy / Saints.
- *Qəne* (**ቅኔ**): A highly sophisticated form of Ethiopian liturgical poetry.
- *Qerəllos* (**ቄርሎስ**): Cyril; usually referring to St. Cyril of Alexandria or a collection of his writings translated into Gəᶜəz.
- *Qes Təmhərt Bet* (**ቄስ ትምህርት ቤት**): Traditional Ethiopian Orthodox Church school system.

R

- *Rasəwan Yäčaläčč Betä Krəstiyan* (**ራሷን የቻለች ቤተ ክርስቲያን**): "A Church that Governs Herself"; Autocephalous Church.
- *Rəstä ʾAbäw* (**ርስተ አበው**): Heritage of the Fathers.
- *Rətuᶜa Haymanot* (**ርቱዐ ሃይማኖት**): Orthodox Faith, Correct Faith; also used as an epithet or pen name for orthodox theologians.

S / Ś

- *Saᶜatat* (**ሰዓታት**): "The Hours"; a liturgical work by Abba Giyorgis of Sägla.
- *Sənkəssar* (**ስንክሳር**): Synaxarium; the collection of saints' lives read daily in the Church.
- *Sənodos* (**ሲኖዶስ**): Synod, council; also a collection of Church canons.
- *Śərᶜat* (**ሥርዓት**): Order, rite, rule, tradition, canon.

Ṣ

- *Ṣägga* (**ጸጋ**): Grace; a key term in the Gondarine Christological debates, referring to a school of thought (also *Śost Lədät*).
- *Ṣälotä Haymanot* (**ጸሎተ ሃይማኖት**): "Prayer of Faith"; the Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed. Also the title sometimes given to Emperor Gälawdewos's Confession.
- *Ṣənat* (**ጽናት**): Resilience, steadfastness.

T / Ṭ

- *Tabot* (ታቦት): Replica of the Ark of the Covenant, consecrated and kept in every EOTC altar.
- *Ṭäbbaqi Haymanot* (ጠባቂ ሃይማኖት): Defender of the Faith (an imperial title).
- *Ṭəbäb* (ጥበብ): Wisdom, knowledge, skill, art.
- *Täʾammərä Maryam* (ተአምረ ማርያም): Miracles of Mary; a large collection of stories about the Virgin Mary.
- *Täsʿatu Qəddusan* (ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን): The Nine Saints.
- *Täwaḥədo* (ተዋሕዶ): "Union," "Unity"; the EOTC's core Christological doctrine affirming the one united divine-human nature of Christ. From the Gəʿəz verb *täwaḥadä* (ተዋሐደ - to be united, to become one).
- *Tərgʷame* (ትርጓሜ): Interpretation, commentary, translation.
- *Təwəfit* (ትውፊት): Tradition.
- *Ṭomarä Gälawdewos* (ጦማረ ገላውዴዎስ): "Epistle/Confession of Gälawdewos."

W

- *Wälədəttä ʾAmlak* (ወላዲተ አምላክ): "Mother of God," "God-bearer" (*Theotokos*); the key Orthodox title for the Virgin Mary.
- *Wəgəzät* (ውግዘት): Excommunication, anathema.

Y

- *YäLay Bet* (የላይ ቤት): "Upper House"; one of the two main schools of Andəmta interpretation, often associated with Gojjam and older traditions.
- *YäTačč Bet* (የታች ቤት): "Lower House"; one of the two main schools of Andəmta interpretation, often associated with Gondär and Mämhər Esdros's revisions.

Z

- *Zema* (ዜማ): Sacred chant of the EOTC, primarily attributed to St. Yared.
- *Zämänä Hawaryat* (ዘመነ ሐዋርያት): Apostolic Age.
- *Zämänä Mäsafənt* (ዘመነ መሳፍንት): "Era of the Princes/Judges"; a period of decentralized rule and political fragmentation in Ethiopia.
- *Zena Mäwaʿəl* (ዜና መዋዕል): Chronicle, history of events.
- *Zəkrä Liqawənt* (ዝክረ ሊቃውንት): "Memorial of the Scholars"; title of a work by Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere, and also a general term.
- *Zəmmare* (ዝማሬ): One of St. Yared's five books of chant, sung after Holy Communion.

Appendix I

List of Ethiopian Church Fathers and Theologian-Rulers

This list provides a brief overview of key Ethiopian Church Fathers, theologian-rulers, and influential scholars whose "lives and works" have shaped the Ethiopian Orthodox Täwaḥədo Church. It is organized chronologically by period.

I. Foundations & Aksumite Era (c. 1st/4th – 7th/8th C. CE)

- **Ethiopian Eunuch (ባኮስ - Bacos)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished c. 34 CE
  - **Contribution:** Baptized by Philip the Apostle (Acts 8); traditionally considered the first to bring the Christian message to Ethiopia, the "apostolic seed."
- **St. Frumentius (Abba Sälama, Käśate Bərhan; አባ ሰላማ, ከሣቴ ብርሃን)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished 4th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** First Bishop of Aksum, consecrated by St. Athanasius of Alexandria. Pivotal in the official Christianization of the Aksumite kingdom under King Ezana. Initiated Gəᶜəz translations of Scripture and liturgical texts. Revered as "Father of Peace" and "Revealer of Light." His "work" established the episcopal structure of the Church.
- **King Ezana (ኢዛና)**
  - **Dates:** Reigned 4th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Aksumite king who, under the guidance of St. Frumentius, declared Christianity the state religion. His inscriptions and coinage reflect this conversion, marking a significant imperial "work" in support of the Church.
- **The Nine Saints (Täsᶜatu Qəddusan, ተሰዓቱ ቅዱሳን)**
  - **Dates:** Arrived c. 480 AD; active into 6th Century CE
  - **Figures Include:** Abba Afse (**አባ አፍጼ**), Abba Alef (**አባ አሌፍ**), Abba Aragawi (**አባ አረጋዊ**), Abba Gärima (**አባ ገሪማ**), Abba Guba (**አባ ጉባ**), Abba Liqanos (**አባ ሊቃኖስ**), Abba Ṗänṭelewon (**አባ ጰንጠሌዎን**), Abba Sehma (**አባ ስሕማ**), Abba Yəmat'a (**አባ ይምአታ**).

- **Contribution:** Monastic Fathers who revitalized and established monasticism across Ethiopia. Their collective "work" significantly advanced the Gəʿəz translation of Scriptures and other crucial patristic and ascetic texts (e.g., *Qərəllos*, *Life of St. Anthony*). They consolidated Miaphysite (*Täwaḥədo*) theology through their teaching and translation "works." Traditionally linked to the ancient Garima Gospels.

- **Saint Yared (Qəddus Yared, ቅዱስ ያሬድ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished 6th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Divinely inspired originator and systematizer of Ethiopian liturgical chant (*Zema*, ዜማ). His monumental "work" includes the authorship of the foundational books of chant (*Dəggʷa*, *Məʿraf*, *Zəmmarɛ*, *Mäwasəʾət*, *Ṣomä Dəggʷa*), the establishment of the three melodic modes (*Gəʿəz*, *ʾƎzəl*, *Araray*), and a system of musical notation (*məlkkətočč*). His hymns are profound liturgical theology.

II. Early Indigenous Voices & Zagwe Era (c. 7th/8th – 1270 CE)

- **Saint Lalibäla (Qəddus Lalibäla, ቅዱስ ላሊበላ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished late 12th – early 13th Century CE (Zagwe Dynasty)
  - **Contribution:** King-saint credited with the vision and creation of the eleven rock-hewn churches in Roha (now Lalibäla). This architectural "work" stands as a profound theological statement in stone, representing a "New Jerusalem" and a unique form of indigenous patristic expression.

III. Early Solomonic Period: Monastic Theologians & Literary Maturation (c. 1270 – c. 1400 CE)

- **Abba Iyäsus Mo'a (አባ ኢየሱስ ሞዐ)**
  - **Dates:** d. c. 1292 CE
  - **Contribution:** Founder of the Däbrä Hayq Istifanos monastery, a major center of higher Christian education and manuscript production. His "work" significantly shaped monastic learning and he was the spiritual father to many subsequent monastic leaders. The office of the *ʾAqabe Säʿat* gained prominence through his influence.

- **Abunä Täklä Haymanot (አቡነ ተክለ ሃይማኖት)**

    - **Dates:** c. 1215 – 1313 CE
    - **Contribution:** One of Ethiopia's most revered saints. Exemplar of ascetic theology and a great evangelist ("New Apostle"). His primary institutional "work" was the founding of the Däbrä Libanos monastery in Shoa, which became the mother-house for a vast monastic network and the seat of the *Ǯčägе*.
- **Abba Ewosṭatewos (አባ ኤዎስጣቴዎስ)**
    - **Dates:** c. 1273 – 1352 CE
    - **Contribution:** Advocated for the observance of both Saturday and Sunday Sabbaths. His "work" and teachings led to the "House of Ewosṭatewos" (*Betä Ewosṭatewos*) monastic movement, sparking a major theological debate that lasted for over a century.
- **Abba Sälama "the Translator" (Sälama Mätərgʷəm, ሰላማ መተርጉም)**
    - **Dates:** Metropolitan c. 1348 – 1388 CE
    - **Contribution:** Immensely influential in the extensive translation "work" of Christian literature from Arabic into Gəᶜəz, including vital texts like the *Haymanotä Abäw* (Faith of the Fathers), *Gädlät* (Hagiographies), and *Filkəsyus* (Philoxenus).
- **Scholar-Father known as Rətuᶜa Haymanot (ርቱዕ ሃይማኖት)**
    - **Dates:** Flourished c. 1375 CE
    - **Contribution:** Compiler of the *Rətuᶜa Haymanot Compendium*, a significant "work" for theological instruction, particularly on the Incarnation.

IV. Climax of Medieval Patristics (15th – Early 16th C. CE)

- **Abba Giyorgis of Sägla/Gasəčča (አባ ጊዮርጊስ ዘሰግላ/ጋሥጫ)**
    - **Dates:** c. 1365 – 1425 CE
    - **Contribution:** Preeminent indigenous theologian of the EOTC. His extensive "works" include the systematic theology *Mäṣḥafä Məśṭir* (Book of Mystery), the profound Marian devotional *Arganonä Maryam* (Harp of Mary), the liturgical *Mäṣḥafä Säᶜatat* (Book of Hours), and the apologetic *Fəkkare Haymanot* (Exposition of Faith).
- **Emperor Zärʾa Yaᶜəqob (አፄ ዘርዐ ያዕቆብ)**
    - **Dates:** Reigned 1434 – 1468 CE

- **Contribution:** Theologian-Emperor who authored and commissioned numerous theological and liturgical "works" aimed at doctrinal standardization and reform. Key writings include *Mäṣḥafä Bərhan* (Book of Light) and *Mäṣḥafä Milad* (Book of Nativity). Convened the Council of Däbrä Məṭmaq (c. 1450).

- **Arkä Śəllus (አርከ ሥሉስ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished 15th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Master of *Qəne* poetry, traditionally credited with the "work" of composing *Arke* hymns for the saints in the *Sənkəssar*.
- **Emperor Naʿod (ዐፄ ናዖድ)**
  - **Dates:** Reigned 1494–1508 CE
  - **Contribution:** Credited with the "work" of composing *Mälkəʾa Maryam* and *Mälkəʾa Mikael*.
- **Emperor Bäʾədä Maryam (ዐፄ በእደ ማርያም)**
  - **Dates:** Reigned 1468–1478 CE
  - **Contribution:** Recognized for the "work" of composing *Mälkəʾa Qurban* and *Mälkəʾa Kidanä Məḥrät*.
- **Emperor Ləbnä Dəngəl (ዐፄ ልብነ ድንግል)**
  - **Dates:** Reigned 1508–1540 CE
  - **Contribution:** His literary "works" include *Mälkəʾa Edom* and Marian praises within the *Mäṣḥafä Säʿatat*.

V. Age of Existential Crisis & Patristic Defense (16th Century)

- **Ǝčč̣äge Ǝnbaqom (እጫጌ ዕንባቆም)**
  - **Dates:** c. 1470 – c. 1560 CE
  - **Contribution:** Convert from Islam who became *Ǝčč̣äge*. Authored the *Anqäṣä Amin* (Gate of Faith), a major apologetic "work" defending Orthodoxy against Islamic polemics. Also a significant translator of "works" like *Bärälam wäYəwasəf*.
- **Emperor Gälawdewos (ኣፄ ገላውዴዎስ)**
  - **Dates:** Reigned 1540 – 1559 CE

- **Contribution:** Theologian-King whose confessional "work," the *Ṭomarä Gälawdewos* (Confession of Gälawdewos), defended Ethiopian Orthodox faith and practices against Jesuit accusations.

- **Abba Baḥrəy (አባ ባሕርይ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished late 16th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Monk, scholar, and chronicler. His "works" include *Zena läGalla* (History of the Oromo Peoples) and the poetic *Mäzmurä Krəstos* (Psalm of Christ).

VI. Gondarine Controversies & Scholarship (Mid-17th – Mid-19th C.)

- **Ǝčč̣äge Beträ Giyorgis (እጬጌ በትረ ጊዮርጊስ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished mid-17th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Leading defender of Täwaḥədo Christology against Jesuit arguments during Emperor Fasilädäs's reign. His primary "work" was his articulate apologetic performance in theological councils.
- **Mämhər Esdros (መምህር ኤስድሮስ)**
  - **Dates:** Flourished 18th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Celebrated *ʾArat ʿAyna* ("Four-Eyed") scholar. His most significant "work" was the critical revision and systematization of the *Anḍəmta* commentary tradition, leading to the *Yä-Lay Bet* and *Yä-Tačč Bet* distinctions.

VII. Imperial Unification, Patristic Standardization, & Autocephaly Journey (Late 19th – Mid-20th C.)

- **Mämhər Akalä Wäld (መምህር አካለ ወልድ)**
  - **Dates:** ca. mid-19th – early 20th Century CE
  - **Contribution:** Renowned traditional scholar. His key teaching "work" at the Council of Boru Meda (1878) was instrumental in affirming the Täwaḥədo/Karra doctrine. Known as "the apostle of Wällo."
- **Aläqa Kidanäwäld Kəfle (አለቃ ኪዳነ ወልድ ክፍሌ)**
  - **Dates:** ca. 1869/72 – 1944 CE
  - **Contribution:** Monumental scholar. His most famous "work" is the comprehensive Gəʿəz-Amharic dictionary, *Mäṣḥafä Säwasəw wägəss wämäzgäbä Qalat Ḥaddis*. Also worked on biblical commentaries.

- Emperor Haile Selassie I (**ቀዳማዊ ኃይለ ሥላሴ**)
    - **Dates:** Reigned 1930 – 1974 CE
    - **Contribution:** His imperial "works" included strong support for church reform, publication of religious texts (including the Amharic Bible), and the crucial diplomatic efforts leading to the EOTC's autocephaly.
- Abunä Peṭros (**አቡነ ጴጥሮስ**)
    - **Dates:** Martyred July 1936 CE
    - **Contribution:** Bishop of Wollo whose martyrdom by Italian Fascists became an enduring "work" of patriotic and Orthodox witness.
- Abunä Basilios (**አቡነ ባስልዮስ**)
    - **Dates:** First Patriarch 1959 – 1970 CE
    - **Contribution:** The first Ethiopian-born Patriarch of the EOTC. His "life and leadership" were foundational for the newly autocephalous Church.

VIII. Contemporary Patristic Engagement (Mid-20th C. – Present)

Aläqa Lämma Haylu (**አለቃ ለማ ኃይሉ**)

- **Dates:** ca. 1868 – 1967 CE
- **Contribution:** Preeminent traditional scholar of the early-to-mid 20th century, master of Gəʿəz, *Zema*, *Qəne*, and *Andəmta*. His memoirs, *Mäshafä Təzzəta zäʾAläqa Lämma*, are a significant "work" preserving traditional knowledge.

- Melake Birhan Admasu Jembere (**መልአከ ብርሃን አድማሱ ጀምበሬ**)
    - **Dates:** ca. 1893 – 2007/08 G.C.
    - **Contribution:** Highly respected "Four-Eyed" traditional scholar. Author of seminal "works" like *Kʷäkʷəḥa Haymanot* (The Rock of Faith) and *Mədlotä Amin* (Balance of Faith), which are key modern compendiums of EOTC doctrine. Also compiled *Zəkrä Liqawənt* (Memorial of the Scholars).
- Aläqa Ayalew Tamiru (**አለቃ አያሌው ታምሩ**)
    - **Dates:** d. 2007 G.C.
    - **Contribution:** Profound scholar despite visual impairment. Authored *Yäʾ Ityoppəya ʾƎmmənät BäSostu Həggəgat* (The Faith of Ethiopia in the Three Laws/Dispensations). Served as head of the Liqawənt Council for many years, a significant "work" in defending and articulating Orthodox tradition.

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